# Collins COBUILD English Grammar, 4the edition (2017)

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## 0.1 About COBUILD

When the 1st COBUILD dictionary was published in 1987, it revolutionized dictionaries for learners.

It was the 1st of the new generation of language reference materials that were based on actual evidence of how English was used, rather than lexicographer intuition.

Collins and the University of Birmingham, led by the linguist John Sinclair, developed an electronic corpus in 1980s, called the Collins Birmingham University International Language Database (COBUILD).

This corpus, which for several years was known as the Bank of English©, became the largest collection of English data in the world.

COBUILD dictionary editors use the corpus to analyze the way that people really use the language.

The Collins Corpus now contains 4.5 billion words taken from websites, newspapers, magazines and books published around the world, and from spoken material from radio, TV and everyday conversations.

New data is added to the corpus every month, to help COBUILD editors identify new words, grammatical structures, and meanings from the moment they are 1st used.

All COBUILD language reference books are based on the information their editors find the Collins Corpus.

Because the corpus is so large, their editors can look at lots of examples of how people really use the language.

The data tells them how the language is used; the function of different structures; which words are used together; and how often these words and structures are used.

All of the examples in COBUILD language materials are examples of real English, taken from the corpus.

The examples have been carefully chosen to demonstrate typical grammatical patterns, typically vocabulary and typical contexts.

COBUILD English Grammar is no exception: Collins editors and researchers have been able to use this wealthy of information to establish a unique and full description of English grammar, and to track the development of certain grammatical structures over time.

The corpus lies at the heart of COBUILD, and you can be confident that COBUILD will show you what you need to know to be able to communicate easily and accurately in English.

To learn more about COBUILD and the Collins Corpus, go to `www.collinselt.com` and click on 'COBUILD Reference'.

## 0.2 Introduction

This grammar is suitable for anyone who is interested in the English language and how it works in everyday current contexts.

It has been written mainly for advanced-level students and their teachers, but any serious learner will find it a valuable reference tool.

The information in this book is taken from a long and careful study of present-day English involving the analysis of the Collins Corpus - a corpus of many millions of words of speech and writing.

### 0.2.1 A functional approach

Most people who study and use a language are interested in how they can *do things* with the language - how they can make meanings, get attention, influence people, and learn about the world.

They are interested in the grammatical structure of the language as a way of getting things done.

A grammar that puts together the patterns of the language and the things you can do with them is called a *functional grammar*.

This is a functional grammar; that is to say, it is based on the important relation between structure and function.

Each chapter is built around a major function of language, e.g. *describing people and things*, and *reporting what someone said*.

Each of these functions is regularly expressed in English by particular structures.

E.g., describing people and things is usually expressed by adjectives, and reporting what people say or think typically involves a reporting verb e.g. *say*, followed by a clause beginning with *that* or a clause with quotation marks (' ') around it.

This grammar follows up each major statement (often called a *rule* in other grammars) with a detailed description of the uses surrounding it - including any exceptions.

The scope of the original function may then be extended.

E.g., the basic, central function of reporting verbs (Chap. 7) is to state what someone has said.

**Example 0.2.1.** *He said he would be back soon.*

It can be easily be extended to include what someone has written.

**Example 0.2.2.** *His mother wrote that he had finally arrived home.*

Then it can be widened to include thoughts and feelings; these do not need to be expressed in words, but the reporting structure is very convenient.

**Example 0.2.3.** *The boys thought he was dead.*

From this we can see the reporting clause as a more general way of introducing another clause.

### Examples

All the examples in this book are taken from the Collins Corpus.

As ever, the corpus lies at the heart of each grammar point described, helping compilers to make confident and accurate decisions about different structures and usage.

Examples themselves remain close to the corpus, with minor changes made so that they are more accessible to the learner.

They are carefully chosen so as to illustrate typical patterns and collocations in real-life situations.

## 0.2.2 Groups of words that behave in the same way

As well as providing a wealth of illustrative examples, this book gives further information about the grammar of a large number of specific words.

The actual words and phrases that are regularly used in each structure are given in a series of lists.

In this way, the learner can get a good idea of how large or small a grammatical class is, and how many words a certain rule applies to.

Wherever there is good reason to do so, the words and phrases are grouped together in a list in a meaningful arrangement.

So, e.g., at [1.21], separate groups are set in a single list, including animals, fish, words ending in *-craft*, and foreign words ending in *-s*.

These all share the same feature, i.e. that they can be either singular or plural nouns without any change in form - *moose, salmon, aircraft, corps*.

From a purely grammatical point of view, they could all go in a single alphabetical list; however from a teaching and learning point of view, it is helpful to have them further classified according to their meaning.

## 0.2.3 'Be creative'

Certain areas of English grammar are very flexible and *productive*.

Some are well known, e.g. the fact that almost any noun in English can modify another noun.

E.g., the noun *steam* can be used in, among others, the following combinations: *steam bath, steam room, steam engine, steam iron, steam power*, and *steam train*.

With this in mind, several 'Be creative' features are included to encourage learners to use their imagination, and to be more confident about expressing themselves.

In such cases, rather than giving a definite rule, the authors prefer to give guidance so that the user can make individual choices with no serious risk of error.

By describing the language in this way, give plenty of scope for creativity and innovation.

## 0.2.4 Accessibility

When using a grammar, it can be difficult to find the information that you want.

This is often the biggest single problem for users of grammars, and a good reason why grammars are often unpopular with learners.

This grammar makes a special effort to support the user.

The authors have aimed to use the most up-to-date and commonly used grammatical terminology throughout.

Technical terms have been used only where there is no obvious alternative.

A glossary of terms is provided and they are also all listed in the index.

There is a contents list at the beginning of the book, and there is an individual contents list at the beginning of each chapter.

Using these of the index, the user will be able to find the section or paragraph where a function is associated with a structure.

Throughout the book there are paragraph headings that show the topic of almost every paragraph, and there are frequent additional headings for each section of a chapter.

At the top of each page, there is another heading to guide the user.

### 0.2.5 New developments in language

The continued development of the corpus enables us to keep us with the ever-changing nature of language.

At COBUILD, the authorscontinually track and research the development of grammatical features, e.g.:

(i) the use of the progressive with so-called stative verbs (e.g. *I'm loving every minute of it*)

(ii) the use of *much* in affirmative unmodified statements (e.g. *There was much debate*)

(iii) the spread of generic pronouns (e.g. *You get some people who are very difficult*)

(iv) the use of *like* in reporting structures (e.g. *And I was like, 'wow!'*)

(v) the use of all-purpose question tags in some varieties of spoken informal English (e.g. *innit*)

The results are often fascinating and surprising, and enable us to ensure that each new edition of the Grammar gives you a clear portrayal of real English as it is written and spoken today.

### 0.2.6 The grammar of business & academic English

An extension of our functional approach has been to focus on 2 main contexts in which English is used as a lingua franca throughout the world - business and academic English.

As a result, 2 supplementary sections identify the principal areas of grammar that learners need to master if they wish to communicate effectively in business and academic contexts.

The section on the grammar of business English looks at typical structures used in such contexts as sharing information, negotiating, and giving presentations.

The academic English section covers such areas as explaining results, reviewing research, and reporting findings.

Extensive cross-referencing allows the user to refer back to the main text, where structures are discussed in greater detail.

The authors hope that you will enjoy learning about English grammar from a functional perspective - from exploring the wealth of real-world examples of current language, to understanding how certain structures work in business and academic contexts.

The authors hope, too, that as a result, you will gain the confidence to use English creatively and effectively in a wide range of everyday situations.

### 0.2.7 Getting the most out of COBUILD English Grammar

Would you like to discover more about the wealth of information COBUILD English Grammar has to offer, and explore the subject of grammar further?

If so, go to `www.collinselt.com/cobuildenglishgrammar`, where you will find a range of blogposts, written by experts in the field, that encourage focused thinking and discussion with your peers on a variety of topics, e.g.:

- questioning traditionally accepted grammar 'rules'
- establishing the difference between nonstandard usage and errors
- thinking about why some people avoid using the word 'tense' to talk about perfect and progressive forms.

To help you examine each topic in turn in greater detail, each blogpost has a link to a corresponding worksheet.

## 0.3 How to use this Grammar

The COBUILD English Grammar is designed to be used both for quick reference and for in-depth study.

### 0.3.1 Organization of the main text

The main text of the Grammar is divided into 10 chapters.

The 1st 2 chapters deal with the noun phrase, Chaps. 3–5 with the verb phrase.

Chap. 6 deals with adverbs and prepositions, Chap. 7 with reporting, Chap. 8 with joining words, phrases and clauses, and Chaps. 9–10 with continuous text.

Each chapter consists of a series of main topics and each topic is divided into sections.

Paragraphs in the chapter are numbered, so that Chap. 1 runs from **1.1** to **1.251**, Chap. 2 from **2.1** to **2.302** and so on.

This numbering system makes it easy for the user to refer to different but related points.

There are cross-references throughout the text, either pointing to the main place where a topic is dealt with or to another paragraph where more information is given.

Most paragraphs also have a heading, saying in a few words what it deals with, especially which grammatical structure is being explained.

Some paragraph headings do not show specifically what the paragraph deals with, but indicate information of a different kind.

These paragraphs have the headings 'Be careful,' 'Be Creative', and 'Usage Note'.

**[!]** 'Be Careful' highlights points where people often have problems with a particular grammatical feature of English, e.g. because it is a feature where English is different from many other languages.

[⋆] 'Be Creative' indicates that the rule that has been mentioned can be applied in English to a very large number of words.

E.g., it is nearly always possible to make the *-ing* participle of a verb into an adjective that is used in front of a noun.

By taking note of these features, you can use the rules that have been presented in a creative and original way, giving you greater freedom to express yourself in English.

'Be Creative' features are explained in greater detail in the Introduction.

**[i]** 'Usage Note' gives information about the use of individual words or small groups of words.

This information is important but cannot be generalized into a grammatical rule.

The Usage Notes help you to understand points that are important for the understanding of particular words, rather than points that relate to large numbers of words.

The U.S. flag symbol highlights paragraphs containing information about typical American English usage.

The speech bubble symbol identifies paragraphs describing structures that are most commonly found in spoken English.

Most of the grammatical explanations are followed by examples showing how the structure is used.

These examples are all taken from the Collins Corpus, and show how the structures are used naturally in speech or writing.

The examples therefore give important information about typical use of a structure, the words it is frequently used with, and the contexts in which it is likely to occur.

Throughout the book, grammatical explanations are followed by lists of the words that typically illustrate that grammatical point.

E.g., in Chap. 3, the point is made that many verbs can be either transitive or intransitive with the same meaning.

This is followed by a list of verbs that are frequently used in this way.

The lists go beyond the actual examples of use that are given, to other words that behave in similar ways.

They show whether the point being made can be applied to a small number or a large number of words.

If the group is small, all members of it are given.

If the group is large, then the most frequently used words are given.

These lists can be used to help you increase your vocabulary and to check that you are using newly learned English words correctly.

### 0.3.2 Additional contents

In addition to the main text, various other sections are included to help you to get the most out of this Grammar.

These additional sections are described below.

#### 0.3.2.1 Glossary of grammatical terms

The Glossary explains the meaning of grammatical terms.

It covers the terms that are used in this grammar, and also includes terms that are used in other grammars, with a cross-reference to the term used in this book, where appropriate.

E.g., this grammar talks about the *present progressive*, whereas some other grammars call it the *present continuous*.

Both of these terms are mentioned in the Glossary, with the explanation being given at *present progressive*.

#### 0.3.2.2 Reference section

This section at the back of the book provides an easy-to-use reference guide that shows how the following groups of words are formed:

- plurals of nouns
- the comparative and superlative of adjectives
- '-ly' adverbs formed from adjectives
- the comparative and superlative of adverbs
- tenses
- other verb forms
- passives
- principal parts of irregular verbs

The Reference section also includes other topics.

E.g., it starts with a pronunciation guide, to remind you of the sounds of English.

There are also lists of numbers, and an explanation of how numbers are expressed aloud.

#### 0.3.2.3 The grammar of business & academic English

These sections provide key guidance in the principal areas of grammar that learners need to master for effective communication in business and academic contexts.

#### 0.3.2.4 Index

The Index is a comprehensive list of everything dealt with in the Grammar.

It covers:

- the grammatical and functional topics dealt with in the Grammar;
- individual words which are used as examples of a particular grammatical point;
- grammatical terms, both those used in this book and those commonly used in other books.

## 0.4 Glossary of grammatical terms

1. **abstract noun**: a noun used to describe a quality, idea, or experience rather than something physical or concrete; e.g., *joy, size, language.*

   Cf. **concrete noun**.

2. **active**: used for describing verb phrases e.g. *gives*, and *has made*, where the subject is the person or thing doing the action or responsible for the action.

   Cf. **passive**.

3. **adjectival clause**: another name for **relative clause**.

4. **adjective**: a word used to tell yu more about a thing, e.g. its appearance, color, size, or other qualities; e.g., ... *a pretty blue dress.*

5. **adverb**: a word that gives more information about when, how, where, or in what circumstances something happens; e.g. *quickly, now.*

   There are several different kinds of adverb; adverbs of degree, manner, place, time, duration, and frequency.

   There are also **focusing adverbs**.

6. **adverbial**: a word or combination of words added to a clause to give more information about time, place, or manner.

   See also **sentence adverbial** and **sentence connector**.

7. **adverb of degree**: an adverb indicating the amount or extent of a feeling or quality; e.g. *extremely.*
8. **adverb/adverbial of duration**: an adverb or adverbial indicating how long something lasts; e.g. *briefly, for a long time.*
9. **adverb/adverbial of frequency**: an adverb or adverbial indicating how often something happens; e.g. *often, once a week.*
10. **adverb of manner**: an adverb indicating the way in which something happens or is done; e.g. *carefully.*
11. **adverb of place**: an adverb that gives more information about position or direction; e.g. *Move closer.*
12. **adverb particle**: an adverb used as part of a phrasal verb; e.g. *hide out, sit up, turn round.*
13. **affirmative**: not containing a negative word.

    Also called **positive**.
14. **agent**: another name for **performer**.
15. **agreement**: the relationship between a subject and its verb, or between a number or determiner and its noun; e.g. *I look/she looks... 1 bell/3 bells.*

    Also called **concord**.
16. **apostrophe s**: an ending ('s) added to a noun to mark possession; e.g. *... Harriet's daughter... the professor's husband... the Managing Director's secretary.*
17. **article**: see **definite article**, **indefinite article**.
18. **aspect**: the use of verb forms to show whether an action is continuing, repeated, or finished.
19. **attributive**: used for describing the position of adjectives when they are used in front of a noun.

    Cf. **predicative**.
20. **auxiliary verb**: 1 of the verbs *be, have*, and *do* when they are used with a main verb to make verb forms, negatives, questions, and so on.

    Also called **auxiliary**.

    **Modals** are also auxiliary verbs.
21. **bare infinitive**: another name for **infinitive without to**.
22. **base form**: the form of a verb that has no letters added to the end and is not a past form; e.g. *walk, go, have, be.*

    The base form is the form you look up in a dictionary.
23. **broad negative**: 1 of a small group of adverbs including *barely* and *seldom* which are used to make a statement almost negative; e.g. *I barely knew her.*
24. **cardinal number**: a number used for counting; e.g. *one, seven, nineteen.*
25. **classifying adjective**: an adjective used to identity something as being of particular type; e.g. *Indian, wooden, mental.*

    They do not have comparatives or superlatives.

    Cf. **qualitative adjective**.
26. **clause**: a group of words containing a verb.

    See also **main clause** and **subordinate clause**.
27. **clause of manner**: a subordinate clause that describes the way in which something is done, usually introduced with *as* or *like*; e.g. *She talks like her mother used to.*
28. **collective noun**: a noun that refers to a group of people or things; e.g. *committee, team.*
29. **color adjective**: an adjective referring to a color; e.g. *red, blue, scarlet.*
30. **common noun**: a noun used to refer to a person, thing, or substance; e.g. *sailor, computer, glass.*

    Cf. **proper noun**.

31. **comparative**: an adjective or adverb with *-er* on the end or *more* in front of it; e.g. *friendlier, more important, more carefully.*

32. **complement**: a noun phrase or adjective that comes after a linking verb e.g. *be*, and gives more information about the subject or object of the clause; e.g. *She is a teacher, She is tired, They made her chairperson.*

33. **complex sentence**: a sentence consisting of 2 or more main clauses linked by a subordinating conjunction; e.g. *We went inside when it started to rain.*

34. **compound**: a combination of 2 or more words functioning as a unit.

    E.g., *self-centered* and *free-style* are compound adjectives, *bus stop* and *state of affairs* are compounds nouns, and *dry-clean* and *roller-skate* are compound verbs.

35. **compound sentence**: a sentence consisting of 2 or more main clauses linked by a coordinating conjunction; e.g. *They picked her up and took her into the house.*

36. **concessive clause**: a subordinate clause, usually introduced by *although* or *while*, that contrasts with a main clause; e.g. *Although I like her, I find her hard to talk to.*

37. **concord**: another name for **agreement**.

38. **concrete noun**: a noun that refers to something we can touch or see; e.g. *table, dress, flower.*

    Cf. **abstract noun**.

39. **conditional clause**: a subordinate clause usually starting with *if.*

    The event described in the main clause depends on the condition described in the subordinate clause; e.g. *If it rains, we'll go to the cinema.*

    *They would be rich if they had taken my advice.*

40. **conjunction**: a word linking together 2 clauses, phrases, or words.

    There are 2 types of conjunction - **coordinating conjunctions**, which link parts of a sentence of the same grammatical type (*and, but, or*), and **subordinating conjunctions**, which begin subordinate clauses (*although, when*).

41. **continuous**: another name for **progressive**.

42. **contraction**: a shortened form in which an auxiliary verb and *not*, or a subject and an auxiliary verb, are joined together and functions as 1 word; e.g. *aren't, she's.*

43. **coordinate clause**: a clause that is connected to another clause with a coordinating conjunction e.g. *and or but*; e.g. *He fell and broke his leg.*

44. **coordinating conjunction**: a word e.g. *and, but*, or *or* which joins together 2 clauses, phrases, or words of the same grammatical type.

45. **copula**: a name sometimes used to refer to the verb *be.*

    In this grammar, the term **linking verb** is used.

46. **countable noun**: a noun that can be singular or plural; e.g. *dog/dogs, lemon/lemons, foot/feet.*

    Also called **count noun**.

47. **declarative**: a clause in the declarative form has the subject followed by the verb.

    Most statements are made in the declarative form.

    Also called **indicative**.

48. **defining non-finite clause**: a participle clause that is placed after a noun phrase to identify the person or thing you are talking about; e.g. *The girl wearing the red hat.*

49. **defining relative clause**: a relative clause that identifies the person or thing that is being talked about; e.g. *I wrote down everything that she said.*

50. **definite article**: the determiner '*the*'.

51. **delexical verb**: a verb that has very little meaning in itself and is used with an object that carries the main meaning of the structure.

    *Give, have*, and *take* are commonly used as delexical verbs; e.g. *She gave a small cry.*

    *I've had a bath.*

52. **demonstrative**: 1 of the words *this, that, these*, and *those* used in front of a noun; e.g. ... *this woman... that tree.*

    They are also used as pronouns; e.g. *That looks nice... This is fun.*

53. **dependent clause**: another name for **subordinate clause**.

54. **definite determiner**: 1 of a groups of determiners including *the, that* and *your* which you use when the person you are speaking to understands which person or thing you are talking about; e.g. *the old man, my ideas.*

55. **determiner**: 1 of a group of words including *the, a, some*, and *my* which are used at the beginning of a noun phrase.

56. **direct object**: a noun phrase referring to a person or thing affected by an action, in a sentence with an active verb; e.g. *She wrote her name... I shut the windows.*

57. **direct speech**: speech reported in the words actually spoken by someone, without any changes in tense, person, and so on.

58. **ditransitive verb**: a verb e.g. *give, take*, or *sell* which can have both an indirect and a direct object; e.g. *She gave me a kiss.*

59. **dynamic verb**: a verb e.g. *run, give* or *slice* which describes an action.

    Cf. **stative verb**.

60. ***-ed* adjective**: an adjective that ends in *-ed*, and usually has the same form as the *-ed* participle of a verb, or is formed by adding *-ed* to a noun; e.g. *a worried look... skilled workers.*

    Adjectives that do not end in *-ed* but have the same forms as irregular *-ed* participles are also called *-ed* adjectives; e.g. a *broken* bone.

61. ***-ed* particle**: a verb form e.g. *walked* or *played*, which is used to make perfect forms and passives, or in some cases an adjective.

    Irregular participles e.g. *given* and *broken* are also called *-ed* participles because they behave like regular *-ed* participles.

    Also called **past participle**.

62. **ellipsis**: when you leave out words because they are obvious from the context.

63. **emphasizing adjective**: an adjective e.g. *complete, utter* or *total* which stresses how strongly you feel about something; e.g. *I feel a complete fool.*

64. **ergative verb**: a verb that can be either transitive or intransitive in the same meaning.

    To use the verb intransitively, you use the object of the transitive verb as the subject of the intransitive verb; e.g. *He had boiled a kettle... The kettle had boiled.*

65. **exclamation**: a word or sentence spoken suddenly and loudly in order to express surprise, anger, and so on; e.g. *Oh gosh!*

66. **finite**: a finite verb is inflected according to person or tense rather than being an infinitive or a participle.

67. **first person**: see **person**.

68. **focusing adverb**: a sentence adverb that indicates the most relevant thing involved; e.g. *only, mainly, especially.*

69. **future**: the use of *will* or *shall* with the base form of the verb to refer to future events; e.g. *She will come tomorrow.*

70. **future progressive**: the use of *will be* or *shall be* and an *-ing* participle to refer to future events; e.g. *She will be going soon.*

    Also called **future continuous**.

71. **future perfect**: the use of *will have* or *shall have* and an *-ed* participle to refer to future events; e.g. *I shall have finished tomorrow.*

72. **future perfect progressive**: the use of *will* or *shall* with *have been* and an *-ing* participle to refer to future events; e.g. *I will have been walking for 3 hours by then.*

    Also called **future perfect continuous**.

73. **gender**: a grammatical term referring to the difference between masculine and feminine words e.g. *he* and *she*.

74. **generic pronoun**: 1 of a group of pronouns including *you* and *they* which are used to refer to people in general.

75. **gerund**: another name for ***-ing* noun**.

76. **gradable**: a gradable adjective can be used with a word e.g. *very* to say that the person or thing referred to has more or less of a quantity; e.g. *very boring, less helpful.*

77. **idiom**: a group of 2 or more words with a meaning that cannot be understood by taking the meaning of each individual word; e.g. *to kick the bucket, to run wild.*

78. ***if*-clause**: a **conditional clause**; or a clause used to report a *yes/no*-question.

79. **imperative**: a clause in the imperative has the base form of the verb without a subject, e.g. *Come here... Take 2 tablets every 4 hours... Enjoy yourself.*

80. **impersonal**: ***it*** is an impersonal subject when it is used to introduce a fact, or when it is used in a split sentence; e.g. *It's raining... It was you who asked.*

81. **indefinite article**: the determiners *a* and *an*.

82. **indefinite determiner**: 1 of a group of determiners including *a, many* and *several* which you use to refer to someone or something of a particular type, without saying which person or thing you mean; e.g. *an old man, several suggestions.*

83. **indefinite place adverb**: 1 of a group of adverbs including *anywhere* and *somewhere* which are used to indicate position or location in a general or vague way.

84. **indefinite pronoun**: 1 of a group of pronouns including *someone* and *anything* which are used to refer to a person or thing in a generaly way.

85. **indicative**: another name for **declarative**.

86. **indirect object**: a 2nd object used with a transitive verb to indicate who or what benefits from an action, or gets something as a result of it; e.g. *She gave me a rose.*

87. **indirect question**: a way of asking a question that makes it sound more polite; e.g. *Can you tell me where the bank is?* instead of *Where is the bank?*

88. **indirect speech**: another name for **reported speech**.

89. **infinitive**: the base form of a verb.

    It is often used with *to* in front of it; e.g. *(to) take, (to) see, (to) bring.*

90. **infinitive without to**: the infinitive form without *to* in front of it, used with modals and certain other verbs; e.g. *You must go... Let me think.*

91. **inflection**: the variation in the form of a word to show differences in tense, number, case, and degree.

92. ***-ing* adjective**: an adjective that has the same form as the *-ing* participle of a verb; e.g. ... *a smiling face... a winning streak.*

93. ***-ing* participle**: a verb form ending in *-ing* that is used to make verb forms, and as an adjective.

    Also called the **present participle**.

94. ***-ing* noun**: a noun that has the same form as the *-ing* participle of a verb; e.g. *Swimming is good for you.*

95. **interjection**: another name for **exclamation**.

96. **interrogative adverb**: 1 of the adverbs *how, when, where*, and *why* when they are used to ask questions.

97. **interrogative**: a clause in the interrogative form has part or all of the verb phrase in front of the subject.

    Most questions are asked in the interrogative form.

98. **interrogative pronoun**: 1 of the pronouns *who, whose, whom, what*, and *which* when they are used to ask questions.

99. **intransitive verb**: a verb that is used to talk about an action or event that only involves the subject and so does not have an object; e.g. *She arrived... I was yawning.*

100. **inversion**: changing the word order in a sentence, especially changing the order of the subject and the verb.

101. **irregular**: not following the normal rules for inflection.

    An irregular verb has a past form and/or *-ed* participle that is formed in a different way from the regular ending.

102. **lexical verb**: another name for **main verb**.

103. **linking verb**: a verb that links the subject and complement of a clause; e.g. *be, become, seem, appear.*

    Also sometimes called **copula**.

104. **main clause**: a clause that is not dependent on, or is not part of, another clause.

105. **main verb**: any verb that is not an auxiliary verb.

    Also called **lexical verb**.

106. **mass noun**: (in this grammar) a noun that is usually an uncountable noun, but that can be used as a countable noun when it refers to quantities or types of something; e.g. *... 2 sugars... cough medicines.*

107. **measurement noun**: a noun that refers to a unit of size, volume, weight, speed, temperature, etc.: e.g. *mile, liter, degree.*

108. **modal**: an auxiliary verb that is used with a main verb to indicate a particular attitude, e.g. possibility, obligation, prediction, or deduction; e.g. *can, could, may, might.*

    Also called *modal auxiliary* or *modal verb.*

109. **modifier**: a word or group of words that come in front of a noun; e.g. *... a beautiful sunny day... a psychology conference.*

110. **negative**: used for describing a sentence that uses a word like *not, never*, or *no one* to indicate the absence or opposite of something, or to say that something is not the case; e.g. *I don't know you... I'll never forget.*

    The opposite is **affirmative**.

111. **negative word**: a word e.g. *never* and *not* which expresses a negative meaning.

112. **nominal relative clause**: a subordinate clause that functions as a noun and often begins with *what* or *whatever*; e.g. *What he said was true.*

113. **nominal *that*-clause**: a subordinate clause that functions as a noun and begins with *that*; e.g. *He showed that it was true.*

114. **non-defining relative clause**: a relative clause that gives more information about someone or something, but that is not needed to identify them; e.g. *That's Mary, who was at university with me.*

    Cf. **defining relative clause**.

115. **non-finite**: the non-finite forms of a verb are the infinitive and participle forms; e.g. *to take, taking, taken.*

116. **noun**: a word that refers to people, things, and abstract ideas e.g. feelings and qualities; e.g. *woman, Harry, guilt.*

117. **noun phrase**: a group of words that acts as the subject, complement, or object of a clause, or as the object of a preposition.

118. **noun modifier**: a noun used in front of another noun, as if it were an adjective; e.g. *... a car door... a steel works.*

119. **number**: the way in which differences between singular and plural are shown; e.g. *flower/flowers, that/those.*

    See also **cardinal number** and **ordinal number**.

120. **object**: a noun phrase that refers to a person or thing, other than the subject, which is involved in or affected by the action of a verb.

    See also **direct object** and **indirect object**.

    Prepositions are also followed by objects.

121. **object complement**: a word that is used to describe the object of a clause and that occurs with verbs e.g. *make* and *find*; e.g. *It made me tired... I found her asleep.*

122. **ordinal number**: a number that is used to indicate where something comes in an order or sequence; e.g. *1st, 5th, 10th, 100th.*

123. **participle**: a verb form used for making different tenses.

    See ***-ed* participle** and ***-ing* participle** for more details.

124. **partitive**: a word that gives information about the amount of a particular thing; e.g. *pint, loaf, portion.*

125. **passive**: verb forms e.g. *was given, were taken, had been made*, where the subject is the person or thing that is affected by the action.

    Cf. **active**.

126. **past form**: the form of a verb, often ending in *-ed*, that is used for the past simple.

127. **past participle**: another name for ***-ed* participle**.

128. **past perfect**: the use of *had* with an *-ed* participle to refer to past events; e.g. *She had finished.*

129. **past perfect progressive**: the use of *had been* with an *-ing* participle to refer to past events; e.g. *He had been waiting for hours.*

    Also called **past perfect continuous**.

130. **past progressive**: the use of *was* or *were* with an *-ing* participle, usually to refer to past events; e.g. *They were worrying about it yesterday.*

    Also called **past continuous**.

131. **past simple**: the use of the past form of a verb to refer to past events; e.g. *They waited... It fell over.*

132. **past tense**: a tense used to describe actions or events that took place in the past.

    See **tense** for more details.

133. **perfect form**: a verb form with *have* and an *-ed* participle; e.g. *I have met him... We had won.*

134. **performative verb**: a verb that states explicitly what action the speaker is performing when he or she uses it; e.g. *apologize, resign, christen.*

135. **performer**: the person or thing that is responsible for the action expressed by the verb; e.g. *Mark phoned... Our dinner was eaten by the dog.*

136. **person**: a term used to refer to the 3 classes of people who are involved in something that is said.

    They are the 1st person (the person speaking or writing), the 2nd person (the person being addressed), and the 3rd person (the person or things that are being talked about).

137. **personal pronoun**: 1 of a group of pronouns including *I, you*, and *me* which are used to refer back to the people or things you are talking about.

138. **phrasal verb**: a combination of a verb and an adverb and/or a preposition, which have a single meaning; e.g. *back down, hand over, look after, look forward to.*

139. **phrase**: a set of words that is smaller than a clause, and that is based around a particular word class: e.g., a verb phrase is based around a main verb, and can also contain auxiliary verbs.

    See also **noun phrase, verb phrase** and **prepositional phrase**.

    **Phrase** is also sometimes used to refer to any group of words.

140. **plural**: the form used to refer to more than 1 person or thing; e.g. *dogs, women.*

141. **plural noun**: a noun that is only used in the plural form; e.g. *trousers, scissors, vermin.*

142. **possessive**: a structure used to show possession; e.g. *your, Jerry's, mine.*

143. **possessive determiner**: a determiner e.g. *my, your*, and *their*.

    Also called **possessive adjective**.

144. **possessive pronoun**: 1 of the words *mine, yours, hers, his, ours*, and *theirs*.

145. **postdeterminer**: a small group of adjectives used after a determiner and in front of other adjectives; e.g. *certain, remaining*.

146. **predeterminer**: a word that comes in front of a determiner; e.g. *all the boys... double the trouble... such a mess*.

147. **predicative**: used for describing the position of adjectives when they are used after a linking verb e.g. 'be'.

    Cf. **attributive**.

148. **preposition**: a word e.g. *by, with* or *from*, which is usually followed by a noun phrase or an *-ing* form.

149. **prepositional phrase**: a structure consisting of a preposition and its object; e.g. *on the table, by the sea*.

150. **present participle**: another name for ***-ing* participle**.

151. **present progressive**: the use of the present simple of 'be' with an *-ing* participle to refer to present events; e.g. *Things are improving*.

    Also called **present continuous**.

152. **present perfect**: the use of the present simple of *have* with an *-ed* participle to refer to past events that exist in the present; e.g. *She has loved him for 10 years*.

153. **present perfect progressive**: the use of *have been* and *has been* with an *-ing* participle to refer to past events that exist in the present; e.g. *We have been sitting here for hours*.

    Also called **present perfect continuous**.

154. **present simple**: the use of the base form or the *s* form of a verb, usually to refer to present events; e.g. *I like bananas... My sister hates them*.

155. **present tense**: a tense used to describe events taking place in the present, or situations that exist in the present.

156. **progressive**: a verb form that contains a form of the verb 'be' and an *-ing* participle; e.g. *She was laughing... They had been playing badminton*.

    Also called **continuous**.

157. **pronoun**: a word used instead of a noun, when you do not want to name someone or something directly; e.g. *it, you, none*.

158. **proper noun**: a noun that refers to a particular person, place, or institution; e.g. *Nigel, Edinburgh, Christmas*.

    Cf. **common noun**.

159. **purpose clause**: a subordinate clause, usually introduced by *in order to*, or *so that*;

    e.g. *I came here in order to ask you out to dinner*.

160. **qualifier**: any word, phrase, or clause that comes after a noun phrase, and gives extra information to expand its meaning; e.g. ... *a book with a blue cover* ... *the shop on the corner*.

161. **qualitative adjective**: an adjective that is used to indicate a quality, and is gradable; e.g. *funny, intelligent, small*.

    Cf. **classifying adjective**.

162. **quantity expression**: a phrase ending in *of* that allows you to refer to a quantity of something without being precise about the exact amount; e.g. *some of, a lot of, a little bit of*.

163. **question**: a structure that typically has the verb in front of the subject and that is used to ask someone about something; e.g. *Have you have any money?*

    Also called **interrogative**.

164. **question tag**: a structure or word that is used at the end of a statement in order to form a question.

165. **reason clause**: a subordinate clause, usually introduced by *because, since*, or *as*; e.g. *Since you're here, we'll start*.

166. **reciprocal pronoun**: the pronouns *each other* and *one another*, used to show that 2 or more people do or feel the same thing; e.g. *They loved each other*.

167. **reciprocal verb**: a verb that describes an action that involves people affecting each other in the same way with the same action; e.g. *They met in the street... He met her yesterday.*

168. **reflexive pronoun**: a pronoun ending in *-self*, e.g. *myself* or *themselves*, which is used as the object of a verb when the person affected by an action is the same as the person doing it.

169. **reflexive verb**: a verb that is typically used with a reflexive pronoun; e.g. *enjoy yourself; pride yourself on.*

170. **reflexive clause**: a subordinate clause that gives more information about someone or something mentioned in the main clause.

    See also **defining relative clause** and **non-defining relative clause**.

171. **relative pronoun**: a *wh*-word e.g. *who* or *which*, used to introduce a relative clause; e.g. *... the girl who was carrying the bag.*

172. **reported clause**: the part of a reporting structure that describes what someone has said; e.g. *She said that I couldn't see her*.

173. **reported question**: a question that is reported using a reporting structure rather than the exact words used by the speaker.

174. **reported speech**: speech that is reported using a reporting structure rather than the exact words used by the speaker.

    Also called **indirect speech**.

175. **reporting clause**: a clause that contains a reporting verb, which is used to introduce what someone has said; e.g. *They asked if I could come.*

176. **reporting verb**: a verb that describes what people say or think; e.g. *suggest, say, wonder.*

177. **reporting structure**: a structure that reports what someone has said by using a reported clause rather than repeating their exact words; e.g. *She told me she'd be late.*

178. **result clause**: a subordinate clause introduced by *so that* which gives the result of something; e.g. *The house was severely damaged, so that it is now uninhabitable*.

179. **rhetorical question**: a question that you use in order to make a comment rather than to obtain information; e.g. *Oh, isn't it silly?*

180. **second person**: see **person**.

181. **semi-modal**: the verbs *dare, need*, and *used to* which behave rather like modals.

182. **sentence**: a group of words that express a statement, question, or command.

    A sentence usually has a verb and a subject, and may consist of 1 clause, or 2 or more clauses.

    A sentence in writing has a capital letter at the beginning and a full-stop, question mark, or exclamation mark at the end.

183. **sentence adverbial**: an adverbial that applies to the whole clause, rather than to part of it; e.g. *We possibly have to wait and see.*

    See also **sentence connector**.

184. **sentence connector**: a sentence adverbial used to introduce a comment or reinforce what is said; e.g. *moreover, besides.*

185. ***s* form**: the base form of a verb with *s* on the end, used in the present simple.

186. **simple sentence**: a sentence that contains only 1 clause.

187. **singular**: the form used to refer to or talk about 1 person or thing; e.g. *dog, woman.*

    Cf. **plural**.

188. **singular noun**: a noun typically used in the singular form; e.g. *sun, business.*

189. **split infinitive**: the placing of a word between *to* and the base form of a verb; e.g. *... to boldly go where no man has gone before.*

190. **split sentence**: a sentence in which emphasis is given to either the subject or the object by using a structure beginning with *it, what*, or *all*; e.g. *It's a hammer we need... What we need is a hammer.*

191. **stative verb**: a verb that describes a state ; e.g. *be, live, know.*

     Cf. **dynamic verb**.

192. **subject**: a noun phrase that usually comes before a verb, and agrees with the verb in person and number.

     In active sentences, the subject usually refers to the person or thing who dose the action expressed by the verb; e.g. *We were going shopping.*

193. **subjunctive**: a verb form that is used in some languages to express attitudes e.g. wishing, hoping, and doubting.

     The subjunctive is not very common in English, and is used mainly in conditional clauses e.g. *If I were you...*

194. **submodifying adverb**: an adverb that is used in front of an adjective or another adverb in order to strengthen or weaken its meaning; e.g. *... very interesting... quite quickly.*

195. **subordinate clause**: a clause that begins with a subordinating conjunction e.g. *because* or *while* and which must be used with a main clause.

196. **subordinating conjunction**: a conjunction that begins a subordinate clause.

197. **substitution**: the special use of pronouns and other words to replace part or all of a clause; e.g. *'Are you going to the party?' – 'I hope so'.*

198. **superlative**: an adjective or adverb with *-est* on the end or *most* in front of it; e.g. *thinnest, quickest, most wisely.*

199. **tense**: the verb form that shows whether you are referring to the past or the present.

200. ***that*-clause**: a clause starting with '*that*' which is used mainly when reporting what someone has said; e.g. *She said that she'd wash up for me.*

     *That* can be omitted when the clause is used after a reporting verb.

201. **third person**: see **person**.

202. **time adverbial**: an adverbial that gives more information about when something happens; e.g. *I saw her yesterday.*

203. **time clause**: a subordinate clause that indicates the time of an event; e.g. *I'll phone you when I get back.*

204. **title**: a word used before a person's name to show their position or status; e.g. *Mrs, Lord, Queen.*

205. ***to*-infinitive**: the base form of a verb preceded by *to*; e.g. *to go, to have, to jump.*

206. **transitive verb**: a verb used to talk about an action or event that involves more than 1 person or thing, and so is followed by an object; e.g. *She's wasting her money.*

207. **uncountable noun**: a noun that refers to a general kind of thing rather than to an individual item, and so has only 1 form; e.g. *money, furniture, intelligence.*

     Also called **uncount noun**.

208. **verb**: a word used with a subject to say what someone or something does, or what happens to them; e.g. *sing, spill, die.*

209. **verb phrase**: a main verb, or a main verb preceded by 1 or more auxiliary verbs, which combines with a subject to say what someone or something does, or what happens to them; e.g. *I'll show them... She's been sick.*

210. **vocative**: a word used when speaking to someone, just as if it were their name; e.g. *darling, madam.*

211. ***wh*-clause**: a clause starting with a *wh*-word.

212. ***whether*-clause**: a clause used to report a *yes/no*-question; e.g. *I asked her whether she'd seen him.*

213. ***wh*-question**: a question that expects an answer giving a particular person, place, thing, amount, and so on, rather than just *yes* or *no*.

214. ***wh*-word**: 1 of a group of words starting with *wh*-, e.g. *what, when* or *who*, which are used in *wh*-questions. *How* is also called a *wh*-word because it behaves like the other *wh*-words.

215. ***yes/no*-question**: a question that can be answered simply with either *yes* or *no*; e.g. *Would you like some more tea?*

# Chapter 1

# Referring to people & things: nouns, pronouns, & determiners

## 1.1 Introduction to the noun phrase

1.1 At its simplest, language is used to talk about people and things.

People do this by using words in a variety of ways, e.g. to make statements, to ask questions, and to give orders.

The words chosen are arranged into groups, either around a noun or around a verb.

They are called **noun phrases** and **verb phrases**.

**Noun phrases** tell us which people or things are being talked about.

**Verb phrases** tell us what is being said about them, e.g. what they are doing.

Chaps. 1–2 of this grammar deal with noun phrases.

For information about verb phrases, see Chap. 3.

1.2 A noun phrase can be the **subject** or **object** of a verb, it can follow a **linking verb**, or it can be the object of a **preposition**.

**Example 1.1.1.** *Babies cry when they are hungry.*

*I couldn't feel anger against him.*

*They were teachers.*

*Let us work together in peace.*

1.3 You use a noun phrase to talk about someone or something by naming them.

You do this by using a general name, called a **noun** or **common noun**, or by using a specific name, called a **proper noun**.

Proper nouns are mainly used for people, places, and events.

**Example 1.1.2.** *Mary likes strawberries.*

*I went to Drexel University and then I went to Pittsburgh to work for a psychiatrist.*

*We flew to Genera with British Airways.*

See paragraphs **1.52–1.58** for more information about **proper nouns**.

1.4 If you use a common noun, you are saying that the person or thing you are talking about can be put in a set with others that are similar in some way.

If you just want to say that the person or thing is in that set, you use an **indefinite determiner** with the common noun.

**Example 1.1.3.** *I met a girl who was a student there.*

*Have you got any comment to make about that?*

*There are some diseases that are clearly inherited.*

If you want to show which member of a set you are talking about, you use a **definite determiner** with a common noun.

**Example 1.1.4.** *I put my arm round her shoulders.*

*... the destruction of their city.*

*She came in to see me this morning.*

See paragraphs **1.162–1.251** for more information about **determiners**, and paragraphs **1.13–1.92** for more information about **nouns**.

1.5 You may decide not to name the person or thing and to use a **pronoun** rather than a proper noun or common noun.

You usually do this because the person or thing has already been named, so you refer to them by using a **personal pronoun** or a **demonstrative pronoun**.

**Example 1.1.5.** *Max will believe us, won't he?*
*'Could I speak to Sue, please?' - 'I'm sorry, she doesn't work here now.'*
*Some people have servants to cook for them.*
*This led to widespread criticism.*

See paragraphs **1.95–1.106** for more information about **personal pronouns**, and paragraphs **1.124–1.127** for more information about **demonstrative pronouns**.

1.6 You may decide not to name the person or thing at all, e.g. because you do not want to, you think it is not important, you do not know, or you want to be vague or mysterious while telling a story.

In such cases you use an **indefinite pronoun**, which does not refer to any particular person or thing.

**Example 1.1.6.** *I had to say something.*
*In this country nobody trusts anyone.*
*A moment later, his heart seemed to stop as he sensed the sudden movement of someone behind him.*

See paragraphs **1.128–1.141** for more information about **indefinite pronouns**.

1.7 If you want to give more information about the person or thing you are talking about, rather than just giving their general or specific name, you can use a **modifier** e.g. an **adjective**, or you can add extra information in the form of a phrase or a clause, for example.

1.8 Most **adjectives** are used as modifiers.

Nouns are also often used as modifiers.

**Example 1.1.7.** *... a big city.*
*... blue ink.*
*He opened the car door.*
*... the oil industry.*

See paragraphs **2.2–2.168** for more information about **adjectives**, and paragraphs **2.169–2.174** for more information about **noun modifiers**.

1.9 You can add a prepositional phrase, a relative clause, a relative clause, an adverb of place of time, or a *to*-infinitive after the noun.

**Example 1.1.8.** *... a girl in a dark grey dress.*
*... the man who employed me.*
*... the room upstairs.*
*... the desire to kill.*

Adjectives and participles are also sometimes used after the noun, usually in combination with other words.

**Example 1.1.9.** *... the Minister responsible for national security.*
*... the 3 cards lying on the table.*

See paragraphs **2.272–2.302** for more details about information that is added after the noun.

1.10 In particular, prepositional phrases beginning with *of* are very common, because they can express many different kinds of relationship between the 2 noun phrases.

**Example 1.1.10.** *... strong feelings of jealousy.*
*... a picture of a house.*
*... the rebuilding of the old hospital.*
*... the daughter of the village cobbler.*
*... problems of varying complexity.*
*... the arrival of the police.*

For more information about the use of *of* in the noun phrase see paragraphs **2.277–2.283**.

1.11 If you want to refer separately to more than 1 person or thing, or you want to describe them in more than 1 way, you link noun phrases using the **conjunctions** *and, or*, or *but*.

Sometimes you use a common instead of *and*, or just put 1 word next to another.

**Example 1.1.11.** ... *a table and chair.*
... *his obligations with regard to Amanda, Robert and Matthew.*
... *some fruit or cheese afterwards.*
... *her long black skirt.*

See paragraphs **8.171–8.201** for more information about the use of conjunctions to link noun phrases and words within noun phrases.

1.12 If you want to say how many things you are talking about, or how much of something here is, you use **numbers** and **quantity expressions**.

**Example 1.1.12.** *Last year I worked 7 days a week 14 hours a day.*
*She drinks lots of coffee.*

**Numbers** are dealt with in paragraphs **2.208–2.239**, and **quantity expressions** are dealt with in **2.175–2.193**.

## 1.2 Identifying people & things: nouns

1.13 A noun is used to identity a person or thing.

In this chapter 6 main types of noun are described.

They are classified according to whether they have a plural form, whether they need a determiner in front of them, and whether they occur with a singular verb or a plural verb when they are the subject of the verb.

The 6 types are:

**classification**: **example**: **comments**: **paragraph**

1. **countable nouns**: a bird, birds: have plural, need determiner: **1.15–1.22**
2. **uncountable nouns**: happiness equipment: no plural, usually no determiner: **1.23–1.33**
3. **singular nouns**: the moon, a day: no plural, need determiner: **1.34–1.40**
4. **plural nouns**: clothes scissors: no singular: **1.41–1.46**
5. **collective nouns**: the public, the staff: either singular or plural verb: **1.47–1.51**
6. **proper nouns**: Mary, London, The United Nations: start with capital letter: **1.52–1.58**

Many nouns have a number of different meanings, and so can be, e.g., a countable noun for 1 meaning, an uncountable noun for another, and a singular noun for another.

There are few other groups of nouns with special features.

These are dealt with in paragraphs **1.59–1.92**.

1.14 Most nouns do not begin with a capital letter, unless they are used to start a sentence.

However, the following types of noun are always spelled with a capital letter:

- **proper nouns** or names

  **Example 1.2.1.** ... *my sister Elizabeth.*

  *I love reading Shakespeare.*

  *I'll be in the office on Monday.*

  *I think he's gone to London.*

  For more information on proper nouns, see paragraphs **1.52–1.58**.

  Proper nouns that are time expressions are dealt with a Chap. 4, and those that are place names in Chap. 6.

- nouns that identify people of a particular nationality, or languages

  **Example 1.2.2.** *Can you think of some typical problems experienced by Germans learning English?*

- nouns that are the name of a particular product

  **Example 1.2.3.** *He drives a Porsche.*

  *Put a bit of Sellotape across it.*

### 1.2.1 Things that can be counted: countable nouns

1.15 Many nouns have 2 forms, the **singular** form, which is used to refer to 1 person or thing, and the **plural** form, which is used to refer to more than 1 person or thing.

These nouns refer to people or things that can be counted.

You can put numbers in front of them.

**Example 1.2.4.** ... *book*... *books*.
... *day*... *days*.
... *3 brothers*.
... *10 minutes*.

These nouns make up the largest group of nouns in English.

They are called **countable nouns**.

1.16 When you use the singular form of a countable noun as the subject of a verb, you use a singular verb.

When you use the plural form of a countable noun as the subject, you use a plural verb.

**Example 1.2.5.** *A dog likes to eat far more meat than a human being.*
*Bigger dogs cost more.*

1.17 Countable nouns have a determiner in front of them when they are used in the singular.

**Example 1.2.6.** *He got into the car and started the motor.*
*They left the house to go for a walk after lunch.*

When you use the plural form of a countable noun to talk about something in general, you do not use a determiner.

**Example 1.2.7.** *They all live in big houses.*
*Most classrooms have computers.*

However, if you are specifying a particular instance of something, you need to use a determiner.

**Example 1.2.8.** *The houses in our street are all identical.*
*Our computers can give you all the relevant details.*

1.18 Here is a list of some common countable nouns:

**Example 1.2.9.** *accident, account, actor, address, adult, animal, answer, apartment, article, artist, baby, bag, ball, bank, battle, beach, bed, bell, bill, bird, boat, book, bottle, box, boy, bridge, brother, bus, bush, camp, captain, car, card, case, castle, cat, chair, chapter, chest, child, cigarette, city, class, club, coat, college, computer, corner, country, crowd, cup, daughter, day, desk, doctor, dog, door, dream, dress, driver, ear, edge, effect, egg, election, engine, eye, face, factory, farm, father, field, film, finger, foot, friend, game, garden, gate, girl, group, gun, hall, hand, handle, hat, head, heart, hill, horse, hospital, hotel, hour, house, husband, idea, island, issue, job, journey, judge, key, king, kitchen, lady, lake, library, line, list, machine, magazine, man, meal, meeting, member, message, method, minute, mistake, model, month, motor, mouth, nation, neck, newspaper, office, page, park, party, path, picture, plan, plane, plant, problem, product, programme, project, ring, river, road, room, scheme, school, ship, shirt, shock, shop, sister, smile, son, spot, star, station, store, stream, street, student, table, task, teacher, tent, thought, tour, town, valley, village, walk, wall, week, window, woman, yard, year*

Note that many of these nouns have some meanings in which they are uncountable nouns, but they are countable nouns in their commonest meanings.

1.19 For most countable nouns the plural form has *-s* at the end, which distinguishes it from the singular form.

**Example 1.2.10.** ... *bed*... *beds*.
... *car*... *cars*.

Some countable nouns have other differences between the singular and plural forms.

**Example 1.2.11.** ... *bus*... *buses*.
... *lady*... *ladies*.
... *calf*... *calves*.
... *man*... *men*.
... *mouse*... *mice*.

For full information about the plural forms of countable nouns, see the Reference section.

1.20 Some countable nouns have the same form for both singular and plural.

**Example 1.2.12.** *... a sheep.*
*... 9 sheep.*

Many of these nouns refer to animals or fish; others are more varied in meaning:

**Example 1.2.13.** *bison, deer, elk, greenfly, grouse, moose, reindeer, sheep*
*cod, fish, goldfish, halibut, mullet, salmon, shellfish, trout, whitebait*
*aircraft, hovercraft, spacecraft*
*crossroads, dice, fruit, gallows, grapefruit, insignia, mews, offspring, series, species*
*bourgeois, chassis, corps, patois, précis, rendezvous*

1.21 The names of many animals and birds have 2 forms, one singular and one plural.
However, when you are referring to them in the context of hunting or when you are saying that there are large numbers of them, it is quite common to use the form without *-s*, even though you are referring to several animals or birds.

**Example 1.2.14.** *We went up north to hunt deer.*

Note that the plural form of the verb is used when several animals or birds are the subject of the sentence, even if you use the form without *-s*.

**Example 1.2.15.** *Zebra are a more difficult prey.*

Similarly, when you are referring to a large number of trees or plants growing together, you can use the singular form of their name.
When you are referring to a small number or to individual trees or plants, you usually use the form with *-s*.

**Example 1.2.16.** *Zebra are a more difficult prey.*

Similarly, when you are referring to a large number of trees or plants growing together, you can use the singular form of their name.
When you are referring to a small number or to individual trees or plants, you usually use the form with *-s*.

**Example 1.2.17.** *... the rows of willow and cypress which lined the creek.*
*... the poplars and willows along the Peshawar Road.*

1.22 [**Be creative**] Although some names of animals, birds, trees, and plants are commonly used in the singular form with plural meaning, in fact all such names can be used in this way.

### 1.2.2 Things not usually counted: uncountable nouns

1.23 Some nouns refer to general things e.g. qualities, substances, processes, and topics rather than to individual items or events.
These nouns have only 1 form, are not used with numbers, and are not usually used with the determiners *the, a*, or *an*.

**Example 1.2.18.** *... a boy or girl with intelligence.*
*Make sure everyone has enough food and drink.*
*... new techniques in industry and agriculture.*
*I talked with people about religion, death, marriage, money, and happiness.*

These nouns are called **uncountable nouns**.
1.24 When you use an uncountable noun as the subject of a verb, you use a singular form of the verb.

**Example 1.2.19.** *Love makes you do strange things.*
*They believed that poverty was a threat to world peace.*
*Electricity is potentially dangerous.*

1.25 Here is a list of some common uncountable nouns:

**Example 1.2.20.** *absence, access, age, agriculture, anger, atmosphere, beauty, behavior, cancer, capacity, childhood, china, comfort, concern, confidence, courage, death, democracy, depression, design, duty, earth, education, electricity, energy, environment, equipment, evil, existence, experience, failure, faith, fashion, fear, finance, fire, flesh, food, freedom, fun, ground, growth, happiness, health, help, history, ice, independence, industry, insurance, intelligence, joy, justice, labor, loneliness, love, luck, magic, marriage, mercy, music, nature, paper, patience, peace, philosophy, pleasure, policy, poverty, power, pride, protection, purity, rain, reality, refief, religion, respect, rice, safety, salt, sand, security, silence, sleep, strength, snow, spite, status, stuff, teaching, technology, time, trade, training, transport, travel, trust, truth, violence, waste, water, wealth, weather, welfare, wind, work, worth, youth*

1.26 [!] There are some words that are uncountable nouns in English, but that refer to things that are considered countable in other languages.

Here is a list of the most common uncountable nouns of this type:

**Example 1.2.21.** *advice, baggage, furniture, hair, homework, information, knowledge, luggage, machinery, money, news, progress, research, spaghetti, traffic*

1.27 Although uncountable nouns refer to things that cannot be counted and are not used with numbers, you often want to talk about an amount of something that is expressed by an uncountable noun.

Sometimes, you can do this by putting an **indefinite determiner** e.g. *all, enough, little*, or *some* in front of the noun.

**Example 1.2.22.** *Do you have enough money?*
*There's some chocolate cake over there.*

For more information on indefinite determiners that can be used with uncountable nouns, see paragraph **1.225**.

You can also put a **quantity expression** in front of the noun.

E.g., when you refer to water you can say *drops of water, a cup of water, 4 gallons of water*, and so on.

The use of quantity expressions with uncountable nouns is explained in paragraphs **2.194**–**2.207**.

1.28 When you are sure that your reader or hearer will understand that a quantity of something is being referred to, you do not need to use a quantity expression.

E.g., in a restaurant you can ask for *3 cups of coffee*, but you can also ask for *3 coffees* because the person you are talking to will know that you mean *3 cups of coffee*.

In this way, the uncountable noun *coffee* has become countable.

Nouns used in this way are called **mass nouns**.

1.29 Mass nouns are often used to refer to quantities of a particular kind of food or drink.

**Example 1.2.23.** *We spent 2 hours talking over coffee and biscuits in her study.*
*We stopped for a coffee at a small café.*

1.30 Similarly, some uncountable nouns can be mass nouns when they refer to types of something,

E.g., *cheese* is usually an uncountable noun but you can talk about *a large range of cheeses*.

**Example 1.2.24.** *... plentiful cheap beer.*
*... profits from low-alcohol beers.*
*We were not allowed to buy wine or spirits at lunch time.*
*We shell a wide variety of wines and liqueurs.*

Mass nouns referring to different types of a substance are mainly used in technical contexts.

E.g. *steel* is nearly always an uncountable noun, but in contexts where it is important to distinguish between different kinds of steel it can be a mass noun.

**Example 1.2.25.** *... imports of European steel.*
*... the use of small amounts of nitrogen in making certain steels.*

1.31 The following is a list of frequency used mass nouns:

**Example 1.2.26.** *adhesive, beer, brandy, bread, cake, cheese, claret, cloth, coal, coffee, cognac, coke, cotton, curry, deodorant, detergent, disinfectant, dye, fabric, fertilizer, fuel, fur, fin, glue, ink, insecticide, iron, jam, jelly, juice, lager, liqueur, lotion, material, meat, medicine, metal, milk, oil, ointment, ore, paint, perfume, pesticide, plastic, poison, preservative, ribbon, salad, sauce, sherry, soap, soil, soup, steel, sugar, tea, vodka, whisky, wine, wood, wool, yarn, yoghurt*

1.32 There are also some other nouns that can be uncountable nouns when they refer to a thing in general, and countable nouns when they refer to a particular instance of it.

Some nouns are commonly both uncountable nouns and countable nouns.

E.g., *victory* refers to the idea of winning in general but *a victory* refers to a particular occasion when someone wins.

**Example 1.2.27.** *He worked long and hard and finally led his team to victory.*
*... his victory in the Australian Grand Prix.*
*Many parents were alarmed to find themselves in open conflict with the church.*
*Hundreds of people have died in ethnic conflicts.*

Some uncountable nouns are rarely or never countable nouns; i.e., they do not occur in a plural form, or with a number.

**Example 1.2.28.** *... a collection of fine furniture.*
*We found Alan weeping with relief and joy.*
*He saved money by refusing to have a telephone.*

1.33 Some nouns that end in *-s* and look as if they are plural are in fact uncountable nouns.
This means that when they are the subject of a verb, the verb is in the singular.
These nouns refer mainly to subjects to study, activities, games, and diseases.

**Example 1.2.29.** *Physics is fun.*
*Politics plays a large part in village life.*
*Economics is the oldest of the social sciences.*
*Darts is a very competitive sport.*
*Measles is in most cases a relatively harmless disease.*

Here are 3 lists of uncountable nouns ending in *-s*.
These nouns refer to subjects of study and activities:

**Example 1.2.30.** *acoustics, aerobics, aerodynamics, aeronautics, athletics, classics, economics, electronics, genetics, gymnastics, linguistics, logistics, mathematics, mechanics, obstetrics, physics, politics, statistics, thermodynamics*

Note that some of these nouns are occasionally used as plural nouns, especially when you are talking about a particular person's work or activities.

**Example 1.2.31.** *His politics are clearly right-wing.*

These nouns refer to games:

**Example 1.2.32.** *billiards, bowls, cards, darts, draughts, skittles, tiddlywinks*

These nouns refer to diseases:

**Example 1.2.33.** *diabetes, measles, mumps, rabies, rickets, shingles*

### 1.2.3 When there is only 1 of something: singular nouns

1.34 There are certain things in the world that are unique.
There are other things that you almost always want to talk about one at a time.
This means that there are some nouns, or more often some meanings of nouns, for which only a singular form is used.
When a noun is used with such a meaning, it is called a **singular noun**.
Singular nouns are always used with a determiner, because they behave like the singular form of a countable noun.
1.35 When you use a singular noun as the subject of a verb, you use a singular form of the verb.

**Example 1.2.34.** *The sun was shining.*
*The atmosphere is very relaxed.*

1.36 Some singular nouns refer to 1 specific thing and therefore are used with the.
Some of these nouns, in fact, refer to something of which there is only one in the world.

**Example 1.2.35.** *There were huge cracks in the ground.*
*The moon had not yet reached my window.*
*Burning tanks threw great spirals of smoke into the air.*
*He's always thinking about the the past and worrying about the future.*

1.37 Other singular nouns can be used to refer to 1 thing only when it is obvious from the context what you are referring to.
E.g., if you are in Leeds and say *I work at the university*, you will almost certainly mean Leeds University.
However, in the following examples it is not clear exactly who or what the singular noun refers to, because there is not enough context.

**Example 1.2.36.** *In many countries the market is small numerically.*
*Their company looks good only because the competition looks bad.*
*You've all missed the point.*

Unless it is made clear which goods or products are being talked about, it is not possible for the reader or listener to be sure which group of potential buyers *the market* refers to.

Similarly it is not possible to know exactly which company or group of companies *the competition* refers to.

In the last example, the speaker is presumably going to state what he or she thinks *the point* is.

1.38 There are some activities that you do not usually do more than once at a time.

The nouns that refer to them are usually the object of a verb, and are used with the determiner *a*.

In this structure the verb has very little meaning and the noun carries most of the meaning of the whole structure.

For more information about these verb + object idioms, see paragraphs **3.32–3.45**.

**Example 1.2.37.** *I went and had a wash.*
*Bruno gave it a try.*

Some singular nouns are used so regularly with a particular verb that they have become fixed phrases and are idiomatic.

**Example 1.2.38.** *I'd like very much for you to have a voice in the decision.*
*Isn't it time we made a move?*

1.39 There are 2 special kinds of structure in which a singular noun is used.

A singular noun is sometimes used with the determiner *a* after a linking verb.

See paragraphs **3.126–3.181** for more information about **linking verbs**.

**Example 1.2.39.** *Decision-making is an art.*
*The quickest way was by using the car.*
*It was a risk but he decided it had to be taken.*
*They were beginning to find Griffiths' visits rather a strain.*

A singular noun is sometimes used with the determiner *the*, followed by a prepositional phrase beginning with *of*.

**Example 1.2.40.** *Comedy is the art of making people laugh.*
*Old machines will be replaced by newer ones to reduce the risk of breakdown.*
*He collapsed under the strain of a heavy workload.*

This group includes nouns used metaphorically; see paragraph **1.64** for more details.

Some singular nouns are always used to refer to 1 particular quality or thing, but are rarely used alone; i.e., they need to be specified in some way by the use of supporting material.

They can be used with a number of different determiners.

**Example 1.2.41.** *There was a note of satisfaction in his voice.*
*Bessie covered the last 50 yards at a tremendous pace.*
*Simon allowed his pace to slacken.*
*She was simply incapable of behaving in a rational and considered manner.*
*... their manner of rearing their young.*

Nouns that are rarely used alone without supporting material are discussed in detail in paragraphs **1.59–1.65**.

**[i] Usage note.**

1.40 Some nouns are used in the singular with a particular meaning only in an idiomatic phrase.

They have the appearance of singular nouns, but they are not used as freely as singular nouns.

**Example 1.2.42.** *What happens down there is none of my business.*
*It's a pity I can't get to him.*

### 1.2.4 Referring to more than 1 thing: plural nouns

1.41 There are some things that are considered to be plural rather than singular, so some nouns have only a plural form.

E.g., you buy *goods*, but not *a good*.

These nouns are called **plural nouns**.

Other nouns have only a plural form when they are used with a particular meaning.

E.g., an official meeting between American and Russian leaders is usually referred to as *talks* rather than as *a talk*.

In these meanings, these nouns are also called **plural nouns**.

**Example 1.2.43.** *Union leaders met the company for wage talks on Oct 9.*
*It is inadvisable to sell goods on a sale or return basis.*
*Take care of your clothes.*
*The weather conditions were the same.*
*All proceeds are going to charity.*
*Employees can have meals on the premises.*

Note that some plural nouns do not end in *-s*: e.g. *clergy, police, poultry*, and *vermin*.

1.42 When you use a plural noun as the subject of a verb, you use plural form of the verb.

**Example 1.2.44.** *Expenses for attending meetings are sometimes claimed.*
*The foundations were shaking.*
*Refreshments were on sale in the café.*
*Attempts were made where resources were available.*

1.43 You do not usually use numbers in front of plural nouns.

You can, however, use some **indefinite determiners** e.g. *some* or *many*.

For more information about the indefinite determiners that can be used with plural nouns, see the section beginning at paragraph **1.223**.

Some plural nouns usually have a definite determiner in front of them, because they are specific; some never have a determiner at all, because they are very general; and some are rarely used alone without extra information in the form of a phrase or a clause, e.g., because they need supporting material.

The lists in the following 2 paragraphs contain some common plural nouns that are frequently used in 1 of these ways.

Many of them have other meanings in which they are countable nouns.

1.44 Some plural nouns are most commonly used with *the*.

**Example 1.2.45.** *Things are much worse when the rains come.*
*The authorities are concerned that the cocaine may be part of an international drug racket.*
*The coach tour of Gran Canaria was a wonderfully relaxing way to see the sights.*

Here is a list of plural nouns that are most commonly used with *the*:

**Example 1.2.46.** *authorities, foundations, fruits, heavens, mains, odds, pictures, races, rains, sights, waters, wilds*

Some plural nouns are most commonly used with a possessive determiner e.g. *my* or *his*:

**Example 1.2.47.** *It offended her feelings.*
*My travels up the Dalmation coast began in Dubrovnik.*
*This only added to his troubles.*

Here is a list of plural nouns that are most commonly used with a possessive determiner:

**Example 1.2.48.** *activities, attentions, feelings, likes, movements, reactions, terms, travels, troubles, wants*

Some plural nouns are most commonly used without a determiner.

**Example 1.2.49.** *There were 1 or 2 cases where people returned goods.*
*There is only 1 applicant, which simplifies matters.*
*They treated us like vermin.*

Here is a list of plural nouns that are most commonly used without a determiner:

**Example 1.2.50.** *airs, appearances, events, expenses, figures, goods, matters, refreshments, riches, solids, talks, vermin*

Some plural nouns can be used both with or without determiners.

**Example 1.2.51.** *The house was raided by police.*
*We call the police.*
*A luxury hotel was to be used as headquarters.*
*The city has been his headquarters for 5 years.*
*We didn't want it to dampen spirits which were required to remain positive.*
*The last few miles really lifted our spirits.*

Here is a list of plural nouns that can be used with or without a determiner:

**Example 1.2.52.** *arms, basics, brains, clergy, costs, directions, essentials, greens, grounds, handcuffs, headquarters, interests, looks, means, morals, papers, particulars, people, police, poultry, premises, proceeds, rates, resources, specifics, spirits, supplies, talks, thanks, tracks, troops, values*

1.45 Some plural nouns are rarely used alone without a modifier, or some other form of extra information, because they need supporting material.

**Example 1.2.53.** *He doesn't tolerate bad manners.*
*Our country's coastal defences need improving.*
*. . . the hidden pressures of direct government funding.*

Here is a list of plural nouns that are rarely used alone without a modifier or some other extra information:

**Example 1.2.54.** *affairs, conditions, defences, demands, details, effects, forces, hopes, lines, manners, materials, matters, pressures, proportions, quarters, relations, remains, sands, services, thoughts, wastes, ways, words, works, writings*

1.46 2 special groups of nouns are usually plural: nouns referring to clothes and some other things that people wear, and nouns referring to tools and some other things that people use.
This is because some clothes and tools, e.g. *trousers* and *scissors*, are made up of 2 similar parts.

**Example 1.2.55.** *She wore brown trousers and a green sweater.*
*He took off his glasses.*
*. . . using the pliers from the toolbox.*

When you want to refer to these items in general, or to an unspecified number of them, you use the plural form with no determiner.

**Example 1.2.56.** *Never poke scissors into a light bulb socket.*
*The man was watching the train through binoculars.*

Here is a list of some plural nouns that refer to clothes and other things that people wear:

**Example 1.2.57.** *braces, briefs, cords, dungarees, glasses, jeans, jodhpurs, knickers, leggings, overalls, panties, pants, pyjamas, shorts, slacks, specs, spectacles, sunglasses, tights, trousers, trunks, underpants*

Here is a list of plural nouns that refer to tools and other things that people use:

**Example 1.2.58.** *binoculars, clippers, compasses, dividers, nutcrackers, pincers, pliers, scales, scissors, secateurs, shears, tongs, tweezers*

When you want to refer to a single piece of clothing or a single tool, you use *some* or *a pair of* in front of the noun.
You refer to more than 1 item by using a number or a quantity expression with *pairs of*.

**Example 1.2.59.** *I got some scissors out of the kitchen drawer.*
*I went out to buy a pair of scissors.*
*He was wearing a pair of old grey trousers.*
*Liza has 3 pairs of jeans.*

You can also use *a pair of* when you are talking about things e.g. gloves, shoes, and socks that typically occur in twos.

**Example 1.2.60.** *. . . a pair of new gloves.*

A possessive determiner e.g. *my* can be used instead of *a*.

**Example 1.2.61.** *. . . his favorite pair of shoes.*

When you use *a pair of* with a noun in the plural form, the verb is singular if it is in the same clause.
If the verb is in a following relative clause, it is usually plural.

**Example 1.2.62.** *It is likely that a new pair of shoes brings more happiness to a child than a new car brings to a grown-up.*
*I always wear a pair of long pants underneath, or a pair of pyjamas is just as good.*
*He put on a pair of brown shoes, which were waiting there for him.*
*He wore a pair of earphones, which were plugged into a radio.*

You use a plural pronoun after *a pair of*.

**Example 1.2.63.** *She went to the wardrobe, chose a pair of shoes, put them on and leaned back in the chair.*
*He brought out a pair of dark glasses and handed them to Walker.*

### 1.2.5 Referring to groups: collective nouns

1.47 Some nouns in English refer to a group of people or things.

These nouns are called **collective nouns**.

They have only 1 form, but many collective nouns have other meanings in which they are countable nouns with 2 forms.

1.48 When you use a collective noun, you can use either a singular verb or a plural verb after it.

You choose a singular verb if you think of the group as a single unit, and a plural verb if you think of the group as a number of individuals.

**Example 1.2.64.** *Our little group is complete again.*
*A 2nd group are those parents who feel that we were too harsh.*
*Our family isn't poor any more.*
*My family are all perfectly normal.*
*The enemy was moving slowly to the east.*
*The enemy were visibly cracking.*
*His arguments were confined to books which the public was unlikely to read.*
*The public were deceived by the newspapers.*

[**AE**] In American English, it is more usual to use a singular verb unless the sentence contains an element that clearly refers to more than 1 person or thing.

The names of many organizations are collective nouns, and can be used with a singular or a plural verb.

**Example 1.2.65.** *The BBC is sending him to Tuscany for the summer.*
*The BBC are planning to use the new satellite next month.*
*England was leading 18-0 at half-time.*
*England are seeking alternatives for their B team.*

[**AE**] American English uses a singular verb for these.

**Example 1.2.66.** *GE reports its 2nd-quarter financial results on Jul 16.*
*New England is going to sign him to a long-term contract.*

If you want to refer back to a collective noun, you choose a singular pronoun or determiner if the previous verb is singular, and a plural pronoun or determiner if the previous verb is plural.

**Example 1.2.67.** *The government has said it would wish to do this only if there was no alternative.*
*The government have made up their minds that they're going to win.*

**[i] Usage note.**

1.49 Note that the words *bacteria, data*, and *media* are now often used as collective nouns, that is with either a singular or a plural verb and no change in form.

Some careful speakers think they should only be used with a plural verb because they have the rare singular forms *bacterium, datum*, and *medium* and are therefore countable nouns.

**Example 1.2.68.** *Medieval Arabic data show that the length of the day has been increasing more slowly than expected.*
*Our latest data shows more firms are hoping to expand in the near future.*

1.50 [!] Although you can use a plural verb after a collective noun, these nouns do not behave like the plural forms of countable nouns.

E.g., you cannot use numbers in front of them.

You cannot say *3 enemy were killed.*

You have to say *3 of the enemy were killed.*

1.51 Here is a list of common collective nouns:

**Example 1.2.69.** *aristocracy, army, audience, bacteria, brood, cast, committee, community, company, council, crew, data, enemy, family, flock, gang, government, group, herd, jury, media, navy, nobility, opposition, panel, press, proletariat, public, staff, team*

Some collective nouns are also **partitives** (nouns that are used to talk about a quantity of something).

E.g., you talk about *a flock of sheep* and *a herd of cattle.*

See paragraph **2.198** for more information about these.

### 1.2.6 Referring to people & things by name: proper nouns

1.52 When you talk about a particular person, you can use their name.
Names are usually called **proper nouns**.
People's names are spelled with a capital letter, and do not have a determiner in front of them.

**Example 1.2.70.** ... *Michael Hall... Jenny... Smith.*

Ways of using people's names when you are speaking to them directly are explained in paragraph **9.95–9.99**.

1.53 Sometimes a person's name is used to refer to something they create.
You can refer to a painting, sculpture, or book by a particular person by using the person's name like a countable noun.
You still spell it with a capital letter.

**Example 1.2.71.** *In those days you could buy a Picasso for £300.*
*I was looking at their Monets and Matisses.*
*I'm reading an an Agatha Christie at the moment.*

You can refer to music composed or performed by a particular person by using the person's name like an uncountable noun.

**Example 1.2.72.** *I remembered it when we were listening to the Mozart.*
*... instead of playing Chopin and Stravinsky all the time.*

1.54 Nouns that refer to relationships between the people in a family, e.g. *mother, dad, aunt*, and *grandpa*, can also be used like names to address people or refer to them.
They are then spelled with a capital letter.

**Example 1.2.73.** *I'm sure Mum will be pleased.*

1.55 Words that show someone's social status or job are called **titles**.
They are spelled with a capital letter.
You use a title in front of a person's name, usually their surname or their full name, when you are talking about them in a fairly formal way or are showing respect to them.

**Example 1.2.74.** ... *Doctor Barker... Lord Curzon... Captain Jack Langtry... Mrs Ford.*

Here is a list of the most common titles that are used before names:

**Example 1.2.75.** *Admiral, Archbishop, Baron, Baroness, Bishop, Brother, Captain, Cardinal, Colonel, Congressman, Constable, Corporal, Dame, Doctor, Emperor, Father, General, Governor, Imam, Inspector, Justice, King, Lady, Lieutenant, Lord, Major, Miss, Mr, Mrs, Ms, Nurse, Police Constable, Pope, President, Prince, Princess, Private, Professor, Queen, Rabbi, Representative, Saint, Senator, Sergeant, Sir, Sister*

A few titles, e.g. *King, Queen, Prince, Princess, Sir*, and *Lady*, can be followed just by the person's 1st name.

**Example 1.2.76.** ... *Queen Elizabeth.*
*... Prince Charles' eldest son.*
*Sir Michael has made it very clear indeed.*

Ways of using titles when you are speaking to people directly are explained in paragraphs **9.97–9.98**.

1.56 Determiners, other modifiers, and phrases with *of* are sometimes used with titles, and the person's name is omitted.

**Example 1.2.77.** ... *Her Majesty the Queen and the Duke of Edinburgh.*
*... the Archbishop of Canterbury.*
*... the President of the United States.*
*... the Bishop of Birmingham.*

1.57 Most words that are titles can also be countable nouns, usually without a capital letter.

**Example 1.2.78.** ... *lawyers, scholars, poets, presidents and so on.*
*... a foreign prince.*
*Maybe he'll be a Prime Minister 1 day.*

1.58 The names of organizations, institutions, ships, magazines, books, plays, paintings, and other unique things are also proper nouns and are spelled with capital letters.

**Example 1.2.79.** ... *British Broadcasting Corporation*
... *Birmingham University.*

They are sometimes used with *the* or another determiner.

**Example 1.2.80.** ... *the United Nations* ... *the Labor Party*... *the University of Birmingham*... *the Queen Mary*... *the Guardian*... *the Wall Street Journal*... *the British Broadcasting Corporation.*

The determiner is not spelled with a capital letter, except in the names of books, plays, and paintings.

**Example 1.2.81.** ... *The Grapes of Wrath.*
... *A Midsummer Night's Dream.*

Some time expressions are proper nouns, and are dealt with in Chap. 4.

### 1.2.7 Nouns that are rarely used alone

1.59 There are some nouns that are rarely used alone.

They need extra material e.g. an adjective or a following phrase, because the meaning of the noun would not be clear without it.

Some of these nouns have many meanings; others have very little meaning on their own.

E.g., you cannot usually refer to someone as *the head* without saying which organization they are head of.

Similarly, you cannot say that there was *a note* in someone's voice without describing it as, e.g., *a triumphant note* or *a note of triumph.*

These nouns are used on their own only if it is obvious from the context what is meant.

E.g., if you have just mentioned a mountain and you say *the top*, it is clear that you mean the top of that mountain.

1.60 A **modifier** is an adjective or a noun that is added to a noun in order to give more information about it.

**Example 1.2.82.** ... *her wide experience of political affairs.*
*I detected an apologetic note in the agent's voice.*
*He did not have British citizenship.*
*Check the water level.*

For more information on modifiers, see Chap. 2.

1.61 Extra information after the noun is usually in the form of a phrase beginning with *of.*

**Example 1.2.83.** ... *at the top of the hill.*
*There he saw for himself the extent of the danger.*
*Ever since the rise of industrialism, education has concentrated on producing workers.*
... *a high level of interest.*

For more information, see paragraphs **2.272**–**2.302**.

1.62 Some nouns are always used with a modifier.

E.g., you would not say that someone is *an eater* because all people eat, but you may want to say that he or she is *a meat eater* or *a messy eater.*

Similarly, if you use *range*, you have to refer to a particular *price range* or *age range.*

If you use *wear* to mean *clothing*, you have to say what sort of clothing, e.g. *sports wear* or *evening wear.*

**Example 1.2.84.** *Time was a slow eater.*
... *the other end of the age range.*
*The company has plans to expand its casual wear.*

1.63 Some nouns are almost always used with a possessive, that is a **possessive determiner**, **'s**, or a prepositional phrase beginning with *of*, because you have to show who or what the thing you are talking about relates to or belongs to.

**Example 1.2.85.** *The company has grown rapidly since its formation 10 years ago.*
*Advance warning of the approach of enemies was of the greatest importance.*
... *the portrait of a man in his prime.*

1.64 Nouns that are being used metaphorically (= when 1 thing is used to describe another thing) often have a modifier or some other form of extra information, often in the form of a phrase beginning with *of*, to show what is really being referred to.

**Example 1.2.86.** ... *the maze of politics.*
*He has been prepared to sacrifice this company on the altar of his own political ambitions.*
*He has worked out a scheme for an economic lifeline by purchasing land.*
*Lloyd's of London is the heart of the world's insurance industry.*
*... those on the lower rungs of the professional ladder.*

1.65 Many nouns have some meanings that need a modifier or some other form of extra information, and other meanings that do not.

Here is a list of these nouns:

**Example 1.2.87.** *affair, approach, area, back, band, base, bottom, boundary, branch, case, center, circumstances, citizenship, class, condition, crisis, culture, depth, development, discovery, eater, edge, edition, element, end, enterprise, epidemic, experience, extent, feeling, field, formation, fringe, ground, growth, head, height, impression, inception, kind, length, level, limit, line, matter, movement, nature, note, period, point, position, power, prime, range, rate, regime, relic, repertoire, rise, role, scale, side, sort, stage, status, structure, stuff, style, system, texture, theory, thought, time, tone, top, transfer, type, version, view, wave, way, wear, wing, world*

### 1.2.8 Adjectives used as nouns: *the poor, the impossible*

1.66 When you want to talk about groups of people who share the same characteristic or equality, you can use *the* + adjective.

E.g., instead of saying *poor people*, you can say *the poor*.

**Example 1.2.88.** ... *the help that's given to the blind.*
*No effort is made to cater for the needs of the elderly.*
*... the task of rescuing the injured.*
*... men and women who would join the sad ranks of the unemployed.*
*Working with the young is stimulating and full of surprises.*
*... providing care for the sick, the aged, the workless and the poor.*

Note that you never add *-s* to the adjective, even though it always refers to more than 1 person.

1.67 [⋆] Although some adjectives are commonly used in this way, in fact it is possible to use almost any adjective in this way.

1.68 When the adjective being used as a noun is the subject of a verb, you use a plural form of the verb.

**Example 1.2.89.** *The rich have benefited much more than the poor.*

1.69 If you want to talk about a more specific group of people, you put a **submodifying adverb** (= an adverb that you put in front of an adjective to give more information about it) or another adjective in front of the headword.

For more information about submodifying adverbs, see paragraphs **2.140–2.168**.

**Example 1.2.90.** *In this anecdote, Ray shows his affection for the very old and the very young.*
*... the highly educated.*
*... the urban poor.*

If you mention 2 groups, you sometimes omit *the*.

**Example 1.2.91.** ... *a study that compared the diets of rich and poor in several nations.*
*... to help break down the barriers between young and old.*

With a few words e.g. *unemployed* and *dead*, you can say how many people you are referring to by putting a number in front of them.

**Example 1.2.92.** *We estimate there are about 300 dead.*

1.70 When you want to refer to the quality of something rather than to the thing itself, you can use the appropriate adjective with *the*.

**Example 1.2.93.** *Don't you think that you're wanting the impossible?*
*He is still exploring the limits of the possible.*
*... a mix of the traditional and the modern.*

1.71 All color adjectives can also be used as nouns.

**Example 1.2.94.** *... patches of blue.*
*... brilliant paintings in reds and greens and blues.*

Clothing of a particular color can be referred to simply by using the color adjective.

**Example 1.2.95.** *The men wore grey.*
*... the fat lady in black.*

**[i] Usage note.**
1.72 Nationality adjectives that end in *-ch, -sh, -se*, or *-ss* can be used in a similar way, unless there is a separate noun for the people.
E.g., French people are referred to as *the French* but Polish people are referred to as *Poles* or *the Poles*.

**Example 1.2.96.** *For many years the Japanese have dominated the market for Chinese porcelain.*
*Britons are the biggest consumers of chocolate after the Swiss and the Irish.*

### 1.2.9 Nouns referring to males or females

1.73 English nouns are not masculine, feminine, or neuter in the way that nouns in some other languages are.
E.g., most names of jobs, e.g. *teacher, doctor*, and *writer*, are used for both men and women.
But some nouns refer only to males and others only to females.
E.g., some nouns indicating people's family relationships, e.g. *father, brother*, and *son*, and some nouns indicating people's jobs, e.g. *waiter* and *policeman*, are used only to refer to males.
In the same way *mother, sister, daughter, waitress, actress*, and *sportswoman* are used only to refer to females.
1.74 Words that refer to women often end in *-ess*, e.g. *actress, waitress*, and *hostress*.
Another ending is *-woman*, as in *policewoman* and *sportswoman*.

**Example 1.2.97.** *... his wife Susannah, a former air stewardess.*
*A policewoman dragged me out of the crowd.*
*Steph Burton was named sportswoman of the year.*

1.75 Words ending in *-man* are either used to refer only to men or to both men and women.
E.g., a *postman* is a man, but a *spokesman* can be a man or a woman.
Some people now use words ending in *-person*, e.g. *chairperson* and *spokesperson*, instead of words ending in *-man*, in order to avoid appearing to refer specifically to a man.
**[i] Usage note.**
1.76 Most names of animals are used to refer to both male and female animals, e.g. *cat, elephant, horse, monkey*, and *sheep*.
In some cases there are different words that refer specifically to male animals or female animals, e.g. a male horse is a *stallion* and a female horse is a *mare*.
In other cases the general name for the animal is also the specific word for males or females: *dog* also refers more specifically to male dogs, *duck* also refers more specifically to female ducks.
Many of these specific words are rarely used, or used mainly by people who have a special interest in animals, e.g. farmers or vets.
Here is a list of some common specific words for male and female animals:

**Example 1.2.98.** *stallion, mare*
*bull, cow*
*cock, hen*
*dog, bitch*
*drake, duck*
*fox, vixen*
*gander, goose*
*lion, lioness*
*ram, ewe*
*buck, hind, stag, doe*
*tiger, tigress*
*boar, sow*

### 1.2.10 Referring to activities & processes: *-ing* nouns

1.77 When you want to talk about an action, activity, or process in a general way, you can use a noun that has the same form as the *-ing* participle of a verb.

These nouns are called different things in different grammars: gerunds, verbal nouns, or *-ing* forms.

In this grammar they are referred to as ***-ing* nouns**.

It is sometimes difficult to distinguish and ***-ing* noun** from an ***-ing* participle**, and it is usually not necessary to do so.

However, there are times when it is clearly a noun, e.g. when it is the subject of a verb, the object of a verb, or the object of a preposition.

**Example 1.2.99.** *Swimming is a great sport.*
*The emphasis was on teaching rather than learning.*
*The closing of so many mills left thousands unemployed.*
*Some people have never done any public speaking.*

The spelling of *-ing* nouns is explained in the Reference section.

The use of *-ing* adjectives is explained in paragraphs **2.63**–**2.76**.

1.78 Because *-ing* nouns refer to activities in a general way, they are usually **uncountable nouns**; i.e., they have only 1 form, cannot be used with numbers, and do not usually have a determiner in front of them.

For more information on uncountable nouns, see paragraphs **1.23**–**1.33**.

1.79 You often use an *-ing* noun because it is the only noun form available for certain verbs, e.g. *eat, hear, go, come*, and *bless*.

Other verbs have related nouns that are not *-ing* nouns: e.g. *see* and *sight*; *arrive* and *arrival*, *depart* and *departure*.

**Example 1.2.100.** *Eating is an important part of a cruise holiday.*
*. . . loss of hearing in 1 ear.*
*Only 6% of children receive any further training when they leave school.*

1.80 If you want to describe the action expressed by the noun, you use 1 or more adjectives or nouns in front of it.

**Example 1.2.101.** *He served a jail sentence for reckless driving.*
*The police need better training in dealing with the mentally ill.*
*He called for a national campaign against under-age drinking.*

1.81 A few *-ing* nouns, mostly words for sporting or leisure activities, and much more common than their related verbs.

In some cases there is no verb, although it is always possible to invent one.

E.g., you are more likely to say *We want caravanning around France* than *We caravanned around France*.

Here is a list of the commonest of these nouns:

**Example 1.2.102.** *angling, boating, bowling, canoeing, caravanning, electioneering, hang-gliding, mountaineering, paragliding, shoplifting, shopping, sightseeing, skateboarding, snorkeling, snowboarding, surfing, weightlifting, window-shopping, windsurfing, yachting*

Although these words are not always associated with a verb, most of them can be used as *-ing* participles.

**Example 1.2.103.** *I spent the afternoon window-shopping with Grandma.*

1.82 Some *-ing* nouns that are related to verbs are **countable nouns**.

They generally refer to the result of an action or process, or to an individual instance of it.

Sometimes their meaning is not closely related to that of the verb.

Here is a list of the commonest of these nouns:

**Example 1.2.104.** *beginning, being, building, drawing, feeling, finding, hearing, meaning, meeting, offering, painting, saying, setting, showing, sitting, suffering, turning, warning*

For more information on countable nouns, see paragraphs **1.15**–**1.22**.

### 1.2.11 Compound nouns: *car park, mother-in-law, breakdown*

1.83 A single noun is often not enough to refer clearly to a person or thing.

When this is the case, a **compound noun** can be used.

A compound noun is a fixed expression that is made from more than 1 word, and that behaves as a noun.

**Example 1.2.105.** *Some people write out a new address book every January.*
*How would one actually choose a small personal computer?*
*Where did you hide the can opener?*
*... a private swimming pool.*

Once it is clear what you are referring to, it is sometimes possible to use just the 2nd word of a 2-word compound noun. E.g., after mentioning *a swimming pool*, you can just refer to *the pool*.
Most compound nouns consist of 2 words, but some consist of 3 or more words.

**Example 1.2.106.** *... a vase of lily of the valley.*

1.84 Some compound nouns are written with hyphens instead of spaces between the words.

**Example 1.2.107.** *I'm looking forward to a lie-in tomorrow.*
*He's very good at problem-solving.*
*Judy's brother-in-law lived with his family.*

Some compound nouns, especially very frequent ones, are written as 1 word.

**Example 1.2.108.** *... patterned wallpaper.*
*They copied questions from the blackboard.*

In some cases, you can choose whether to write a compound noun with or without a hyphen, or with or without a space. E.g., both *air-conditioner* and *air conditioner* are possible, and both *postbox* and *post box* are possible.
A few compound nouns that consist of more than 2 words are written partly with hyphens and partly with spaces, e.g. *back-seat driver* and *bring-and-buy sale*.

**Example 1.2.109.** *... children from 1-parent families.*
*... a Parent-Teacher Association.*

1.85 Compound nouns may be countable, uncountable, singular, or plural.
Here is a list of some common countable compound nouns:

**Example 1.2.110.** *address book, air conditioner, air raid, alarm clock, assembly line, baby-sitter, back-seat driver, bank account, bird of prey, book token, blood donor, bride-to-be, bring-and-buy sale, brother-in-law, burglar alarm, bus stop, can opener, car park, compact disc, contact lens, credit card, dining room, drawing pin, driving license, estate agent, fairytale, father-in-law, film star, fire engine, fork-lift truck, frying pan, guided missile, health center, heart attack, high school, human being, letter box, lily of the valley, mother-in-law, musical instrument, nervous breakdown, news bulletin, old hand, 1-parent family, package holiday, Parent-Teacher, Association, parking meter, pen-friend, personal computer, polar bear, police station, post office, rolling pin, sister-in-law, sleeping bag, swimming pool, T-shirt, tea bag, telephone number, traveler's cheque, washing machine, X-ray, youth hostel, zebra crossing.*

1.86 Here is a list of some common uncountable compound nouns:

**Example 1.2.111.** *air conditioning, air-traffic control, barbed wire, birth control, blood pressure, bubble bath, capital punishment, central heating, chewing gum, common sense, cotton wool, data processing, do-it-yourself, dry-cleaning, family planning, fancy dress, fast food, 1st aid, food poisoning, further education, general knowledge, hay fever, heart failure, higher education, hire purchase, income tax, junk food, law and order, lost property, mail order, mineral water, nail varnish, natural history, old age, pocket money, remote control, science fiction, show business, show jumping, sign language, social security, social work, soda water, stainless steel, table tennis, talcum powder, toilet paper, tracing paper, unemployment benefit, value added tax, washing powder, washing-up liquid, water-skiing, writing paper*

1.87 Here is a list of some common singular compound nouns:

**Example 1.2.112.** *age of consent, arms race, brain drain, continental divide, cost of living, death penalty, diplomatic corps, dress circle, fire brigade, general public, generation gap, greenhouse effect, hard core, human race, labor force, labor market, long jump, mother tongue, open air, private sector, public sector, rank and file, solar system, sound barrier, space age, welfare state, women's movement*

1.88 Here is a list of some common plural compound nouns:

**Example 1.2.113.** *armed forces, baked beans, civil rights, current affairs, French fries, grass roots, high heels, human rights, industrial relations, inverted commas, licensing laws, luxury goods, modern languages, natural resources, race relations, road works, social services, social studies, swimming trunks, vocal cords, winter sports, yellow pages*

1.89 Most compound nouns consist of 2 nouns, or an adjective and a noun.

**Example 1.2.114.** *I listened with anticipation to the radio news bulletin.*
*. . . a big dining room.*
*Old age is a time for reflection and slowing down.*

however, some compound nouns are related to **phrasal verbs**.
These are sometimes written with a hyphen, and sometimes as 1 word.
They are rarely written as separate words.

**Example 1.2.115.** *The President was directly involved in the Watergate cover-up.*
*I think there's been a mix-up.*
*. . . a breakdown of diplomatic relations.*
*The singer is making a comeback.*

Here is a list of frequent nouns based on phrasal verbs.
They are shown in this list in the form in which they are most frequently written, either with a hyphen or as 1 word.

**Example 1.2.116.** *backup, bailout, blackout, breakaway, breakdown, break-in, breakout, break-up, build-up, buyout, check-in, checkout, check-up, comeback, cover-up, crackdown, cutbacks, drawback, feedback, follow-up, giveaway, handout, kick-off, lead-up, lookout, make-up, meltdown, mix-up, passer-by, run-in, runner-up, run-off, run-up, sell-out, setback, set-up, show-off, slowdown, takeaway, take-off, turnover, warm-up*

For more information about phrasal verbs, see paragraphs **3.83–3.116**.
**[i] Usage note.**
1.90 In some cases, the meaning of a compound noun is not obvious from the words it consists of.
E.g., someone's *mother tongue* is not the tongue of their mother but the language they learn as a child, and an *old hand* is not a hand that is old but a person who is experienced at doing a particular job.
**[Bubble]** In other cases, the compound noun consists of words that do not occur on their own, e.g. *hanky-panky, hodge-podge*, and *argy-bargy.*
These nouns are usually used in informal conversation rather than formal writing.

**Example 1.2.117.** *Most of what he said was a load of hocus-pocus.*
*She is usually involved in some sort of jiggery-pokery.*

1.91 The plural forms of compound nouns vary according to the type of words that they consist of.
If the final word of a compound noun is a countable noun, the plural form of the countable noun is used when the compound noun is plural.

**Example 1.2.118.** *Air raids were taking place every night.*
*. . . health centers, banks, post offices, and police stations.*
*Loud voices could be heard through letter boxes.*
*. . . the refusal of dockers to use fork-lift trucks.*

For full information about the plural forms of countable nouns, see the Reference section.
Compound nouns that are directly related to phrasal verbs usually have a plural form ending in *-s*.

**Example 1.2.119.** *Nobody seems disturbed about cover-ups when they are essential to the conduct of a war.*
*Naturally, I think people who drive smarter, faster cars than mine are show-offs.*

A few compound nouns are less directly related to phrasal verbs, and consist of a countable noun and an adverb.
In these cases, the plural form of the countable noun is used before the adverb when the compound noun is plural.
E.g., the plural of *runner-up* is *runners-up*, and the plural of *summing-up* is *summings-up*.

**Example 1.2.120.** *Passers-by helped the victim, who was unconscious.*

Compound nouns that consist of 2 nouns linked by the prepositions *of* or *in*, or a noun followed by *to-be*, have a plural form in which the 1st noun in the compound is plural.

**Example 1.2.121.** *I like birds of prey and hawks particularly.*
*She was treated with contempt by her sisters-in-law.*
*Most mothers-to-be in their 40s opt for this test.*

Some compound nouns have been borrowed from other languages, mainly French and Latin, and therefore do not have normal English plural forms.

**Example 1.2.122.** *Agents provocateurs were sent to cause trouble.*
*The nouveaux riches of younger states are building palatial mansions for themselves.*

1.92 Compound nouns are fixed expressions.
However, nouns can always be used in front of other nouns in order to refer to something in a more specific way.
For the use of nouns as **modifiers**, see paragraphs **2.169–2.174**.

## 1.3 Talking about people & things without naming them: pronouns

1.93 When you use language, both in speech and writing, you constantly refer to things you have already mentioned or are about to mention.
You can do this by repeating the noun phrase, but unless there is a special reason to do so, you are more likely to use a **pronoun** instead.
Pronouns make statements less repetitive.

**Example 1.3.1.** *John took the book and opened it.*
*Deborah recognized the knife as hers.*
*Shilton was pleased with himself.*
*This is a very busy place.*

However, if you have mentioned 2 or more different things, you usually have to repeat the noun phrase to make it clear which thing you are now talking about.

**Example 1.3.2.** *Leaflets and scraps of papers were scattered all over the floor.*
*I started to pick up the leaflets.*
*I could see a lorry and a car.*
*The lorry stopped.*

For other ways of talking about things that have already been mentioned, see paragraphs **10.2–10.39**.
1.94 There are several different types of pronoun:

- **personal pronouns**. See paragraphs **1.95–1.106**.
- **possessive pronouns.** See paragraphs **1.107–1.110**.
- **reflexive pronouns.** See paragraphs **1.111–1.118**.
- **generic pronouns.** See paragraphs **1.119–1.123**.
- **demonstrative pronouns.** See paragraphs **1.124–1.127**.
- **indefinite pronouns.** See paragraphs **1.128–1.141**.
- **reciprocal pronouns.** See paragraphs **1.142–1.145**.
- **relative pronouns.** See paragraphs **1.146–1.150**.
- **interrogative pronouns.** See paragraphs **1.151–1.153**.

There are a few other words that can be used as pronouns.
For more information about these, see paragraphs **1.154–1.161**.

### 1.3.1 Talking about people & things: personal pronouns

1.95 You use **personal pronouns** to refer to yourself, the people you are talking to, or the people or things you are talking about.
There are 2 sets of personal pronouns: subject pronouns and object pronouns.
1.96 Subject pronouns refer to the subject of a clause.
Here is a table of subject pronouns:

| | **singular** | **plural** |
|---|---|---|
| **1st person** | I | we |
| **2nd person** | you | you |
| **3rd person** | he, she, it | they |

1.97 You refer to yourself by using the pronoun *I*.
*I* is always written with a capital letter.

**Example 1.3.3.** *I don't know what to do.*
*I think I made the wrong decision.*
*May I ask why Stephen's here?*

1.98 You refer to the person or people you are talking to as *you*.
Note that the same word is used for the singular and the plural.

**Example 1.3.4.** *You may have to wait a bit.*
*Would you come and have a drink?*
*How did you get on?*

*You* is also used to refer to people in general, rather than to the person you are talking or writing to.
For more information on this, see paragraph **1.120**.
If you want to make it clear that you are addressing more than 1 person, you can create a plural form by using *you* followed by a determiner, a number or a noun.
Forms like this can also be used in object position.

**Example 1.3.5.** *My granddad wants you both to come round next Saturday.*
*As you all know, this is a challenge.*

Here is a list of the most common plural forms of *you*.

**Example 1.3.6.** *you all, you guys, you lot, you 2, you 3, you both*

*You guys* and *you lot* are more frequent in informal English.
*You lot* is not commonly used in American English.

**Example 1.3.7.** *I love working with you guys.*
*You guys are great!*
*So you lot will have to look after yourselves.*

Note that people often use *you lot* when they are being very direct with a group of people, as in the last example above.
**[AE]** Some varieties and dialects of English have developed particular forms of plural *you*.
In American English, particularly Southern American English, *y'all* is sometimes used, especially in speech.

**Example 1.3.8.** *What did y'all eat for breakfast?*
*I want to thank y'all.*

In some dialects of British and American English, *yous* and *youse* are used as plural forms:

**Example 1.3.9.** *I know what some of yous might be thinking.*

Another plural form is *you people*.
However, this can sound rude, and should only be used if you want to show that you are angry or annoyed with the people you are talking to.

**Example 1.3.10.** *'Why can't you people leave me alone?' he says.*
*'I can't work with you people,' Zoe said.*

Some plural forms of *you* - *you guys, you lot, you 2, you 3* and *y'all* - can be used as **vocatives**.
For more information on vocatives, see paragraphs **9.95–9.99**.
*You all* and *you both* cannot be used as vocatives.

**Example 1.3.11.** *'Listen, you guys,' she said. 'I'll tell you everything you want.'*
*Come on, you 2. Let's go home.*
*Bye, y'all!*

For more information on *you* as an **object pronoun**, see paragraphs **1.104–1.106**.
1.99 You refer to a man or a boy as *he*, and to a woman or a girl as *she*.

**Example 1.3.12.** *My father is 78, and he's very healthy and independent.*
*Billy Knight was a boxer, wasn't he?*
*Mary came in. She was a good-looking woman.*
*'Is Sue there?' - 'I'm sorry, she doesn't work here now.'*

1.100 You use *it* to refer to anything that is not male or female; e.g., an object, a place, an organization, or something abstract.

**Example 1.3.13.** *Have you seen Toy Story? It's a good film for kids.*
*'Have you been to London?' - 'Yes, it was very crowded.'*
*How much would the company be worth if it were sold?*
*It is not an idea that has much public support.*

*It* is often used to refer to an animal when its gender is not known or not considered to be important.
Some people also refer to babies in this way.

**Example 1.3.14.** *They punched the crocodile until it let go of her.*
*If the shark is still around it will not escape.*
*How Winifred loved the baby! And how Stephanie hated it!*

You also use *it* in general statements, e.g. to refer to a situation, the time, the date, or the weather.

**Example 1.3.15.** *It is very quiet here.*
*It is half past 3.*
*It is Jan 19th.*
*It is rainy and cold.*

For more information on the use of *it* in general statements, see paragraphs **9.31–9.45**.
Note that *it* is also an **object pronoun**.
For more information on this, see paragraphs **1.104–1.106**.
**[i] Usage note.**
1.101 Although *it* is used as a pronoun to refer to something that is not male or female, *she* is sometimes used to refer to ships, cars, and countries.
Some people do not like this usage.

**Example 1.3.16.** *When the repairs had been done she was a fine and beautiful ship.*

1.102 You use *we* to refer to a group of people that includes yourself.
The group can be:

- you can the person or people you are talking to

  **Example 1.3.17.** *Where shall we meet, Sally?*

- you and the person or people you are talking to and 1 or more others not there at the time

  **Example 1.3.18.** *We aren't exactly gossips, you and I and Watson.*

- you and 1 or more other people, but not including the person or people you are talking to

  **Example 1.3.19.** *I do the washing; he does the cooking; we share the washing-up.*

- any group that you feel yourself to be part of, e.g. a school, your local community, or even mankind as a whole.

  For more information on this, see paragraph **1.122**.

1.103 You use *they* to refer to a group of things, or to a group of people not including yourself or the person or people you are talking to.

**Example 1.3.20.** *All the girls think he's great, don't they?*
*Newspapers reach me on the day after they are published.*
*Winters here vary as they do elsewhere.*

*They* is also used to refer to people in general.
For more information on this, see paragraph **1.123**.
1.104 Object pronouns refer to the same sets of people or things as the corresponding subject pronouns.
Here is a table of object pronouns:

| | **singular** | **plural** |
|---|---|---|
| **1st person** | me | us |
| **2nd person** | you | you |
| **3rd person** | him, her, it | them |

1.105 Object pronouns are used as the object of a clause.

**Example 1.3.21.** *The nurse washed me with cold water.*
*He likes you; he said so.*
*The man went up to the cat and started stroking it.*

They can be the indirect object of a clause.

**Example 1.3.22.** *Send us card so we'll know where you are.*
*A man gave him a car.*
*You have to offer them some kind of incentive.*

They can also be the object of a preposition.

**Example 1.3.23.** *She must have felt intimidated by me.*
*Madeleine, I want to talk to you immediately.*
*We were all sitting in a café with him.*

1.106 Object pronouns can also be used after **linking verbs**.
E.g., you can say *It was me, It's her.*
However, in formal or written English, people sometimes use a subject pronoun after a linking verb.
E.g., *It was I, It is she.*
For more information on linking verbs, see paragraphs **3.126–3.181**.

### 1.3.2 Talking about possession: possessive pronouns

1.107 When you are talking about people or things, you often want to say how they are connected with each other.
There are several different ways in which you can do this, but you usually do it by using a **possessive pronoun** to show that something belongs to someone or is associated with them.
Here is a table showing possessive pronouns:

| | **singular** | **plural** |
|---|---|---|
| **1st person** | mine | ours |
| **2nd person** | yours | yours |
| **3rd person** | his, hers | theirs |

Note that *its* cannot be used as a possessive pronoun.
1.108 You use possessive pronouns when you are talking about the same type of thing that has just been mentioned but want to show that it belongs to someone else.
E.g., in the sentence *Jane showed them her passport, then Richard showed them his*, *his* refers to a passport and shows that it belongs to Richard.
Possessive pronouns are often used to contrast 2 things of the same type that belong to or are associated with different people.
E.g., *Sarah's house is much bigger than ours.*

**Example 1.3.24.** *Her parents were in Malaya, and so were mine.*
*He smiled at her and laid his hand on hers.*
*Is that coffee yours or mine?*
*My marks were higher than his.*
*Fred put his profits in the bank, while Julia spent hers on a car.*
*That's the difference between his ideas and ours.*
*It was his fault, not theirs.*

1.109 Possessive pronouns are used with *of* to add information to a noun phrase.
This structure suggests that you are talking about 1 of a group of things.
E.g., if you say *a friend of mine* you are talking about 1 of a number of friends whereas if you say *my friend* you are talking about 1 friend in particular.

**Example 1.3.25.** *He was an old friend of mine.*
*A student of yours has just been to see me.*
*David Lodge? I've just read a novel of his.*
*It was hinted to him by some friends of hers.*
*The room was not a favorite of theirs.*

1.110 For other ways of showing that something belongs to someone or is connected with them, see paragraphs **1.211–1.221**.

### 1.3.3 Referring back to the subject: reflexive pronouns

1.111 When you want to show that the object or the indirect object of a verb is the same person or thing as the subject of the verb, you use a **reflexive pronoun**.

Some verbs are very frequently used with reflexive pronouns.

For information about these, see paragraphs **3.26–3.31**.

Here is a table of reflexive pronouns:

| | **singular** | **plural** |
|---|---|---|
| **1st person** | myself | ourselves |
| **2nd person** | yourself | yourselves |
| **3rd person** | himself, herself, itself | themselves |

1.112 [!] Unlike personal pronouns and possessive pronouns, there are 2 forms of the reflexive pronoun used for the 2nd person.

You use *yourself* when you are talking to 1 person.

You use *yourselves* when you are talking to more than 1 person, or referring to a group that includes the person you are talking to.

1.113 You use a reflexive pronoun to make it clear that the object of a verb is the same person or thing as the subject of the verb, or to emphasize this.

E.g., *John killed himself* means that John did the killing, and he was also the person who was killed.

**Example 1.3.26.** *He forced himself to remain absolutely still.*
*She stretched herself out on the sofa.*
*I'm sure history repeats itself.*
*We all shook hands and introduced ourselves.*
*The boys formed themselves into a line.*
*Here is the question you have to ask yourselves.*

You also use reflexive pronouns to show or emphasize that the indirect object of a verb is the same person or thing as the subject of the verb.

E.g., in the sentence *Ann poured herself a drink*, Ann did the pouring and she was also the person who the drink was for.

**Example 1.3.27.** *Here's the money, you can go and buy yourself a watch.*

1.114 [!] Reflexive pronouns are not usually used with actions that people normally do to themselves, e.g. washing, dressing, or shaving.

So you do not usually say *He shaves himself every morning.*

You can, however, sometimes use reflexive pronouns with these actions for emphasis, or to talk about a surprising event, e.g. a child doing something that they were not previously able to do.

1.115 If the subject of a clause and the object of a preposition refer to the same person, and the clause does not have a direct object, you use a reflexive pronoun after the preposition.

**Example 1.3.28.** *I was thoroughly ashamed of myself.*
*Barbara stared at herself in the mirror.*
*We think of ourselves as members of the local community.*
*They can't cook for themselves.*

However, if the clause does have a direct object, you usually use a personal pronoun after the preposition.

**Example 1.3.29.** *I will take it home with me.*
*They put the book between them on the kitchen table.*
*I shivered and drew the rug around me.*
*Mrs Bixby went out, slamming the door behind her.*

Note that if the clause has a direct object and it is not obvious that the subject of the clause and the object of the preposition refer to the same person, you use a reflexive pronoun.

E.g., *The Managing Director gave the biggest pay rise to himself.*

1.116 Especially in speech, people sometimes use reflexive pronouns rather than personal pronouns as the object of a preposition, in order to emphasize them.

**Example 1.3.30.** *... people like myself who are politically active.*
*... the following conversation between myself and a 15-year-old girl.*
*The circle spread to include himself and Ferdinand.*
*People like yourself still find new things to say about Shakespeare.*
*There is always someone worse off than yourself.*
*With the exception of a few Algerians and ourselves, everyone spoke Spanish.*

1.117 You can use reflexive pronouns in addition to nouns to personal pronouns.
You usually do this in order to make it clear or to emphasize who or what you are referring to.

**Example 1.3.31.** *I myself sometimes say things I don't mean.*
*Sally herself came back.*

You also use a reflexive pronoun to compare or contrast 1 person or thing with another.

**Example 1.3.32.** *His friend looked as miserable as he felt himself.*
*It is not Des Moines I miss, but Iowa itself.*

The reflexive pronoun follows the noun or pronoun that it relates to.

**Example 1.3.33.** *It is hot in London; but I myself can work better when it's hot.*
*The town itself was so small that it didn't have a priest.*
*The lane ran right up to the wood itself.*

It can also be placed at the end of the clause.

**Example 1.3.34.** *I am not a particularly punctual person myself.*
*You'll probably understand better when you are a grandparent yourself.*
*It is rare for Governments to take the initiative themselves.*

1.118 You use a reflexive pronoun to emphasize that someone did something without any help or interference from anyone else.
In this use, the reflexive pronoun is normally placed at the end of the clause.

**Example 1.3.35.** *She had printed the card herself.*
*I'll take it down to the police station myself.*
*Did you make these yourself?*

### 1.3.4 People in general: generic pronouns

1.119 When you want to talk about people in general, you can use a **generic pronoun**.
Here is a list of pronouns that can be used as generic pronouns:

| | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| **Subject** | you | one | we | they |
| **Object** | you | one | us | them |
| **Possessive** | yours | - | ours | theirs |
| **Reflexive** | yourself | oneself | ourselves | themselves |

1.120 *You* is sometimes used to make statements about people in general, or about a person in a situation that you are imaging.
*You* is used in this way in both subject and object position.
The possessive form *yours* and the reflexive form *yourself* can also be used as generic pronouns.

**Example 1.3.36.** *To be a good doctor you need to have good communication skills.*
*Champagne can give you a headache.*
*Once you've bought a physical book, you own it: you can lend it to people, donate it, and, well, it's yours.*
*When you live alone you have to force yourself to go out more.*

In informal English, you can use *you get* or *you have* to make a general statement about something that exists in the world.

**Example 1.3.37.** *You get some old people who are very difficult.*
*Anytime you have over 8 inches of snow, driving becomes problematic.*

1.121 In formal writing, *one* is sometimes used instead of *you*.
*Once* can be used in subject or object position.
The reflexive form *oneself* is also used, but there is no possessive pronoun form of *one*.

**Example 1.3.38.** *Going round Italy, one is struck by the number of opera houses there are.*
*This scene makes one realize how deeply this community has been afflicted.*
*If one puts oneself up for public office, then it is inappropriate that one should behave badly.*

1.122 You can refer to a general group that includes yourself as *we* or, in object position, *us*.
This group can be all of mankind, or it can be smaller group e.g. a nation or a community.
The possessive form *ours* and the reflexive form *ourselves* can also be used in this way.

**Example 1.3.39.** *We all need money.*
*This survey gives us insight into our attitudes and behavior as a nation.*
*No other language has ever advanced as far, as fast, as ours.*
*We need a change of government; just riding ourselves of the prime minister isn't enough.*

1.123 You can use *they* to refer to people in general.

**Example 1.3.40.** *Isn't that what they call love?*

*They* can also refer to a group of people whose identity does not need to be stated.
E.g., in the sentence *They've given John another pay rise* it is clear that *they* refers to John's employers.

**Example 1.3.41.** *'Don't worry', I said to Mother, 'they are moving you from this ward soon.'*

You can also use *they* in subject position, or *them* in object position, to refer to an individual when you do not know, or do not want to specify, whether the individual is male or female.
The possessive form *theirs* and the reflexive form *themselves* can also be used in this way.
This use is very common after:

- the **indefinite pronouns** *anyone, anybody, someone* and *somebody*.

  These are explained in paragraphs **1.128–1.141**.

- singular nouns e.g. *person, parent* and *teacher*, which do not specify whether the person is male or female

  - If anyone wants to be a childminder, they must attend a course.
    If I think someone is having problems, I will spend hours talking to them.
    A person's body fat determines how long they can withstand cold water.

Note that the plural form of the verb is always used after *they*, even when it refers to only 1 person.
You can also use *they, them, theirs* and *themselves* to refer to:

- the **indefinite pronouns** *everyone, everybody, no one* and *nobody*.

  These are explained in paragraphs **1.128–1.141**.

- noun phrases with the determiners *each, every* and *any*.

In these cases, although the pronouns or noun phrases are grammatically singular, they refer to groups of people.

**Example 1.3.42.** *I never avoid my obligations and I expect everyone else to meet theirs.*
*Each parent was sent an individual letter informing them of the situation.*
*We want every player to push themselves to get into the team.*

Another way is to use *he or she* instead of *they, him or her* instead of *them, himself or herself* instead of *themselves* and *his or hers* instead of *theirs*.
This is often used in formal or written English.

**Example 1.3.43.** *Would a young person be able to get a job in Europe? That would depend on which country he or she wanted to go to.*
*The student should feel that the essay belongs to him or her.*

Some people use *he* and *him* in general statements or after indefinite pronouns, but many people object to this use because it suggests that person being referred to is male.

### 1.3.5 Referring to a particular person or thing: *this, that, these* and *those*

1.125 When *this, that, these*, and *those* are used as pronouns, they are used as the subject or the object of a clause, or the object of a preposition.

Demonstrative pronouns are rarely used as the indirect object of a clause, because the indirect object is usually a person, and demonstrative pronouns normally refer to things.

1.125 *This* and *that* are usually used as pronouns only when they refer to things.

You use them instead of a singular countable noun or an uncountable noun.

*This* refers to something that is close to you in place or time, and *that* refers to something that is more distant in place or time.

**Example 1.3.44.** *This is a list of the rules.*
*This is the most important part of the job.*
*The biggest problem was the accent. That was difficult for me.*
*That looks interesting.*

1.126 *This* and *that* are used as pronouns to refer to a person when you are identifying someone or asking who they are.

**Example 1.3.45.** *Who's this?*
*He stopped and looked at a photograph that stood on the dressing table. Is this your wife?*
*Was that Patrick on the phone?*

When you are introducing people, you can say *This is Mary* or *This is Mr and Mrs Baker.*

Note that you use *this* even when you are introducing more than 1 person.

1.127 *These* and *those* can be used as pronouns instead of a plural countable noun.

They are most often used to refer to things, although they can be used to refer to people.

*These* refers to a number of people and things that are close to you in place or time, and *those* refers to a number of people and things that are more distant in place or time.

**Example 1.3.46.** *'I brought you these.' Adam held out a bag of grapes.*
*Vitamin tablets usually contain vitamins A, C, and D. These are available from any child health clinic.*
*These are no ordinary students.*
*It may be impossible for them to pay essential bills, e.g. those for heating.*
*Those are easy questions to answer.*
*There are a lot of people who are seeking employment, and a great number of those are married women.*

*This, that, these*, and *those* can also be **definite determiners**.

For more information, see paragraphs **1.184–1.193**.
See also *Referring back* and *Referring forward* in Chap. 10.

### 1.3.6 Referring to people & things in a non-specific way: *someone, anyone, everyone*, etc.

1.128 When you want to refer to people or things but you do not know exactly who or what they are, or their identity is not important, you can use an **indefinite pronoun** e.g. *someone, anyone*, or *everyone.*

An indefinite pronoun shows only whether you are talking about people or about things, rather than referring to a specific person or thing.

**Example 1.3.47.** *I was there for over an hour before anybody came.*
*Jack was waiting for something.*

Here is a list of indefinite pronouns:

**Example 1.3.48.** *I was there for over an hour before anybody came.*
*Jack was waiting for something.*

Here is a list of indefinite pronouns:

**Example 1.3.49.** *anybody, anyone, anything, everybody, everyone, everything, nobody, no one, nothing, somebody, someone, something*

[**AE**] Note that all indefinite pronouns are written as 1 word except *no one.*

It is always 2 words in American English, but in British English it can also be spelled with a hyphen: *no-one.*

1.129 You always use singular verbs with indefinite pronouns.

**Example 1.3.50.** *Is anyone here?*
*Everybody recognizes the importance of education.*
*Everything was ready.*
*Nothing is certain in this world.*

1.130 You use the indefinite pronouns ending in *-thing* to talk about objects, ideas, situations, or activities.

**Example 1.3.51.** *Can I do anything?*
*Jane said nothing for a moment.*

1.131 You use the indefinite pronouns ending in *-one* and *-body* to refer to people.

**Example 1.3.52.** *It had to be someone like Dan.*
*Why does everybody believe in the law of gravity?*

Note that indefinite pronouns ending in *-body* are more frequent in informal English.
1.132 Although you use singular verbs with indefinite pronouns, if you want to refer back to an indefinite pronoun, you use the plural pronouns *they, them*, or *themselves*, or the possessive determiner *their*.

**Example 1.3.53.** *Ask anyone. They'll tell you.*
*There's no way of telling somebody why they've failed.*
*No one liked being young then as they do now.*
*Everybody's enjoying themselves.*
*Everyone put their pens down.*

See paragraph **1.123** for more information about *they* used to refer to 1 person.
**[i] Usage note.**
1.133 In more formal English, some people prefer to use *he, him, his*, or *himself* to refer back to an indefinite pronoun, but many people dislike this use because it suggests that the person being referred to is male.

**Example 1.3.54.** *If someone consistently eats a lot of fatty foods, it is not surprising if he ends up with clogged arteries.*
*Everybody has his dream.*

For other ways of using pronouns when you do not want to specify whether the person you are talking about is male or female, see paragraph **1.123**.
1.134 You add *'s* (apostrophe *s*) to indefinite pronoun to refer to things that belong to or are associated with people.

**Example 1.3.55.** *She was given a room in someone's studio.*
*That was nobody's business.*
*I would defend anyone's rights.*
*Everything has been arranged to everybody's satisfaction.*

1.135 [!] You do not usually add *'s* to indefinite pronouns referring to things.
So, e.g., you would be more likely to say *the value of something* than *something's value.*
1.136 When you want to give more information about the person or thing referred to by an indefinite pronoun, you can use a phrase or a clause after it.

**Example 1.3.56.** *Anyone over the age of 18 can apply.*
*He would prefer to have somebody who had a background in the humanities.*

1.137 You can also use adjectives to add information.
Note that adjectives are placed after the indefinite pronoun rather than in front of it, and that you do not use a determiner.
You do not say *an important someone*, you say *someone important.*

**Example 1.3.57.** *What was needed was someone practical.*
*They are doing everything possible to take care of you.*
*There is nothing wrong with being popular.*

1.138 If you have already mentioned a person or thing, and you want to refer to a different person or thing, or an additional one, you use *else* after an indefinite pronoun.

**Example 1.3.58.** *Somebody else will have to go out there.*
*She couldn't think of anything else.*
*Everyone knows what everyone else is doing.*
*He got that job because nobody else wanted it.*

Note that if you want to show association or possession with an indefinite pronoun and *else*, you add the *'s* to *else*.

**Example 1.3.59.** *Problems always became someone else's fault.*
*No one has control over anyone else's career.*

1.139 Just like nouns, indefinite pronouns are the subject, object, or indirect object of clauses.
They can also be used as the objects of prepositions.
The indefinite pronouns beginning with *some-* and *every-* are most often used in affirmative clauses.

**Example 1.3.60.** *Everything went according to plan.*
*I remember somebody putting a pillow under my head.*
*'Now you'll see something,' he said.*
*I gave everyone a generous helping.*
*I want to introduce you to someone who is helping me.*
*Is everything all right?*

They are sometimes used as the subject of a negative clause.

**Example 1.3.61.** *He could tell that something wasn't right.*

Note that the indefinite pronouns beginning with *some-* cannot be used as the object of a negative clause, unless they are followed by a phrase or a clause.

**Example 1.3.62.** *He wasn't someone I admired as a writer.*

1.140 Indefinite pronouns beginning with *any-* can be used as the object or indirect object of a question or a negative clause.

**Example 1.3.63.** *Don't worry - I won't tell anyone.*
*You still haven't told me anything.*
*Take a good look and tell me if you see anything different.*
*I haven't given anyone their presents yet.*

They are often used as the subject of both negative and affirmative questions.
Note that they are not used as the subject of a negative statement.
You do not say, e.g., *Anybody can't come in.*

**Example 1.3.64.** *Does anybody agree with me?*
*Won't anyone help me?*
*If anything unusual happens, could you call me on this number?*

Note that when you are making an affirmative statement, *anyone* and *anybody* are used to refer to people in general and not to only 1 person.

**Example 1.3.65.** *Anybody who wants to can come in and buy a car from me.*

1.141 Indefinite pronouns beginning with *no-* are always used with the affirmative form of a verb, and they make the clause negative.
For more information on **negative statements**, see paragraphs **5.49–5.93**.

**Example 1.3.66.** *Nobody said a word.*
*There was nothing you could do, nothing at all.*
*She was to see no one, to speak to nobody, not even her own children.*

Note that they are sometimes used in questions.
When this is the case, the answer to the question is usually expected to be *no*.

**Example 1.3.67.** *'Is there nothing I can do?' - 'Not a thing'.*
*'Is there nobody else?' - 'Not that I know of'.*

### 1.3.7 Showing that people do the same thing: *each other* & *one another*

1.142 *Each other* and *one another* are called **reciprocal pronouns**.

They are used to say that people do the same thing, feel the same way, or have the same relationship.

E.g., if your brother hates your sister and your sister hates your brother, you can say *My brother and sister hate each other* or *They hate one another.*

Reciprocal pronouns are not used as the subject of a clause.

You can use them as the object or indirect object of a verb.

**Example 1.3.68.** *We help each other a lot.*
*You and I understand each other.*
*We support one another through good times and bad.*
*They sent each other gifts from time to time.*

You also use them as the object of a preposition.

**Example 1.3.69.** *Terry and Mark were jealous of each other.*
*The 2 lights were moving towards one another.*
*They didn't dare to look at one another.*

Some verbs are very commonly used with reciprocal pronouns.

For more information about these, see paragraphs **3.68**–**3.72**.

1.143 Note that there is very little difference between *each other* and *one another.*

They are both used to talk about 2 or more people or things, although some people prefer the use of *each other* when there are only 2 people or things, and *one another* when there are more than 2.

1.144 In formal written English, you can also use *each* as the subject of a clause and *the other* as the object of a clause or preposition.

So, a more formal way of saying *They looked at each other* is *Each looked at the other.*

Note that *each* is always followed by a singular verb.

**Example 1.3.70.** *Each accuses the other of lying.*
*Each is unwilling to learn from the experience of the others.*

*Each* is also a determiner.

For more information about this, see paragraph **1.243**.

1.145 You add *'s* (apostrophe *s*) to *each other, one another*, and *the other* to form possessives.

**Example 1.3.71.** *I hope that you all enjoy each other's company.*
*Apes spend a great deal of time grooming one another's fur.*
*The males fight fiercely, each trying to seize the other's long neck in its beak.*

### 1.3.8 Joining clauses together: relative pronouns

1.146 When a sentence consists of a main clause followed by a **relative clause** introduced by *who, whom, which*, or *that*, these words are called **relative pronouns**.

Relative pronouns do 2 things at the same time.

Like other pronouns, they refer to someone or something that has already been mentioned.

At the same time they join clauses together.

For more information about relative clauses, see paragraphs **8.83**–**8.116**.

1.147 *Who* and *whom* always refer to people.

*Who* can be the subject of a relative clause.

**Example 1.3.72.** *... mathematicians who are concerned with very difficult problems.*

In the past, *whom* was normally used as the object of a relative clause.

Nowadays, *who* is more often used, although some careful speakers of English think that this is more correct to use *whom.*

**Example 1.3.73.** *... a man who I met recently.*
*He's the man who I saw last night.*
*... 2 girls whom I met in Edinburgh.*

*Who* is sometimes used as the object of a preposition when the object is separated from the preposition.

Some careful speakers think that it is more correct to use *whom.*

**Example 1.3.74.** *That's the man who I gave it to.*
*... those whom we cannot talk to.*

*Whom* is almost always used when the object comes immediately after the preposition.

**Example 1.3.75.** *... Lord Scarman, a man for whom I have immense respect.*

1.148 *Which* always refers to things.
It can be used as the subject or object of a relative clause, or as the object of a preposition.
*Which* is often used in British English to introduce relative clauses that refer to things.

**Example 1.3.76.** *... a region which was threatened by growing poverty.*
*... 2 horses which he owned.*
*... the house in which I was born.*

Note that which cannot be used as the indirect object of a clause.
1.149 *That* refers to either people or things.
It is used as the subject or the object of a relative clause or the object of a preposition.
*That* is generally preferred in American English to introduce relative clauses that refer to things or to combinations of people and things.

**Example 1.3.77.** *... the games that politicians play.*
*He's the boy that sang the solo last night.*
*It was the 1st bed that she had ever slept in.*

*That* cannot be used as the indirect object of a clause.
1.150 *Whose* shows who or what something belongs to or is connected with.
Note that it cannot be used by itself, but must come in front of a noun.

**Example 1.3.78.** *... the thousands whose lives have been damaged.*
*There was a chap there whose name I've forgotten.*
*... predictions whose accuracy will have to be determined.*
*... sharks, whose brains are minute.*

Note that *whose* is not restricted to people.

### 1.3.9 Asking questions: interrogative pronouns

1.151 1 way of asking questions i by using an **interrogative pronoun**.
The interrogative pronouns are *who, whose, whom, what*, and *which*.
They are used as the subject or object of a clause, or as the object of a preposition.
*Whose* and *which* are also determiners.
Other words, e.g. *where, when, why*, and *how*, are also used to ask questions.
Interrogative pronouns are not used as the indirect object of a clause.

**Example 1.3.79.** *Who was at the door?*
*'There's a cat outside.' - 'Whose is it?'*
*Whom do you support?*
*Which is best, gas or electric?*

For more information about structures in which interrogative pronouns are used, see paragraphs **5.10–5.36**.
1.152 Interrogative pronouns refer to the information you are asking for.
*Who, whose*, and *whom* are used when you think that the answer to the question will be a person.

**Example 1.3.80.** *'He lost his wife.' - 'Who? Terry?'*
*He looked at the cat. Whose is it? Have you ever seen it before?*
*'To whom, if I may ask, are you engaged to be married?' - 'To Danial Orton.'*

*Which* and *what* are used when you think that the answer to the question will be something other than a person.

**Example 1.3.81.** *Is there really a difference? Which do you prefer?*
*'What did he want?' - 'Maurice's address.'*

1.153 Interrogative pronouns are also used to introduce reported questions.

**Example 1.3.82.** *I asked her who she had been talking to.*
*He wondered what Daintry would do now.*

For more information about **reported questions**, see paragraphs **7.32–7.38**.

### 1.3.10 Other pronouns

1.154 Many other words can be pronouns, provided that it is clear what is being talked about, because it is then unnecessary to repeat the noun.

E.g., most **indefinite determiners** can also be pronouns.

For more information about indefinite determiners, see paragraphs **1.223–1.250**.

Here is a list of indefinite determiners that are also pronouns:

**Example 1.3.83.** *all, another, any, both, each, either, enough, few, fewer, less, little, many, more, most, much, neither, several, some*

Like all noun phrases, they can be used as the subject, direct object, or indirect object of a clause, or the object of a preposition.

**Example 1.3.84.** *Both were offered jobs immediately.*
*Children? I don't think she has any.*
*I saw 1 girl whispering to another.*

1.155 Although *a, an, every*, and *no* are indefinite determiners, they cannot stand alone as pronouns.

To refer back to a noun phrase that includes the determiner *a* or *an*, you can use the pronoun *one*.

Similarly, you use *each* to refer back to a noun phrase that includes *every*, and *none* to refer back to a noun phrase that includes *no*.

Note that *another* and *others* are pronouns, but *other* cannot be a pronoun.

1.156 *All, both*, and *each* can be used in addition to nouns or personal pronouns for emphasis, in a similar way to use of **reflexive pronouns** described in paragraphs **1.116–1.118**.

**Example 1.3.85.** *The brothers all agreed that something more was needed.*
*He loved them both.*
*Ford and Duncan each had their chances.*

They come after an auxiliary verb, a model, or *be*.

**Example 1.3.86.** *They were both still working at their universities.*
*The letters have all been signed.*
*The older children can all do the same things together.*

*Each* can also come at the end of the clause.

**Example 1.3.87.** *3 others were fined £200 each.*

1.157 **Numbers** can also be pronouns.

E.g., the answer to the question *How many children do you have?* is usually *3* rather than *3 children*.

**Example 1.3.88.** *'How many people are there?' - '45.'*
*Of the other women, 2 are dancers.*
*They bought 8 companies and sold of 5.*

For more information on numbers, see paragraphs **2.213–2.231**.

1.158 The number *one* is a special case.

Like other numbers, it is sometimes used to refer to 1 of a group of things.

*One* is also used to refer back to a noun phrase with the determiner *a*.

**Example 1.3.89.** *Could I have a bigger one, please?*

It can also be used for emphasis after another determiner.

**Example 1.3.90.** *There are systems of communication right through the animal world; each one is distinctive.*

*One* can be used as a **personal pronoun**.

This use is explained in paragraph **1.121**.

1.159 Note that *the one* and *the ones* can be used to refer to a noun alone, rather than to the whole of the noun phrase.

They are nearly always used with a modifier e.g. an adjective, or some form of information after the noun, e.g. a prepositional phrase.

**Example 1.3.91.** *'Which poem?' - 'The one they were talking about yesterday.'*
*There are 3 bedrooms. Mine is the one at the back.*
*He gave the best seats to the ones who arrived 1st.*

1.160 You use *the other, the others, others*, or *another* to refer to different members of a group of things or people.

**Example 1.3.92.** *Some writers are greater than others.*
*1 runner was way ahead of all the others.*

1.161 If you want to say something about a member of a group of people or things you can use *one*.
You can then refer to the rest of the group as *the others*.

**Example 1.3.93.** *The bells are carefully installed so that disconnecting one will have no effect on the others.*
*They had 3 little daughters, one a baby, the others twins of 12.*

You use *the one* and *the other* to refer to each of a pair of things.

**Example 1.3.94.** *The same factors push wages and prices up together, the one reinforcing the other.*

If you do not wish to specify exactly which of a group you are talking about, you refer to *one or other* of them.

**Example 1.3.95.** *It may be that one or other of them had fears for their health.*

## 1.4 Definite & indefinite determiners

1.162 In English, there are 2 main ways in which you can use a **noun phrase**.
You can use it to refer to someone or something, knowing that the person you are speaking to understands which person or thing you are talking about.

**Example 1.4.1.** *The man began to run towards the boy.*
*Young people don't like these operas.*
*Thank you very much for your comments.*
*. . . a visit to the Houses of Parliament.*

Alternatively, you can use a noun phrase to refer to someone or something of a particular type, without saying which person or thing you mean.

**Example 1.4.2.** *There was a man in the lift.*
*I wish I'd bought an umbrella.*
*Any doctor would say she didn't know what she was doing.*

In order to distinguish between these 2 ways of using a noun phrase, you use a special class of words called **determiners**.
There are 2 types of determiner, **definite determiners** and **indefinite determiners**.
You put them at the beginning of a noun phrase.

### 1.4.1 Using the definite determiner *the*

1.163 *The* is the most common definite determiner; it is sometimes called the **definite article**.
*This, that, these*, and *those* are often called **demonstratives** or **demonstrative adjectives**.
For more information on these, see paragraphs **1.184–1.193**.
*My, your, his, her, its, our* and *their* are **possessive determiners**.
They are also sometimes called **possessive adjectives** or just **possessives**.
For more information about these, see paragraphs **1.194–1.210**.
Here is the list of definite determiners:

**Example 1.4.3.** *the*
*this, that, these, those*
*my, your, his, her, its, our, their*

Note that in English you cannot use more than 1 definite determiner before a noun.
1.164 Because *the* is the most common definite determiner, you can put *the* in front of any common noun.

**Example 1.4.4.** *She dropped the can into the grass.*
*The girls were not in the house.*

In these examples, the use of *the can* means that a can has already been mentioned; *the grass* is definite because it has already been stated that *she* is outside, and the presence of grass may also have been stated or is presumed; *the girls*, like *the can*, must have been mentioned before; and *the house* means the one where the girls were staying at the time.
1.165 *The* always has the same spelling, but it has 3 different pronunciations:

- /ðə/ when the following word begins with a consonant sound

  **Example 1.4.5.** *... the dictionary... the 1st act... the big box*

- /ði/ when the following word begins with a vowel sound

  **Example 1.4.6.** *... the exhibition... the effect... the impression*

- /ðiː/ when it is emphasized

  **Example 1.4.7.** *You don't mean the Ernest Hemingway?*

See paragraph **1.181** for more information about emphatic uses of *the*.

1.166 You can use a noun phrase consisting just of *the* and a noun when you know that the person you are talking or writing to will understand which person, thing, or group you are referring to.

**Example 1.4.8.** *The expedition sailed out into the Pacific.*
*... the most obnoxious boy in the school.*
*He stopped the car in front of the bakery.*

1.167 Some nouns are used with *the* because they refer to only 1 person, thing, or group.

Some of these are specific names or **proper nouns**, e.g. titles e.g. *the Pope*, unique things e.g. *the Eiffel Tower*, and place names e.g. *the Atlantic*.

**Example 1.4.9.** *... a concert attended by the Queen.*
*We went on camel rides to the Pyramids.*

See paragraphs **1.52–1.58** for more information about proper nouns.

Some are **singular nouns**, that is they refer to something of which there is only 1 in the world, e.g. *the ground*, or *the moon*.

**Example 1.4.10.** *The sun began to turn red.*
*In Apr and May the wind blows steadily.*

See paragraphs **1.34–1.40** for more information about singular nouns.

1.168 Other nouns are used to talk about just 1 person, thing, or group in a particular place or organization, so that if you are talking about that place or organization or talking to someone in it, you can use just *the* and the noun.

E.g., if there is only 1 station in a town, the people who live in the town will talk about *the station*.

Similarly, people living in Britain talk to each other about *the economy*, meaning *the British economy*, and people working for the same organization might talk about *the boss, the union*, or *the canteen* without needing to specify the organization.

**Example 1.4.11.** *The church has been broken into.*
*There's a wind coming off the river.*
*We had to get rid of the director.*
*The mayor is a 48-year-old former laborer.*
*What is the President doing about all this?*

1.169 Normally, if you want to talk generally about all people or things of a particular type, you use the plural form of a noun without a determiner.

However, there are some countable nouns that are used in the singular with *the* to refer to something more general.

E.g., you can use *the theater* or *the stage* to talk about all entertainment performed in theaters.

Similarly, *the screen* refers to films in general, and *the law* refers to the system of laws in a country.

**Example 1.4.12.** *For him, the stage was just a way of earning a living.*
*He was as handsome in real life as he was on the screen.*
*They do not hesitate to break the law.*

Some nouns that normally refer to an individual thing or person can be used in the singular with *the* to refer generally to a system or service in a particular place.

E.g., you can use *the bus* to talk about a bus service and *the phone* to talk about a telephone system.

**Example 1.4.13.** *How long does it take on the train?*
*We rang for the ambulance.*

Nouns referring to musical instruments can be used in the singular with *the* when you are talking about someone playing, or being able to play, a particular kind of instrument.

**Example 1.4.14.** *You play the oboe, I see, said Simon.*
*I was playing the piano when he phoned.*

1.170 When you want to talk generally about groups of people who share the same characteristic or quality, you often choose an adjective preceded by *the*.

**Example 1.4.15.** *This project is all about giving employment to the unemployed.*

See paragraphs **.166–1.72** for more information about using adjectives as nouns.
1.171 Nouns referring to plants and animals can be used in the singular with *the* when you are making a statement about every member of a species.
E.g., if you say *The swift has long, narrow wings*, you mean that all swifts have long, narrow wings.

**Example 1.4.16.** *The primrose can grow abundantly on chalk banks.*
*Australia is the home of the kangaroo.*

Similarly, a noun referring to a part of the human body can be used with *the* to refer to that part of anyone's body.

**Example 1.4.17.** *These arteries supply the heart with blood.*
*. . . the arteries supplying the kidneys.*

*The* is sometimes used with other nouns in the singular to make a statement about all the members of a group.

**Example 1.4.18.** *The article focuses on how to protect the therapist rather than on how to cure the patient.*

These uses are fairly formal.
They are not common in ordinary speech.
Usually, if you want to make a statement about all the things of a particular kind, you use the plural form of a noun without a determiner.
See paragraph **1.227** for more information about this.
**[i] Usage note.**
1.172 Many common time expressions consist of just *the* and a noun.

**Example 1.4.19.** *We wasted a lot of money in the past.*
*The train leaves Cardiff at 4 in the afternoon.*
*. . . the changes which are taking place at the moment.*

See Chap. 4 for more information about time expressions.
1.173 In each of the paragraphs above showing uses of *the* and a noun, it is possible to understand who or what is being referred to because the noun phrase is commonly accepted as referring to 1 particular person, thing, or group.
However, you can use *the* with any noun, if it is obvious who or what you are referring to from what has already been said or written.
The usual way of referring back to a noun is to use a pronoun, but if the 2nd reference does not come immediately after the 1st one, or if it is not immediately obvious which noun is being referred to, you should use *the*, and the noun again.
E.g., if you have already mentioned that you were in a train, and then continued to tell a story, you can say afterwards *The train suddenly stopped.*
1.174 You can also use *the* and a noun when you are referring to someone or something closely connected with something you have just mentioned.
E.g., you do not usually say *We tried to get into the room, but the door of the room was locked.*
You say *We tried to get into the room, but the door was locked*, because it is obvious which door you are referring to.

**Example 1.4.20.** *She stopped and lit a match. The wind almost blew out the flame.*

1.175 Although there are many situations where you use just *the* and a noun, there are other occasions when you need to add something else to the noun in order to make it clear which person, thing, or group you are referring to.
1.176 Sometimes you can show who or what you are referring to by putting an **adjective** between *the* and the noun.

**Example 1.4.21.** *This is the main bedroom.*
*Somebody ought to have done it long ago, remarked the fat man.*

Sometimes you need to use more than 1 adjective.

**Example 1.4.22.** *After the crossroads look out for the large white building.*

For more information about adjectives, see paragraphs **2.2–2.168**.

1.177 When you use an adjective between *the* and a noun, you do not always do it in order to make clear who or what is being referred to.

E.g., you might want to add further information about someone or something that you have already mentioned.

So, if you 1st refer to someone as *a woman* in a sentence e.g. *A woman came into the room*, you might later want to refer to her as *the unfortunate woman* or *the smiling woman.*

This is a very common use in written English, especially in stories, but it is not often used in conversation.

**Example 1.4.23.** *The astonished waiter was now watching from the other end of the room.*
*The poor woman had witnessed terrible violence.*
*The loss of pressure caused the speeding car to go into a skid.*

1.178 Another way of showing who or what you are referring to is buy adding extra information after *the* and a noun, e.g. a prepositional phrase, a relative clause, a *to*-infinitive, an adverb of place or time, or a phrase introduced by a participle.

So you might refer to particular people at a party by using noun phrases e.g. *the girl in the yellow dress, the woman who spilled her drink*, or *the man smoking a cigar.*

**Example 1.4.24.** *The cars in the driveways were all Ferraris and Porsches.*
*The book that I recommend now costs over 20 pounds.*
*The thing to aim for is an office of your own.*
*Who made the bed in the room upstairs?*
*It depends on the person being interviewed.*

For more information about this type of extra information that is added to a noun, see paragraphs **2.272–2.302**.

1.179 You do not normally use *the* with **uncountable nouns** because they refer to something in a general way.

However, *the* is necessary if the uncountable noun is followed by extra information e.g. clause or a phrase that relates it to a particular person, thing, or group.

E.g., you cannot say *I am interested in education of young children*,

You have to say *I am interested in the education of young children.*

**Example 1.4.25.** *Babies need the comfort of their mother's arms.*
*Even the honesty of Inspector Butler was in doubt.*
*I've no idea about the geography of Scotland.*

For more information about uncountable nouns, see paragraphs **1.23–1.33**.

1.180 *The* is also used with **superlative adjectives**.

**Example 1.4.26.** *I'm not the best cook in the world.*
*They went to the most expensive restaurant in town.*

See paragraphs **2.112–2.122** for more information about superlative adjectives.

1.181 *The* is often used in front of a noun to indicate that someone or something is the best of its kind.

**Example 1.4.27.** *New Zealand is now the place to visit.*

You can also use *the* in front of a person's name to show that you are referring to the most famous person with that name.

**Example 1.4.28.** *You actually met the George Harrison?*

When you use *the* in either of these ways, you emphasize it and pronounce it /ðiː/.

1.182 *The* can be used in front of some **indefinite determiners**, usually to give an indication of amount or quantity.

These indefinite determiners are:

**Example 1.4.29.** *few, little, many, other*

**Example 1.4.30.** *... pleasures known only to the few.*
*... a coup under the leadership of the select few.*
*He was 1 of the few who knew where to find me.*
*We have done the little that is in our power.*

For more information about indefinite determiners, see paragraphs **1.223–1.250**.

1.183 *The* is used with *one* and *ones.*

**Example 1.4.31.** *I'm going to have the green one.*
*The shop was different from the ones I remembered.*
*. . . a pair of those old glasses, the ones with those funny square lenses.*

*The* is also used with other **numbers**.

**Example 1.4.32.** *It is a mistake to confuse the 2.*
*Why is she so different from the other 2?*

See paragraphs **2.208–2.239** for more information about numbers.

### 1.4.2 Definite determiners: using *this, that, these*, and *those*

1.184 You use the **definite determiners** *this, that, these*, and *those* to talk about people or things in a definite way.
You use *this* and *these* to talk about people and things that are close to you in place or time.
When you talk about people or things that are more distant in place or time, you use *that* and *those*.
You put *this* and *that* in front of singular nouns, uncountable nouns, and the singular pronoun one.
You put *these* and *those* in front of plural nouns and the plural pronoun *ones*.
*This, that, these*, and *those* are often called **demonstratives** or **demonstrative adjectives**.
1.185 *This* and *these* are used to talk about people or things that are very obvious in the situation that you are in.
E.g., if you are inside a house, you can refer to it as *this house*.
If you are holding some keys in your hand, you can refer to them as *these keys*.
If you are at a party, you can refer to it as *this party*.

**Example 1.4.33.** *I have lived in this house my entire life.*
*I am going to walk up these steps towards you.*
*I'll come as soon as these men have finished their work.*
*I like this university.*
*Good evening. In this programme we are going to look at the way in which British music has developed in recent years.*

When it is clear who or what you are referring to, you can use *this* and *these* as **pronouns**.
This use is explained in paragraphs **1.124–1.127**.
1.186 *This* and *these* are also used in many expressions that refer to current periods of time, e.g. *this month, this week*, and *these days*.
This use is explained in Chap. 4.
1.187 You use *that* and *those* when you are talking about things or people that you can see but that are not close to you.

**Example 1.4.34.** *How much is it for that big box?*
*Can I have one of those brochures?*
*Can you move those books off there?*

1.188 When it is clear who or what you are talking about, you can use *that* and *those* as **pronouns**.
This use is explained in paragraphs **1.124–1.127**.

**Example 1.4.35.** *Could you just hold that?*
*Please don't take those.*

**[i] Usage note.**
1.189 You can show that you are referring to the same person or thing you have just mentioned by using *this, that, these*, or *those* in front of a noun.
E.g., if you have just mentioned a girl, you can refer to her as *this girl* or *that girl* the 2nd time you mention here.
Normally, you use a **pronoun** to refer to someone or something you have just mentioned, but sometimes you cannot do this because it might not be clear who or what the pronoun refers to.

**Example 1.4.36.** *Students and staff suggest books for the library, and normally we're quite happy to get those books.*
*Their house is in a valley. The people in that valley speak about the people in the next valley as foreigners.*
*They had a lot of diamonds, and they asked her if she could possibly get these diamonds to Britain.*

The use of *this, that, those*, etc. to refer again to something that has already been mentioned is fully explained in paragraphs **10.7–10.10**.
1.190 In informal English, you can also use *that* and *those* in front of a noun to talk about people or things that are already known to the person you are speaking or writing to.

**Example 1.4.37.** *That idiot Antonio has gone and locked our cabin door.*
*Have they found those missing children yet?*
*Do you remember that funny little apartment?*

1.191 You can use *that* in front of a noun when you are talking about something that has just happened.

**Example 1.4.38.** *I knew that meeting would be difficult.*

*That* is used as a **pronoun** to talk about something that has just happened.
This use is explained in paragraphs **1.124–1.127**.
1.192 In more formal English, *those* can be used instead of *the* in front of a plural noun when the plural noun is followed by a **relative clause**.
In this use, the relative clause specifies exactly which group of people or things are being referred to.

**Example 1.4.39.** *... those workers who are employed in large enterprises.*
*The parents are not afraid to be firm about those matters that seem important to them.*

1.193 In informal spoken English, people sometimes use *this* and *these* in front of nouns even when they are mentioning someone or something for the 1st time.

**Example 1.4.40.** *And then this woman came up to me and she said, I believe you have a goddaughter called Celia Ravenscroft.*
*At school we had to wear these awful white cotton hats.*

### 1.4.3 Possessive determiners: *my, your, their*, etc.

1.194 You often want to show that a thing belongs to someone or that it is connected in some way with someone.
1 way of doing this is to use a word like *my, your*, and *their*, which tells you who something belongs to.
These words are called **possessive determiners**.

**Example 1.4.41.** *Are your children bilingual?*
*I remember his name now.*
*They would be welcome to use our library.*
*I'd been waiting a long time to park my car.*

1.195 There are 7 possessive determiners in English, and each one is associated with a particular personal pronoun:

| | **singular** | **plural** |
|---|---|---|
| **1st person** | my | our |
| **2nd person** | your | your |
| **3rd person** | his, her, its | their |

Personal pronouns are explained in paragraphs **1.95–1.106**.
1.196 [!] You do not spell the possessive *its* with an apostrophe.
*It's* is short for *it is*.
1.197 Possessive determiners, like other determiners, come after any words like *all* or *some of* (called **predeterminers**), and before any numbers or adjectives.

**Example 1.4.42.** *... all his letters.*
*... their next message.*
*... my little finger.*
*... our 2 lifeboats.*

See paragraph **1.251** for more information about predeterminers.
1.200 [!] When you want to draw attention to the fact that something belongs or relates to a particular person or thing, you can use the word *own* after the possessive determiner.

**Example 1.4.43.** *I helped him to some more water but left my own glass untouched.*
*Residents are allowed to bring their own furniture with them if they wish to do so.*
*Make your own decisions.*
*I heard it with my own ears.*
*She felt in charge of her own affairs.*

If you use a number or adjective in this structure, you put the number or adjective after *own*.

**Example 1.4.44.** *... their own 3 children.*
*The players provided their own white shorts.*

1.201 Possessive determiners do not always show that what follows them is actually possessed (or owned) by someone. Sometimes they just show that what follows is connected or associated with someone in some way.

**Example 1.4.45.** *They then turned their attention to other things.*
*... the vitality of our music and our culture.*
*In summer, hay fever interfaced with all her activities.*
*It's his brother who has the workshop.*

1.202 You can use a possessive determiner in front of a noun that refers to an action, in order to show who or what is doing the action.

**Example 1.4.46.** *... not long after our arrival.*
*... his criticism of the Government.*
*... their fight for survival.*
*I'm waiting for your explanation.*
*Most of their claims were worthy.*

In the last example, *their claims* refers to the claims that they have made.
1.203 You can also use a possessive determiner to say who or what is affected by an action.

**Example 1.4.47.** *My appointment as the 1st woman chairman symbolizes change.*
*... the redistribution of wealth, rather than its creation.*
*They expressed their horror at her dismissal.*

In the last example, *her dismissal* refers to the fact that she was dismissed by someone or by a company.
In the 1st of the following examples, *his supporters* means the people who support him.

**Example 1.4.48.** *... Birch and his supporters.*
*She returned the ring to its owner.*

**[i] Usage note.**
1.204 Sometimes in English the determiner *the* is used where there is an obvious possessive meaning.
In these cases the possession is already made clear by a preceding noun or pronoun.
The following paragraphs explain the situations in which you use *the* rather than a possessive determiner.
1.205 When you refer to a specific part of somebody's body, you normally use a possessive determiner.

**Example 1.4.49.** *She has something on her feet and a bag in her hand.*
*Nancy suddenly took my arm.*
*The children wore nothing on their feet.*
*She thanked him shyly and patted his arm.*
*I opened the cupboard and they fell on my head.*
*He shook his head.*

However, when you are describing an action that someone does a part of someone else's body, you often use the definite article (*the*), especially when the body part is the object of a preposition and when the object of the verb is a pronoun.
E.g., if you say *She hit me on the head, head* is the object of the preposition *on* and *me* is the object of the verb *hit*.

**Example 1.4.50.** *I patted him on the head*.
*He took her by the arm and began drawing her away.*

You use the definite article because the *owner* of the body part has already been identified, and you do not need to repeat this information.
Similarly, if the object of the verb is a **reflexive pronoun** e.g. *myself, yourself*, and so on, you use the definite article.
This is because the reflexive pronoun already refers to you or to the person who is doing the action, so you do not need to repeat this information by using a possessive determiner.

**Example 1.4.51.** *I accidentally hit myself on the head with the brush handle.*
*We can pat ourselves on the back for bringing up our children.*

Uses of reflexive pronouns are explained in paragraphs **1.111–1.118**.

1.206 If you want to describe something that you do to yourself or that someone else does to themselves, you normally use a possessive determiner.

**Example 1.4.52.** *She was brushing her hair.*
*'I'm going to brush my teeth,' he said.*
*She gritted her teeth and carried on.*
*He walked into the kitchen and shook his head.*

1.207 [!] You usually use possessive determiners when you refer to people or animals.
You do not usually use them to refer to things that are not alive.
It is, e.g., more usual to say *the door* or *the door of the room* than *its door*.

1.208 Possessive determiners are sometimes used to talk about things that belong to or are associated with people in general, in a similar way to generic pronouns.
For more information on **generic pronouns**, see paragraphs **1.119–1.123**.
*Your* can be used when you are talking about something that belongs to or is associated with people in general, or with a person in a situation that you are imagining.

**Example 1.4.53.** *Can eating a low-fat diet weaken your hair?*
*Going to the gym is good for your general health.*
*Part of the process involves discussing your decision with a career counselor.*

In more formal English, *one's* is sometimes used instead of *your*.

**Example 1.4.54.** *A satisfying job can bring structure and meaning to one's life.*

*Our* can be used to talk about all of mankind or society.

**Example 1.4.55.** *Being a child is not easy in our society.*

*Their* can be used to refer to a person when you do not know, or do not want to specify, whether that person is male or female.

**Example 1.4.56.** *The most important asset a person has is their ability to work.*
*Each winner received a plaque with their award title.*

1.209 There are other ways of showing that something is owned by or connected with someone or something else.
E.g., you can use *'s* (apostrophe *s*) or a prepositional phrase beginning with *of*.

**Example 1.4.57.** *Mary's daughter is called Elizabeth.*
*Very often the person appointed has no knowledge of that company's end product.*
*... the house of a rich banker in Paris.*
*In the opinion of the team, what would they consider to be absolutely necessary?*

1.210 Possessive determiners are also sometimes used in titles e.g. *Your Majesty* and *His Excellency*.
This use is explained in paragraph **1.56**.

### 1.4.4 The possessive form: apostrophe *s* (*'s*)

1.211 You usually show that something belongs to or is associated with a specific, named person by adding *'s* to the name of the person, and by placing this possessive form in front of the thing that belongs to them, or is associated with them.
E.g., if John owns a motorbike, you can refer to it is 'John's motorbike'.

**Example 1.4.58.** *Sylvia put her hand on John's arm.*
*... the main features of Mr Brown's economic policy.*

When you use a noun rather than a name to refer to the person, the noun phrase containing the possessive form also contains a determiner in the usual way.

**Example 1.4.59.** *... his grandmother's house.*
*Your mother's best handbag.*

Note that the determiner applies to the possessive form and not to the noun that is being modified by the possessive.

1.212 The spelling and pronunciation patterns used to form possessives change according to the spelling and pronunciation of the name or noun.

These are explained in the Reference section.

1.213 Note that in addition ot being the possessive form, the pattern *'s* can also be added to words as a contraction of *is* or *has*.

This is explained in the Reference section.

1.214 Apostrophe *s* (*'s*) is most often added to a noun referring to a person or an animal.

**Example 1.4.60.** *I wore a pair of my sister's boots.*
*Philip watched his friend's reaction.*
*Billy patted the dog's head.*

It can also be used to show that something belongs to or is associated with a group of people or an institution.

**Example 1.4.61.** *She runs the foreign exchange desk for the banks corporate clients.*
*They also prepare the university's budget.*
*... the paper's political editor, Mr Fred Emery.*
*There was a raid on the Democratic Party's headquarters.*
*What is your government's policy?*

1.215 Apostrophe *s* (*'s*) is sometimes added to a noun referring to an object when specifying a part of it or a quality or feature that it has.

**Example 1.4.62.** *I like the car's design.*
*You can predict a computer's behavior because it follows rules.*

Apostrophe *s* (*'s*) is used after nouns and names referring to places to specify something in that place.

**Example 1.4.63.** *He is the administrative head of the country's biggest city.*
*The city's population is in decline.*
*... Britain's most famous company.*

1.216 If you want to emphasize that something belongs or relates to a particular person and nobody else, you use *own*.

*Own* can be used after the possessive form of a name or noun, as well as after a possessive determiner.

**Example 1.4.64.** *Prof. Wilson's own answer may be unacceptable.*
*We must depend on David's own assessment.*

If you are specifying a number of things, you put the number after *own*.

**Example 1.4.65.** *... the Doctor's own 2 rooms.*

1.217 When you are talking about 2 things of the same type that belong to different people you can use the possessive form of a name or noun like a possessive pronoun so that you can avoid repeating the thing itself.

In the 1st example below, *her brother's* is used instead of *her brother's appearance*.

**Example 1.4.66.** *Her appearance is very different to her brother's.*
*My room is next to Karen's.*
*It is your responsibility rather than your parents'.*

The possessive form can also be used on its own to refer to someone's home or place of work.

**Example 1.4.67.** *He's round at David's.*
*She stopped off at the butcher's for a piece of steak.*
*She hasn't been back to the doctor's since.*

**Possessive pronouns** are explained in paragraphs **1.107–1.110**.

1.218 The possessive form can be used in a prepositional phrase beginning with *of* after a noun phrase.

You use this structure when you are talking about 1 of a number of things that belong to someone or are associated with them, rather than about something unique.

**Example 1.4.68.** *Julia, a friend of Jenny's, was there too.*
*That word has a favorite of of your father's.*

**[i] Usage note.**

1.219 Possessive forms can also be used to refer to things of a particular type that are usually associated with someone.

**Example 1.4.69.** *... a woman dressed in a man's raincoat.*
*... a policeman's uniform.*
*... women's magazines.*
*... the men's lavatory.*

1.220 The possessive form can sometimes be used with nouns that refer to an action in order to show who or what is performing the action.

**Example 1.4.70.** *... the banking service's rapid growth.*
*... Madeleine's arrival at Fairwater House School.*

Note that phrases beginning with *of* are used more commonly to do this, and that they are more formal than this use of possessive forms.

The use of prepositional phrases beginning with *of* to show who or what is performing an action is explained in paragraph **2.282**.

1.221 Sometimes you can add apostrophe *s* (*'s*) to a noun referring to the thing affected by the performer of an action and put it in front of the noun referring to that performer.

E.g., you can talk about *the scheme's supporters.*

**Example 1.4.71.** *... Christ's followers.*
*... the car's owner.*

Sometimes an apostrophe *s* (*'s*) structure can be used to refer to the thing affected by an action.

**Example 1.4.72.** *... Capello's appointment as England manager.*

Note again that *of* structures are more commonly used to do this.

1.222 It is also possible to show possession by using either a prepositional phrase beginning with *of*, or a structure with a noun modifier in it.

Prepositional phrases beginning with *of* are explained in paragraphs **2.277–2.283**.

Noun modifiers are explained in paragraphs **2.169–2.174**.

### 1.4.5 Indefinite determiners: *all, some, many*, etc.

1.223 **Indefinite determiners** are used in noun phrases when you are talking about people or things in a general way, without identifying them.

Here is a list of indefinite determiners:

**Example 1.4.73.** *a, all, an, another, any, both, each, either, enough, every, few, little, many, more, most, much, neither, no, other, several, some*

*A*, and *an* are the most common indefinite determiners; they are sometimes called the **definite article**.

For more information about *a* and *an*, see paragraphs **1.228–1.235**.

For more information about the other indefinite determiners, see paragraphs **1.236–1.250**.

1.224 *A* and *an* are used with singular countable nouns, and show that you are talking about just 1 person or thing.

*Another* is used with singular countable nouns and *other* with plural countable nouns, but only after 1 or more of the same type of person or thing has been mentioned.

*Any* can be used with singular and plural countable nouns to talk about 1 or more people or things.

You use *enough, few, many, more, most, several*, and *some* with plural countable nouns to show that you are talking about a number of people or things.

Each of these determiners indicates a different set or group within the total number.

For more information about their meanings, see the section beginning at paragraph **1.236**.

*All, both, each, either*, and *every* show that you are talking about the total number of people or things involved.

*Both* and *either* specify that only 2 people or things are involved.

*Both* is used with a plural noun, and *either* with a singular noun.

*All, each*, and *every* usually show that there are more than 2.

*All* is used with a plural noun, and *each* and *every* with a singular noun.

*No* and *neither* refer to the total number of things involved in negative statements.

*No* is used with singular or plural nouns, and *neither* only with singular nouns.

*No* and *neither* are covered in the section on **negative words** in Chap. 5.

For more information about **countable nouns**, see paragraphs **1.15–1.22**.

1.225 For uncountable nouns, *any, enough, little, more, most, much*, and *some* are used to talk about a quantity of something.

*No* and *all* indicate the total quantity of it.

For more information about **uncountable nouns**, see paragraphs **1.23–1.33**.

1.226 [!] *A, an, another, both, each, either, every, few, many, neither*, and *several* are not usually used with uncountable nouns.

1.227 When you are referring to things or people in an indefinite way, you can sometimes use a noun without a determiner.

**Example 1.4.74.** *... raising money from industry, government, and trusts.*
*Permission should be asked before visitors are invited.*

**Uncountable nouns** are usually used without a determiner.

**Example 1.4.75.** *Health and education are matters that most voters feel strongly about.*
*Wealth, like power, tends to corrupt.*

**Plural nouns** are used without a determiner when you are referring to all the people or things of a particular kind.

**Example 1.4.76.** *Dogs need a regular balanced diet, not just meat.*
*Are there any jobs that men can do that women can't?*

Plural nouns can also be used without a determiner to talk about an unspecified number of things.

**Example 1.4.77.** *Teachers should read stories to children.*
*Cats and dogs get fleas.*

For more information about plural nouns, see paragraphs **1.41–1.46**.

### 1.4.6 *A* & *an*

1.228 *A* and *an* are the most common **indefinite determiners**.

They are used for talking about a person or thing when it is not clear or not important which one is intended.

You put *a* or *an* in front of the singular form of a **countable noun**.

**Example 1.4.78.** *He's bought the children a puppy.*
*He was eating an apple.*
*An old lady was calling to him.*

1.229 You use *a* when the following word begins with a consonant sound.

**Example 1.4.79.** *... a piece... a good teacher... a language class.*

This includes some words that begin with a vowel in their written form, because the 1st sound is a *y* sound, /j/.

**Example 1.4.80.** *... a university... a European language.*

You use *an* when the following word begins with a vowel sound.

**Example 1.4.81.** *... an example... an art exhibition... an early train.*

This includes some words that begin with the letter *h* in their written form, because the *h* is not pronounced.

**Example 1.4.82.** *... an honest politician... quarter of an hour.*

*A* is usually pronounced /ə/.
*An* is usually pronounced /ən/.

1.230 People often say that you use *a* or *an* when you are mentioning something for the 1st time, but this is not a very helpful rule because there are so many situations where you use *the* for the 1st mention of something.

See, e.g., paragraphs **1.166**, **1.167–1.168**.

You usually use *a* or *an* when it is not clear or not important which specific person or thing is being referred to.

**Example 1.4.83.** *She picked up a book.*
*After weeks of looking, we eventually bought a house.*
*A colleague and I got some money to do research on rats.*

1.231 Sometimes, *a* or *an* is simply followed by a noun.

**Example 1.4.84.** *I got a postcard from Susan.*
*The FBI is conducting an investigation.*

But if you want to add extra information, you can add an adjective, or a following clause or phrase.

**Example 1.4.85.** *I met a Swedish girl on the train from Copenhagen.*
*I've been reading an interesting article in The Economist.*
*We had to write a story about our parents' childhood.*
*I chose a picture that reminded me of my own country.*

1.232 You can alos use *a* or *an* after a **linking verb**.

**Example 1.4.86.** *She is a model and an artist.*
*His father was an alcoholic.*
*Noise was considered a nuisance.*
*His brother was a sensitive child.*

For more informative about linking verbs, see Chap. 3.

1.233 Sometimes, *a* or *an* are used with an uncountable noun, especially one that relates to human emotions or mental activity.

This only happens when the uncountable noun is limited by an adjective, or a phrase or clause giving more information.

**Example 1.4.87.** *A general education is perhaps more important than an exact knowledge of some particular theory.*
*She had an eagerness for life.*

1.234 You can use *a* or *an* with a noun when you are using 1 individual person or thing to make a general statement about all people or things of that type.

E.g., if you say *A gun must be kept in a safe place*, you are talking about an individual gun in order to make a general statement about all guns.

**Example 1.4.88.** *A computer can only do what you program it to do.*
*A dog likes to eat far more meat than a human being.*
*An unmarried mother was looked down on.*

This is not the usual way of referring to groups.

Normally, if you want to make a statement about all the people or things of a particular kind, you use the plural form of a noun without a determiner.

See paragraph **1.227** for more information about this.

1.235 *A* and *an* sometimes used with **singular nouns** e.g. *sun, moon*, and *sky* that refer to just 1 thing.

You normally use *the* with these nouns, but you use *a* or *an* when you are drawing attention to some special feature by adding a modifier or a following phrase or clause to the noun.

This use is particularly common in literature.

**Example 1.4.89.** *We drove under a gloomy sky.*
*A weak sun shines on the promenade.*

For more information on singular nouns, see paragraphs **1.34–1.40**.

### 1.4.7 Other indefinite determiners

1.236 *Some* is usually used to show that there is a quantity of something or a number of things or people, without being precise.

It is used with uncountable nouns and plural countable nouns.

*Some* is usually used in affirmative statements.

**Example 1.4.90.** *There is some evidence that the system works.*
*There's some chocolate cake over there.*
*I had some good ideas.*

*Some* can be used in questions, when you expect the answer to be *yes*.

**Example 1.4.91.** *Could you give me some examples?*
*Would you like some coffee?*

*Some* is also used to mean quite a large amount or number.
E.g., in *I did not meet her again for some years, some* means almost the same as *several* or *many.*

**Example 1.4.92.** *You will be unable to restart the car for some time.*
*It tool some years for Dan to realize the truth.*

1.237 You can also use *some* in front of numbers, in slightly more literary English, to show that you are not being totally accurate.

**Example 1.4.93.** *I was some 15 miles by sea from the nearest village.*
*. . . an animal weighing some 5 tons.*

1.238 When you want to emphasize that you do not know the identity of a person or thing, or you think their identity is not important, you can use *some* with a singular countable noun, instead of *a* or an.

**Example 1.4.94.** *Most staff members will spend a few weeks in some developing country.*
*Supposing you had some eccentric who came and offended you a thousand pounds.*

1.239 *Any* is used before plural nouns and uncountable nouns when you are referring to a quantity of something that may or may not exist.

**Example 1.4.95.** *The patients know their rights like any other consumers.*
*Check online if you're in any doubt.*
*You can stop at any time you like.*

*Any* is also used in questions asking whether something exists or not.
It is also used in negative statements to say that something does not exist.

**Example 1.4.96.** *Do you have any advice on that?*
*Do you have any vacancies for bar staff?*
*It hasn't made any difference.*
*Nobody in her house knows any English.*
*I range up to see if there were any tickets left.*

Questions and negative statements are explained further in Chap. 5.
Note that you can use *any* with singular countable nouns to talk about someone or something of a particular type, when you do not want to mention a specific person or thing.

**Example 1.4.97.** *Any big tin container will do.*
*Cars can be rented at almost any US airport.*

*Any* can also be used as a **pronoun**.
See paragraphs **1.93–1.161** for more information about pronouns.
It is also used in ***if*-clauses**.
For more information about these, see Chap. 8.
1.240 *Another* is used with singular countable nouns to talk about an additional person or thing of the same type as you have already mentioned.

**Example 1.4.98.** *Could I have another cup of coffee?*
*He opened another shop last month.*

It can also be used before numbers to talk about more than 1 additional thing.

**Example 1.4.99.** *Margaret staying with us for another 10 days.*
*5 officials were sacked and another 4 arrested.*

*Other* is used with plural nouns, or occasionally with uncountable nouns.

**Example 1.4.100.** *Other people must have thought like this.*
*They are either asleep or entirely absorbed in play or other activity.*

1.241 *Enough* is used to say that there is as much of something as is needed, or as many things as are needed.
You can therefore use *enough* in front of uncountable nouns or plural nouns.

**Example 1.4.101.** *There's enough space for the children to run around.*
*They weren't getting enough customers.*

*Many* indicates that there is a large number of things, without being very precise.
You use *many* with a plural countable noun.

**Example 1.4.102.** *He spoke many different languages.*

When you want to emphasize that there is only a small number of things of a particular kind, you use *few* with a plural countable noun.

**Example 1.4.103.** *There are few drugs that act quickly enough to be effective.*
*There were few doctors available.*

*Few* is quite formal.
In less formal English, you can use *not many* with the same meaning.

**Example 1.4.104.** *There aren't many gardeners like him.*

*Most* indicates nearly all of a group or amount.
You use *most* with an uncountable noun or a plural countable noun.

**Example 1.4.105.** *Most people recover but the disease can be fatal.*
*Most farmers are still using the old methods.*

*Several* usually indicates an imprecise number that is not very large, but is more than 2.
You use *several* with a plural countable noun.

**Example 1.4.106.** *Several projects had to be postponed.*
*I had seen her several times before.*
*There were several reasons for this.*

1.242 *All* includes every person or thing of a particular kind.
You use *all* with an uncountable noun or a plural countable noun.

**Example 1.4.107.** *They believe that all prisoners should be treated the same.*

*Both* is used to say something about 2 people or things of the same kind.
You use *both* with a plural countable noun.
The 2 people or things have usually been mentioned or are obvious from the context.
*Both* is sometimes used to emphasize that 2 people or things are involved, rather than just 1.

**Example 1.4.108.** *There were excellent performances from both actresses.*
*Denis held his cocoa in both hands.*

*Either* is also used to talk about 2 things, but usually indicates that only 1 of the 2 is involved.
You use *either* with a singular countable noun.
When it is part of the subject of a clause, the verb is in the singular.

**Example 1.4.109.** *No argument could move either old gentleman from this decision.*
*If either parent has the disease, there is a much higher chance that the child will develop it.*

Note that *either* can mean both of 2 things, especially when it is used with *end* and *side*.

**Example 1.4.110.** *They stood on either side of the bed.*

1.243 You use *each* and *every* when you are talking about all the members of a group of people or things.
You use *each* when you are thinking about the members as individuals, and *every* when you are making a general statement about all of them.
*Each* and *every* are followed by a singular countable noun.

**Example 1.4.111.** *Each seat was covered with a white lace cover.*
*They would rush out to meet each visitor.*
*This new wealthy can be seen in every village.*
*Every child would have milk every day.*
*Each applicant has 5 choices.*
*I agree with every word Peter says.*

You can modify *every* but not *each*.

You can say things e.g. *Almost every chair is broken* or *Not every chair is broken* but you cannot say *Almost each chair is broken* or *Not each chair is broken*.

This is because *each* is slightly more precise and definite than *every*.

Note that *each* can be used when talking about 2 people or things, but *every* is only used for numbers larger than 2.

1.244 If you want to emphasize that there is only a small amount of something, you use *little*.

You use *much* to emphasize a large amount.

*Little* and *much* are used with uncountable nouns.

*Little* is used only in affirmative statements.

It is not used in questions or negatives.

**Example 1.4.112.** *There was little applause.*
*We've made little process.*
*We have very little information.*

*Little* is quite formal.

In less formal contexts, *not much* is more common.

E.g., instead of saying *We've made little progress*, you can say *We haven't made much progress.*

*Much* is usually used in questions and negatives.

**Example 1.4.113.** *Do you watch much television?*
*He did not speak much English.*

*Very much* is used only in negative statements.

E.g., *I don't have very much sugar* means *I have only a small quantity of sugar.*

**Example 1.4.114.** *I haven't given very much attention to this problem.*

*Much* is used in affirmative statements when it is modified by an adverb e.g. *too, so* or *as.*

**Example 1.4.115.** *It would take too much time.*
*Provide as much information as you can about the property.*

In more formal English, *much* can be used in affirmative statements without an adverb.

This usage is most common with abstract nouns, particularly those relating to discussion, debate and research.

**Example 1.4.116.** *The subject of company annual accounts is generating much debate among accountants and analysts.*
*The team's findings have caused much excitement among medical experts.*
*After much speculation, intelligence agencies now believe that he survived.*

Usually, though, *much* is not used in affirmative statements.

Instead, people generally use *a lot of* and, in less formal texts, *lots of.*

E.g., people would not usually say *I have much work to do;* instead, they would say *I have a lot of work to do.*

For more information on *a lot of*, see **2.176**.

1.245 Some other words can be indefinite determiners, e.g. *certain, numerous*, and *various.*

You use *certain, numerous* and *various* with a plural countable noun.

*Certain* is used to refer to some members of a group, without specifying which ones.

**Example 1.4.117.** *We have certain ideas about what topics are suitable.*

*Numerous*, like *many*, indicates a large number in an imprecise way.

**Example 1.4.118.** *I have received numerous requests for information.*

*Various* is used to emphasize that you are referring to several different things or people.

**Example 1.4.119.** *We looked at schools in various European countries.*

1.246 There are 3 comparatives that are determiners.

*More* is used in front of plural and uncountable nouns, usually with *than*, to refer to a quantity or amount of something that is greater than another quantity or amount.

**Example 1.4.120.** *He does more hours than I do.*
*His visit might do more harm than good.*

But *more* is also often used to refer to an additional quantity of something rather than in comparisons.

**Example 1.4.121.** *More teachers need to be recruited.*
*We need more information.*

*Less* is used to refer to an amount of something that is smaller than another amount.
*Fewer* is used to refer to a group of things that is smaller than another group.
*Less* is usually used before uncountable nouns and *fewer* before plural nouns, but in informal English *less* is also used before plural nouns.

**Example 1.4.122.** *The poor have less access to education.*
*... machinery which uses less energy.*
*As a result, he found less time than he would have hoped for his hobbies.*
*There are fewer trees here.*

For more information about **comparison**, see paragraphs **2.103–2.139**.
1.247 Some other expressions also behave like indefinite determiners: *a few, a little, a good many, a great many.*
These have a slightly different meaning from the single word determiners *few, little*, and *many.*
If you are mentioning a small number of things, but without any emphasis, you can use *a few* with plural countable nouns.

**Example 1.4.123.** *They went to San Diego for a few days.*
*A few years ago we set up a factory.*
*I usually do a few jobs for him in the house.*

Similarly, if you are just mentioning a small amount of something without any emphasis, you can use *a little* with uncountable nouns.

**Example 1.4.124.** *He spread a little honey on a slice of bread.*
*I have to spend a little time in Oxford.*
*Charles is having a little trouble.*

However, *a good many* and *a great many* are more emphatic forms of *many.*

**Example 1.4.125.** *I haven't seen her for a good many years.*
*He wrote a great many novels.*

1.248 Some indefinite determiners can be modified by *very, too*, and *far*, or sometimes by another indefinite determiner.
You can modify *more* with numbers or with other indefinite determiners.

**Example 1.4.126.** *Downstairs there are 4 more rooms.*
*There had been no more accidents.*
*You will never have to do any more work.*

You can use too many or *too much* to say that a quantity is more than is wanted or needed, and *too few* or *too little* if it is not enough.

**Example 1.4.127.** *There were too many competitors.*
*They gave too much power to the Treasury.*
*There's too little literature involved.*

You can use *very* before *few, little, many*, and *much.*
You can also say *a very little* or *a very great many.*

**Example 1.4.128.** *Very many women have made their mark on industry.*
*Very few cars had reversing lights.*
*I had very little money left.*

1.249 You use *one* as a determiner when you have been talking or writing about a group of people or things and you want to say something about a particular member of the group.
*One* is used instead of *a* or *an* and is slightly more emphatic.

**Example 1.4.129.** *We had 1 case that dragged on for a couple of years.*
*They criticize me all the time, wrote 1 woman.*
*I know 1 household where that happened, actually.*

The use of *one* as a **number** is explained in paragraphs **2.214–2.215**.

1.250 Many determiners are also **pronouns**; i.e., they can be used without a following noun.
For more information about these, see paragraphs **1.154–1.161**.

1.251 Normally, a determiner is the 1st word in a noun phrase.
However, there is a class of words called **predeterminers** which can come in front of a determiner.
Here is a list of predeterminers:

**Example 1.4.130.** *all, both, double, half, many, quarter, twice*
*quite, rather, such, what*

The 1st group are used to talk about amounts or quantities.
*All* can also be used to refer to every part of something.
When used with this meaning it is used with an uncountable noun.

**Example 1.4.131.** *<u>All</u> the boys started to giggle.*
*He will give you <u>all</u> the information.*
*<u>All</u> these people knew each other.*
*I shall miss <u>all</u> my friends.*
*I invited <u>both</u> the boys.*
*<u>Both</u> these parties shared 1 basic belief.*
*She paid <u>double</u> the sum they asked for.*
*I'm getting <u>twice</u> the pay I used to get.*

In the 2nd group, *quite* and *rather* can be used either to emphasize or to reduce the effect of what is being said.
In speech, the meaning is made clear by your tone of voice.
In writing, it is sometimes difficult to know which meaning is intended without reading more of the text.

**Example 1.4.132.** *It takes <u>quite</u> a long time to get a divorce.*
*It was <u>quite</u> a shock.*
*Seaford is <u>rather</u> a pleasant town.*
*It was <u>rather</u> a disaster.*

*Such* and *what* are used for emphasis.

**Example 1.4.133.** *He has <u>such</u> a beautiful voice.*
*<u>What</u> a mess!*

# Chapter 2

# Giving information about people & things: adjectives, numbers, & other modifiers

## 2.1 Introduction

2.1 In the previous chapter the use of nouns, pronouns, and determiners to name and identify people and things was explained.

This chapter explains ways of giving more information about the people and the things that have already been named or identified.

1 way of giving more information within a noun phrase about people or things is by the use of an **adjective**, e.g. *small, political*, or *blue*.

Adjectives can be used as modifiers of a noun or after linking verbs.

They are explained in paragraphs **2.2–2.168**.

Sometimes, **nouns**, rather than adjectives, are used to modify the noun.

This is explained in paragraphs **2.169–2.174**.

There are other groups of words that are used before a noun phrase to give more information about people and things.

They are linked to the noun phrase by *of*.

These include certain **indefinite determiners** e.g. *many of* and *some of* (explained in paragraphs **2.176–2.193**), and other expressions that are used for describing a part or amount of something, e.g. *a piece of* and *a bottle of* (explained in paragraphs **2.194–2.207**).

**Numbers** and **fractions** are also used to indicate the amount of people or things you are talking about.

Numbers are explained in paragraph **2.208–2.239** and fractions are explained in paragraphs **2.250–2.249**.

The other way of giving more information within a noun phrase about people or things is by using a **qualifier**, i.e., giving extra information in the form of a phrase or a clause after the noun to expand its meaning.

This is explained in paragraphs **2.272–2.302**.

## 2.2 Describing people & things: adjectives

2.2 When you want to give more information about something than you can give by using a noun alone, you can use an **adjective** to identify it or describe it in more detail.

**Example 2.2.1.** *... a new idea.*

*... new ideas.*

*... new creative ideas.*

*Ideas are important.*

*... to suggest that new ideas are useful.*

2.3 The most important things to notice about an adjective in English are

- what structure it is in (e.g. before a noun or after a linking verb)
- what type of adjective it is (e.g. describing a quality or placing the noun in a particular class).

2.4 [!] The form of an adjective does not change: you use the same form for singular and plural and for subject and object.

**Example 2.2.2.** *We were looking for a good place to camp.*
*The next good place was 45 miles further on.*
*Good places to fish were hard to find.*
*We found hardly any good places.*

2.5 Adjectives are nearly always used in connection with a noun or pronoun to give information about the person, thing, or group that is being referred to.

When this information is not the main purpose of a statement, adjectives are placed in front of a noun, as in *hot coffee*.

The use of adjectives in a noun phrase is explained in paragraph **2.19**.

2.6 Sometimes, however, the main purpose of a statement is to give the information expressed by an adjective.

When this happens, adjectives are placed after a **linking verb** e.g. *be* or *become*, as in *I am cold* and *He became ill*.

The use of adjectives after a linking verb is explained in paragraphs **3.122**–**3.137**.

2.7 There is a large group of adjectives that identify qualities that someone or somethings has.

This group includes words e.g. *happy* and *intelligent*.

These are called **qualitative adjectives**.

Qualitative adjectives are explained in paragraphs **2.22**–**2.25**.

2.8 There is another large group of adjectives that identify someone or something as a member of a class.

This group includes words e.g. *financial* and *intellectual*.

These are called **classifying adjectives**.

Classifying adjectives are explained in paragraphs **2.26**–**2.28**.

Some adjectives are both qualitative and classifying.

These are explained in paragraph **2.29**.

2.9 There is a small group of adjectives that identify the color of something.

This group includes words like *blue* and *green*.

They are called **color adjectives**.

Color adjectives are explained in paragraphs **2.30**–**2.35**.

2.10 Another small group of adjectives are used to emphasize your feelings about the person or thing you are talking about.

These adjectives are called **emphasizing adjectives**, and they include adjectives e.g. *complete, absolute*, and *utter*.

Emphasizing adjectives are explained in paragraphs **2.36**–**2.39**.

2.11 There is a small group of adjectives that are used in a very similar way to **determiners** (see paragraphs **1.162**–**1.251**) to make the reference more precise.

These are called **postdeterminers** because their place in a noun phrase is immediately after the determiner, if there is one, and before any other adjectives.

Postdeterminers are explained in paragraph **2.40**.

2.12 Most adjectives can be used either before the noun or after a linking verb.

However, there are some that can be used only in 1 position or the other.

This is explained in paragraphs **2.41**–**2.53**.

2.13 There are a few adjectives that can be used immediately after the noun.

They are explained in paragraphs **2.58**–**2.62**.

2.14 When 2 or more adjectives are used in a structure, they usually occur in a particular order.

This is explained in paragraphs **2.54**–**2.57**.

2.15 There are a large number of English adjectives ending in *-ing*, many of which are related to the ***-ing* participle** of a verb.

In this grammar they are called ***-ing* adjectives**.

There are also a large number of English adjectives ending in *-ed*, many of which are related to the ***-ed* participle** of a verb.

In this grammar they are called ***-ed* adjectives**.

*-ing* adjectives are explained in paragraphs **2.63**–**2.76**.

*-ed* adjectives are explained in paragraphs **2.77**–**2.93**.

2.16 **Compound adjectives** are made up of 2 or more words, usually written with hyphens between them.

Compound adjectives are explained in paragraphs **2.94**–**2.102**.

2.17 When you want to compare the amount of a quality that 2 or more people or things have, you can use **comparative** and **superlative** adjectives.

There are also some other ways of comparing things.

Comparatives are explained in paragraphs **2.103**–**2.111**, and superlatives are explained in paragraphs **2.113**–**2.122**.

Other ways of comparing things are explained in paragraphs **2.123**–**2.139**.

2.18 You can also talk about the amount of a quality that something or someone has by using an adverb like *totally* or *mildly* with an adjective.

This is explained in paragraphs **2.141**–**2.168**.

### 2.2.1 Adjective structures

2.19 Adjectives are used in 2 main structures.

1 of them involves adjectives coming before the noun phrase.

If you say *Julia was carrying an old suitcase*, you main purpose is to say that Julia was carrying a suitcase.

The adjective *old* gives more information about what kind of suitcase it was.

**Example 2.2.3.** *He was wearing a white t-shirt.*
*. . . a technical term.*
*. . . a pretty little star-shaped flower bed.*

Most adjectives can be used in this way.

2.20 The other main structure involves adjectives being used after **linking verbs** e.g. *be* and *become*.

Putting an adjective after a linking verb has the effect of focusing attention on the adjective.

If you say *The suitcase she was carrying was old*, your main purpose is to describe the suitcase, so the focus on the adjective *old*.

**Example 2.2.4.** *The roads are busy.*
*The house was quiet.*
*He became angry.*
*I feel cold.*
*Nobody seemed amused.*

The use of adjectives after linking verbs is explained in paragraphs **3.132–3.137**.

Most adjective can be used in this way.

2.21 In the following examples, the 1st example in each pair shows an adjective being used before the noun, while the 2nd example shows it being used with a linking verb.

**Example 2.2.5.** *There was no clear evidence.*
*'That's very clear,' I said.*
*It has been a pleasant evening.*
*It's not a big stream, but it's very pleasant.*
*She bought a loaf of white bread.*
*The walls were white.*

### 2.2.2 Identifying qualities: *a sad story, a pretty girl*

2.22 There are 2 main types of adjective, **qualitative** and **classifying**.

Adjectives that describe a quality that someone or something has, e.g. *sad, pretty, small, happy, healthy, wealthy*, and *wise*, are called **qualitative adjectives**.

**Example 2.2.6.** *. . . a sad story.*
*. . . a pretty girl.*
*. . . a small child.*
*. . . a happy mother with a healthy baby.*
*. . . a wealthy bankers.*
*I think it would be wise to give up.*

2.23 Adjectives that describe qualities are **gradable**, which means that the person or thing referred to can have more or less of the quality mentioned.

2.24 The usual way in which you show the amount of a quality that something or someone has is by using adverbs like *very* and *rather* in front of qualitative adjectives.

This is explained in paragraphs **2.140–2.156**.

2.25 The other way in which you can talk about the amount of a quality that something or someone has is by using a **comparative**, e.g. *bigger* and *more interesting*, or a **superlative**, e.g. *the biggest* and *the most interesting*.

Comparatives and superlatives are explained in paragraphs **2.103–2.122**.

Here is a list of qualitative adjectives:

**Example 2.2.7.** *active, angry, anxious, appropriate, attractive, bad, beautiful, big, brief, bright, broad, busy, calm, careful, cheap, clean, clear, close, cold, comfortable, common, complex, cool, curious, dangerous, dark, dear, deep, determined, different, difficult, dirty, dry, easy, effective, efficient, expensive, fair, familiar, famous, fast, fat, fine, firm, flat, frank, free, fresh, friendly, frightened, funny, good, great, happy, hard, heavy, high, hot, important, interesting, kind, large, late, light,*

*likely, long, loose, loud, lovely, low, lucky, narrow, nervous, new, nice, obvious, odd, old, pale, patient, plain, pleasant, poor, popular, powerful, pretty, proud, quick, quiet, rare, reasonable, rich, rough, sad, safe, sensible, serious, sharp, shocked, short, sick, significant, silly, simple, slow, small, soft, special, steady, strange, strong, stupid, successful, suitable, sure, surprised, sweet, tall, terrible, thick, thin, tight, tiny, tired, typical, understanding, useful, violent, warm, weak, wet, wide, wild, worried, young*

### 2.2.3 Identifying type: *financial help, abdominal pains*

2.26 The other main type of adjective consists of adjectives that you use to identify the type or *class* that something belongs to.

E.g., if you say *financial help*, you are using the adjective *financial* to describe what type of help you are talking about (i.e., to *classify* help).

Adjectives that are used in this way are called **classifying adjectives**.

**Example 2.2.8.** ... *financial help.*
... *abdominal pains.*
... *a medieval manuscript.*
... *my daily shower.*
... *an equal partnership.*
... *a sufficient amount of milk.*

Note that **noun modifiers** (see paragraphs **2.169–2.174**) are used in a similar way to classifying adjectives.

E.g., *financial matters* and *money matters* are similar in both structure and meaning.

Here is a list of classifying adjectives:

**Example 2.2.9.** *absolute, active, actual, agricultural, alternative, annual, apparent, available, basic, central, chemical, civil, commercial, communist, conservative, cultural, daily, democratic, direct, domestic, double, due, east, eastern, economic, educational, electric, empty, external, female, financial, foreign, free, full, general, golden, historical, human, ideal, independent, industrial, inevitable, intellectual, internal, international, legal, local, magic, male, medical, mental, military, modern, moral, national, natural, negative, north, northern, nuclear, official, open, original, personal, physical, political, positive, possible, potential, private, professional, proper, psychological, public, raw, ready, real, religious, revolutionary, right, royal, rural, scientific, separate, sexual, single, social, solid, south, southern, standard, straight, sufficient, theoretical, traditional, urban, west, western, wooden, wrong*

2.27 Adjectives e.g. *British, American*, and *Australian*, that indicate nationality or origin, are also classifying adjectives.

They start with a capital letter because they are related to names of countries.

**Example 2.2.10.** ... *American citizens.*

Some classifying adjectives are formed from people's names, e.g. *Victorian* and *Shakespearean.*

They also start with a capital letter.

**Example 2.2.11.** ... *Victorian houses.*

2.28 Because they put something in a class, classifying adjectives are not **gradable** in the way that qualitative adjectives are.

E.g., if you do not have to pay for something, you cannot say that it is *very free*, or *rather free.*

Things are either in a particular class or not in it.

Therefore, classifying adjectives do not have comparatives and superlatives and are not normally used with adverbs like *very* and *rather.*

However, when you want to show that you feel strongly about what you are saying, you can use an *intensifying* adverb e.g. *absolutely* with a classifying adjective.

This is explained in paragraphs **2.147–2.148**.

2.29 Some adjectives can be either **qualitative** or **classifying** depending on the meaning.

E.g., in *an emotional person, emotional* is a qualitative adjective meaning *feeling or expressing strong emotions*; it has a comparative and superlative and it can be used with words like *very* and *rather.*

Thus, a person can be *very emotional, rather emotional*, or *more emotional* than someone else.

However, in *the emotional needs of children, emotional* is a classifying adjective meaning *relation to a person's emotions*, and so it cannot be used with words like *very* or *rather*, and it does not have a comparative and superlative.

Here is a list of adjectives that are often used both as qualitative adjectives and as classifying adjectives:

**Example 2.2.12.** *academic, conscious, dry, educational, effective, emotional, extreme, late, modern, moral, objective, ordinary, regular, religious, revolutionary, rural, scientific, secret, similar, social*

### 2.2.4 Identifying colors: color adjectives

2.30 When you want to say what color something is, you use a **color adjective**.

**Example 2.2.13.** *... her blue eyes.*
*... a red ribbon.*

Here is a list of the main color adjectives:

**Example 2.2.14.** *black, blue, brown, cream, green, grey, orange, pink, purple, red, scarlet, violet, white, yellow*

2.31 If you want to specify color more precisely, you use a word e.g. *light, pale, dark, deep*, or *bright*, in front of a color adjective.

**Example 2.2.15.** *... light brown hair.*
*... a pale green suit.*
*... a dark blue dress.*
*... deep red dye.*

These combinations sometimes have hyphens.

**Example 2.2.16.** *... a light-blue suit.*
*... the plant's tiny pale-pink flowers.*

Note that these words cannot be used with the colors *black* or *white*, because you cannot have different shades of black and white.

If you want to talk about a color that does not have a definite name you can:

- use a color adjective with *-ish* added to the end

  **Example 2.2.17.** *... greenish glass.*
  *... yellowish hair.*

- combine 2 color adjectives, often with *-ish* or *-y* on the end of the 1st one.

  **Example 2.2.18.** *... greenish-white flowers.*

2.33 [⋆] You can mix colors in these ways to produce whatever new color you are trying to describe.
2.34 Color adjectives e.g. *blue* and *green* occasionally have comparatives and superlatives ending in *-er* and *-est*.

**Example 2.2.19.** *His face was redder than usual.*
*... the bluest sky I have ever seen.*

**Comparatives** and **superlatives** are explained in paragraphs **2.103**–**2.122**.
2.35 Colors can also be nouns, and the main colors can also be plural nouns.

**Example 2.2.20.** *The snow shadows had turned to a deep blue.*
*They blended in so well with the khaki and reds of the landscape.*
*... brilliantly colored in reds, yellows, blacks, and purples.*

### 2.2.5 Showing strong feelings: *complete, absolute*, etc.

2.36 You can emphasize your feelings about something that you mention by putting an adjective e.g. *complete, absolute*, or *utter* in front of a noun.

**Example 2.2.21.** *He made me feel like a complete idiot.*
*Some of it was absolute rubbish.*
*... utter despair.*
*... pure bliss.*

You generally use an adjective of this kind only when the noun shows your opinion about something.
Because they are used to show strong feelings, these adjectives are called **emphasizing adjectives**.
Here is a list of emphasizing adjectives:

**Example 2.2.22.** *absolute, complete, entire, outright, perfect, positive, pure, real, total, true, utter*

2.37 A small group of adjectives ending in *-ing* are used in very informal spoken English for emphasis, usually to show disapproval or contempt.

**Example 2.2.23.** *Everybody in the whole stinking town was loaded with money.*
*Shut that blinking door!*

Here is a list of adjectives used informally for emphasis:

**Example 2.2.24.** *blinking, blithering, blooming, blundering, crashing, flaming, freezing, piddling, raving, scalding, stinking, thumping, thundering, whopping*

2.38 [!] Many of these adjectives are usually used with 1 particular noun or adjective after them: *blithering idiot, blundering idiot, crashing bore, raving lunatic, thundering nuisance, freezing cold, scalding hot, piddling little..., thumping great..., whopping great....*

**Example 2.2.25.** *He's driving that car like a raving lunatic!*
*I've got a stinking cold.*
*... a piddling little car.*

2.39 The word *very* is sometimes used to emphasize a noun, in expressions like *the very top* and *the very end*.

**Example 2.2.26.** *... at the very end of the shop.*
*... the very bottom of the hill.*
*These molecules were formed at the very beginning of history.*

### 2.2.6 Making the reference more precise: postdeterminers

2.40 There is a small group of adjectives that are used in a very similar way to **determiners** (see paragraphs **1.162–1.251**) to make the reference more precise.

These are called **postdeterminers**, because their place in a noun phrase is immediately after the determiner, if there is one, and before any other adjectives.

**Example 2.2.27.** *... the following brief description.*
*... certain basic human qualities.*
*... improvements in the last few years.*
*... further technological advance.*
*He wore his usual old white coat...*
*... the only sensible thing to do.*

You often need to make it clear precisely what you are referring to.
E.g., if you say *Turn left at the tall building* someone might ask which tall building you mean.
If you say *Turn left at the next tall building*, there can be no doubt which one you mean.
The postdeterminer *next* picks it out precisely.
Here is a list of adjectives that are postdeterminers:

**Example 2.2.28.** *additional, certain, chief, entire, existing, 1st, following, further, last, main, next, only, opposite, other, particular, past, present, previous, principal, remaining, same, special, specific, usual*

Some of these adjectives are also ordinary classifying adjectives.

**Example 2.2.29.** *He had children from a previous marriage.*
*There are 2 main reasons for this.*

Here is a list of postdeterminers that are also classifying adjectives:

**Example 2.2.30.** *additional, chief, existing, further, main, other, particular, past, previous, principal, remaining, specific*

Adjective that are used to show the position of something are also used for precise reference.

**Example 2.2.31.** *... the middle button of her black leather coat.*
*... the top 100 German companies.*

Here is a list of adjectives sometimes used to talk about the position of something as well as for precise reference:

**Example 2.2.32.** *left, right, upper, lower, top, bottom, middle, end, front, back*

Postdeterminers can also be used with numbers.
This is explained in paragraph **2.219**.

### 2.2.7 Special classes of adjectives

2.41 Most adjectives can be used both before the noun and after a linking verb, but there are some that are only used in 1 position or the other.

There are a few adjectives that are always or almost always used in front of a noun and are never or rarely used after a linking verb.

These adjectives are called **attributive adjectives**.

Examples are *atomic* and *outdoor*.

You can talk about *an atomic explosion*, but you do not say *The explosion was atomic*.

You can talk about *outdoor pursuits*, but you do not say *Their pursuits are outdoor*.

2.42 A few **qualitative adjectives** (see paragraphs **2.22–2.25**) are only used in front of a noun.

Here is a list of qualitative adjectives always used in this way:

**Example 2.2.33.** *adoring, belated, chequered, choked, commanding, fateful, flagrant, fleeing, knotty, paltry, punishing, ramshackle, scant, searing, thankless, unenviable*

Most adjectives that are only used in front of a noun are **classifying adjectives** (see paragraphs **2.26–2.28**).

Here is a list of classifying adjectives used attributively:

**Example 2.2.34.** *atomic, bridal, cardiac, countless, cubic, digital, east, eastern, eventual, existing, federal, forensic, indoor, institutional, introductory, investigate, judicial, lone, maximum, nationwide, neighboring, north, northern, occasional, orchestral, outdoor, phonetic, preconceived, remedial, reproductive, smokeless, south, southern, subterranean, supplementary, underlying, west, western, woolen*

2.43 There are no **color adjectives** (see paragraphs **2.30–2.35**) that are restricted to this position.

**Emphasizing adjectives** (see paragraphs **2.36–2.39**) are usually used in front of a noun.

2.44 Some adjectives are normally used only after a linking verb and not in front of a noun.

These adjectives are called **predicative adjectives**.

E.g., you can say *She felt glad*, but you do not normally talk about *a glad woman*.

Here is a list of adjectives usually used in this way:

**Example 2.2.35.** *afraid, alive, alone, apart, asleep, awake, aware, content, due, glad, ill, likely, ready, safe, sorry, sure, unable, unlikely, well*

Note that they do not have to be followed by a prepositional phrase.

2.45 Some adjectives are usually followed by a prepositional phrase because their meaning would otherwise be unclear or incomplete.

E.g., you cannot simply say that someone is *accustomed*.

You have to say that they are *accustomed to* something.

The following usage note explains which prepositions you use after a particular adjective.

**[i] Usage note.**

2.46 There are a few adjectives that are followed by the preposition *to* when they are used after a linking verb.

**Example 2.2.36.** *She's allergic to cats.*

*Older people are particularly susceptible to heart problems.*

Here is a list of adjectives that are usually or always used after a linking verb and are followed by *to*:

**Example 2.2.37.** *accustomed, adjacent, allergic, attributable, attuned, averse, close, conducive, devoted, impervious, injurious, integral, prone, proportional, proportionate, reconciled, related, resigned, resistant, similar, subject, subservient, susceptible, unaccustomed*

2.47 There are a few adjectives that are followed by the preposition *of* when they are used after a linking verb.

**Example 2.2.38.** *He was aware of the danger that faced him.*

*They seemed capable of winning their 1st game of the season.*

*He was devoid of any talent whatsoever.*

*His mind seemed to have become incapable of any thought.*

Here is a list of adjectives that are usually or always used after a linking verb and are followed by *of*:

**Example 2.2.39.** *aware, bereft, capable, characteristic, desirous, devoid, fond, full, heedless, illustrative, incapable, indicative, mindful, reminiscent, representative*

2.48 There are a few adjectives that are followed by the preposition *with* when they are used after a linking verb.

**Example 2.2.40.** *His surprise became tinged with disbelief.*
*The plastic has to be compatible with the body tissues that make contact with it.*
*This way of life is fraught with danger.*

Here is a list of adjectives that are usually or always used after a linking verb and are followed by *with*:

**Example 2.2.41.** *compatible, consonant, conversant, filled, fraught, riddled, tinged*

2.49 Some adjectives are followed by other prepositions when they are used after a linking verb.

**Example 2.2.42.** *These ideas are rooted in self-deception.*
*Didn't you say the raid was contingent on the weather?*
*Darwin concluded that people were descended from apes.*

Here is a list of adjectives that are usually or always used after a linking verb and are followed by the preposition indicated:

**Example 2.2.43.** *contingent on, descended from, inherent in, lacking in, rooted in, steeped in, swathed in, unhampered by*

In some cases, there is a choice between 2 prepositions.

**Example 2.2.44.** *Many of their courses are connected with industry.*
*Such names were arbitrarily given and were not connected to any particular event.*

Here is a list of adjectives that are usually or always used after a linking verb and that are followed by the prepositions shown:

**Example 2.2.45.** *answerable for/to, burdened by/with, connected to/with, dependent on/upon, immune from/to, inclined to/towards, incumbent on/upon, insensible of/to, intent on/upon, parallel to/with, reliant on/upon, stricken by/with*

2.50 *Different* is most commonly followed by *from*.
It is also sometimes followed by *to* in British English or *than* in American English.

**Example 2.2.46** (AE)**.** *Students today are different from the students 10 years ago.*

2.51 To complete the meaning of some adjectives that are used predicatively, you need to follow with a clause beginning with a ***to*-infinitive**.
E.g., you cannot just say *He is unable.*
You have to add a clause beginning with *to*-infinitive e.g. *to do*: *He is unable to do it.*
***To*-infinitive clauses** are explained in the Reference section.

**Example 2.2.47.** *They were unable to help her.*
*I am willing to try.*
*She is bound to notice there's something wrong.*
*I'm inclined to agree with the minister.*

Here is a list of adjectives that are always or nearly always followed by a *to*-infinitive clause:

**Example 2.2.48.** *able, bound, destined, doomed, due, fated, fit, inclined, liable, likely, loath, prepared, unable, unwilling, willing*

2.52 You can also use a clause beginning with *to*-infinitive after many other adjectives to give more information about something.

**Example 2.2.49.** *I was afraid to go home.*
*I was happy to see them again.*
*He was powerless to prevent it.*
*I was almost ashamed to tell her.*
*The path was easy to follow.*

Note that the subject of the main clause is also the subject of the *to*-infinitive clause.
2.53 When adjectives that refer to someone's beliefs or feelings are used after a linking verb, they are often followed by a ***that*-clause** (see paragraphs **8.119**–**8.121**).
The subject of the *that*-clause is not always the same as the subject of the main clause, so you need to specify it.

**Example 2.2.50.** *She was sure that he meant it.*
*He was frightened that something terrible might be said.*
*I'm aware that I reached a rather large audience through the book.*

note that the word *that* is not always used in a *that*-clause.

**Example 2.2.51.** *They were sure she had been born in the city.*

Here is a list of common adjectives often followed by a *that*-clause:

**Example 2.2.52.** *afraid, angry, anxious, aware, certain, confident, frightened, glad, happy, pleased, proud, sad, sorry, sure, surprised, unaware, upset, worried*

Note that all of these adjectives except *angry, aware, unaware, upset*, and *worried* can also be followed by a *to*-infinitive.

**Example 2.2.53.** *I was afraid that she might not be able bear the strain.*
*Don't be afraid to ask questions.*
*She was surprised that I knew about it.*
*The twins were very surprised to see Ralph.*

### 2.2.8 Position of adjectives in noun phrases

2.54 When you use more than 1 adjective in a noun phrase, the usual order for the adjective is: qualitative adjectives, followed by color adjectives, followed by classifying adjectives.

**Example 2.2.54.** ... *a little white wooden house.*
... *pretty black lacy dresses.*
... *a large circular pool of water.*
... *a beautiful pink suit.*
... *rapid technological advance.*
... *a nice red apple.*
... *the black triangular fin.*

This order is nearly always followed in English.
Occasionally however, when you want to focus on a particular characteristic of the person or thing you are describing, you can vary this order, especially when 1 of the adjectives refers to color or size.

**Example 2.2.55.** ... *a square black hole.*

Note that you sometimes put a common or *and* between adjectives.
This is explained in paragraphs **8.180–8.186** and paragraph **8.201**.

**Example 2.2.56.** ... *the long, low caravan.*
*It was a long and tedious business.*

2.55 **Comparatives** (see paragraphs **2.103–2.111**) and **superlatives** (see paragraphs **2.112–2.122**) normally come in front of all other adjectives in a noun phrase.

**Example 2.2.57.** ... *better parental control.*
... *the highest monthly figures on record.*

2.56 When a noun phrase contains both an adjective and a noun modifier (see paragraphs **2.169–2.174**) the adjective is placed in front of the noun modifier.

**Example 2.2.58.** ... *the booming European car industry.*
... *the world's biggest and most prestigious book fair.*

2.57 When you use 2 adjectives after a linking verb, you use a conjunction, usually *and*, to link them.
If you use more than 2 adjectives, you usually put a conjunction e.g. *and* between the last 2 adjectives and commas between the others.
This is fully explained in paragraphs **8.180–8.186** and paragraph **8.201**.

**Example 2.2.59.** *The room was large and square.*
*We felt hot, tired, and thirsty.*

Note that you put the adjectives in the order that you think is the most important.

2.58 There are a few adjectives that are usually or always used after a noun.

Here is a list showing the different groups of adjectives used after a noun:

**Example 2.2.60.** *designate, elect, galore, incarnate, manqué*
*broad, deep, high, long, old, tall, thick, wide*
*concerned, involved, present, proper, responsible*
*affected, available, required, suggested*

**[i] Usage note.**

2.59 The adjectives *designate, elect, galore, incarnate*, and *manqué* are only used immediately after a noun.

**Example 2.2.61.** *She was now president elect.*
*There are empty houses galore.*

2.60 The adjectives *broad, deep, high, long, old, tall, thick*, and *wide* are used immediately after measurement nouns when giving the size, duration, or age of a thing or person.

This use is fully explained in paragraph **2.253**.

**Example 2.2.62.** *... 6 feet tall.*
*... 3 meters wide.*
*... 25 years old.*

2.61 The adjectives *concerned, involved, present, responsible*, and *proper* have different meanings depending on whether you put them in front of a noun or immediately after one.

E.g., *the concerned mother* describes a mother who is anxious, but *the mother concerned* simply refers to a mother who has just been mentioned.

**Example 2.2.63.** *... the approval of interested and concerned parents.*
*The idea needs to come from the individuals concerned.*
*All this became a very involved process.*
*He knew all of the people involved.*
*... the present international situation.*
*Of the 18 people present, I know only one.*
*... parents trying to act in a responsible manner.*
*... the person responsible for his death.*
*... a proper training in how to teach.*
*... the 1st round proper of the FA Cup.*

2.62 The adjectives *affected, available, required*, and *suggested* can be used in front of a noun or after a noun without any change in meaning.

**Example 2.2.64.** *Newspaper were the only available source of information.*
*... the number of teachers available.*
*... the required changes.*
*You're way below the standard required.*
*... the cost of the suggested improvements.*
*The proposals suggested are derived from successful experiments.*
*Aside from the affected child, the doctor checks every other member of the household.*
*... the proportion of the population affected.*

### 2.2.9 Special forms: *-ing* adjectives

2.63 There are many adjectives ending in *-ing*.

Most of them are related in form to the ***-ing* participles** of verbs.

In this grammar they are called ***-ing* adjectives**.

**Example 2.2.65.** *He was an amiable, amusing fellow.*
*He had been up all night attending a dying man.*

The ***-ing* form** is explained in the Reference section.

2.64 1 group of *-ing* adjectives describe the effect that something has on your feelings and ideas, or on the feelings and ideas of people in general.

**Example 2.2.66.** *... an alarming increase in burglaries.*
*A surprising number of men do not marry.*
*... a charming house on the outskirts of the town.*
*... a warm welcoming smile.*

2.65 These adjectives are normally **qualitative adjectives**.
This means that they can be used with a **submodifying adverb** (a word like *very* or *rather*), and have comparatives and superlatives.

**Example 2.2.67.** *... a very convincing example.*
*There is nothing very surprising in this.*
*... a very exciting idea.*
*... a really pleasing evening at the theater.*
*When Bernard moans he's much more convincing.*
*... 1 of the most boring books I've ever read.*

2.66 They can be used in front of a noun or after a linking verb.

**Example 2.2.68.** *They can still show amazing loyalty to their parents.*
*It's amazing what they can do.*
*... the most terrifying tale ever written.*
*The present situation is terrifying.*

2.67 These *-ing* adjectives have a related transitive verb that you use to describe the way someone is affected by something.
E.g., if you speak of *an alarming increase*, you mean that the increase alarms you.
If you speak of *a surprising number*, you meant that the number surprises you.
Here is a list of *-ing* adjectives that describe an effect and that have a similar meaning to the usual meaning of the related verb:

**Example 2.2.69.** *alarming, amazing, amusing, annoying, appalling, astonishing, astounding, bewildering, boring, challenging, charming, compelling, confusing, convincing, demeaning, depressing, devastating, disappointing, disgusting, distracting, distressing, disturbing, embarrassing, enchanting, encouraging, entertaining, exciting, frightening, harassing, humiliating, infuriating, inspiring, interesting, intimidating, intriguing, menacing, misleading, mocking, overwhelming, pleasing, refreshing, relaxing, rewarding, satisfying, shocking, sickening, starling, surprising, tempting, terrifying, threatening, thrilling, tiring, welcoming, worrying*

Transitive verbs are explained in paragraphs **3.14–3.25**.
2.68 The other main group of *-ing* adjectives are used to describe a process or state that continues over a period of time.

**Example 2.2.70.** *... her growing band of supporters.*
*Oil and gas drillers are doing a booming business.*
*... a life of increasing labor and decreasing leisure.*

2.69 These adjectives are **classifying adjectives**, so they are not used with words like *very* and *rather*.
However, adjectives used to identify a process are often modified by adverbs that describe the speed with which the process happens.

**Example 2.2.71.** *... a fast diminishing degree of personal freedom.*
*... rapidly rising productivity.*

2.70 These *-ing* adjectives have related intransitive verbs.
Here is a list of *-ing* adjectives that describe a continuing process or state and that have a similar meaning to the usual meaning of the related verb:

**Example 2.2.72.** *ageing, ailing, bleeding, booming, bursting, decreasing, diminishing, dwindling, dying, existing, increasing, living, prevailing, recurring, reigning, remaining, resounding, rising, ruling*

Intransitive verbs are explained in paragraphs **3.8–3.13**.
2.71 These *-ing* adjectives are only used in front of a noun, so when *-ing* forms of intransitive verbs appear after the verb *be* they are actually part of a progressive form.
2.72 [⋆] In English, you can make most verbs into adjectives by adding *-ing* to the verb and putting it in front of the noun, to say that someone or something is doing.

**Example 2.2.73.** *... a walking figure.*
*... FIFA, world football's ruling body.*
*... bands performing in front of screaming crowds.*
*... 2 years of falling employment.*
*... a tremendous noise of smashing glass.*

2.73 Most of the *-ing* adjectives talked about so far are related to verbs.
Sometimes however, *-ing* adjectives are not related to verbs at all.
E.g., there is no verb *to neighbor*.

**Example 2.2.74.** *Whole families came from neighboring villages.*

Here is a list of *-ing* adjectives that are not related to verbs:

**Example 2.2.75.** *appetizing, balding, cunning, enterprising, excruciating, impending, neighboring, scathing, unwitting*

2.74 Sometimes, an *-ing* adjectives is related to an uncommon use of a verb, or appears to be related to a verb but is not related exactly to any current use.
E.g., the verb *haunt* is most commonly used in connection with ghosts, but the adjective *haunting* is more often used to talk about such things as songs and memories.
A *haunting tune* is a tune you cannot forget.
Here is a list of qualitative *-ing* adjectives that are not related to a common transitive use of a verb:

**Example 2.2.76.** *becoming, bracing, cutting, dashing, disarming, engaging, fetching, halting, haunting, moving, penetrating, piercing, pressing, promising, rambling, ravishing, retiring, revolting, searching, taxing, trying*

Here is a list of classifying *-ing* adjectives that are not related to a common intransitive use of a verb:

**Example 2.2.77.** *acting, driving, floating, gathering, going, leading, missing, running*

2.75 Some adjectives are derived from a verb and a prefix.
E.g., *outgoing* is derived from the verb *go* and the prefix *out-*.
There is no verb *to outgo*.

**Example 2.2.78.** *Wouldn't that cause a delay in outgoing mail?*

here is a list of *-ing* adjectives derived from a verb and a prefix:

**Example 2.2.79.** *forthcoming, incoming, oncoming, ongoing, outgoing, outstanding, overarching, overbearing, uplifting, upstanding*

2.76 A small group of *-ing* adjectives are used in informal spoken English for emphasis, usually to express disapproval.
This use is explained in paragraphs **2.41**–**2.42**.
Some **compound adjectives** (see paragraphs **2.94**–**2.102**) end in *-ing*.

### 2.2.10 Special forms: *-ed* adjectives

2.77 A large number of English adjectives end in *-ed*.
Many of them have the same form as the ***-ed* participle** of a verb.
Others are formed by adding *-ed* to a noun.
Others are not closely related to any other words.

**Example 2.2.80.** *... a disappointed man.*
*... a bearded man.*
*... sophisticated electronic devices.*

2.78 Adjectives with the same form as irregular ***-ed* participles** (see the Reference section) that do not end in *-ed* are also included here as *-ed* adjectives.

**Example 2.2.81.** *Was it a broken bone, a torn ligament, or what?*

The *-ed* participles of some **phrasal verbs** (see paragraphs **3.83**–**3.116**) can also be used as adjectives.
When they are used in front of a noun, the 2 parts of the phrasal verb are usually written with a hyphen between them.

**Example 2.2.82.** *... the built-up urban mass of the city.*

2.79 Most *-ed* adjectives are related to a transitive verb and have a passive meaning.
They show that something has happened or is happening to the thing being described.
E.g., *a frightened person* is a person who has been frightened by something.
*A known criminal* is a criminal who is known by the police.

**Example 2.2.83.** *We have a long list of satisfied customers.*
*We cannot refuse to teach children the required subjects.*

2.80 *-ed* adjectives that refer to a person's mental or emotional reaction to something are generally qualitative.

**Example 2.2.84.** *He was a worried old man.*
*... a bored old woman.*
*... an interested student.*

These adjectives can be modified by words e.g. *very* and *extremely*, just like other qualitative adjectives (see paragraphs **2.140–2.156**).
2.81 Like other adjectives used for talking about feelings, these adjectives are often used to describe the expression, voice, or manner or the person affected, instead of referring directly to that person.

**Example 2.2.85.** *... her big blue frightened eyes.*
*She could hear his agitated voice.*
*Barry gave him a worried look.*

2.82 Here is a list of qualitative *-ed* adjectives that have a similar meaning to the most common meaning of the related verb:

**Example 2.2.86.** *agitated, alarmed, amused, appalled, astonished, bored, confused, contented, delighted, depressed, deprived, disappointed, disgusted, disillusioned, distressed, embarrassed, excited, frightened, inhibited, interested, pleased, preoccupied, puzzled, satisfied, shocked, surprised, tired, troubled, worried*

Here is a list of qualitative *-ed* adjectives that do not have a similar meaning to the usual meaning of the related verb:

**Example 2.2.87.** *animated, attached, concerned, determined, disposed, disturbed, guarded, hurt, inclined, mixed, strained*

2.83 Many other *-ed* adjectives are used for classifying, and so cannot be used with words like *very* and *rather*.
E.g., *a furnished apartment* is 1 type of apartment, contrasting with *an apartment without furniture*.

**Example 2.2.88.** *... a furnished apartment.*
*... a painted wooden bowl.*
*... the closed bedroom door.*

Most adjectives that refer to physical distinctions are classifying adjectives.
2.84 Here is a list of classifying *-ed* adjectives that have a similar meaning to the most common meaning of the related verb:

**Example 2.2.89.** *abandoned, armed, blocked, boiled, broken, canned, classified, closed, concentrated, condemned, cooked, divided, drawn, dried, established, fixed, furnished, haunted, hidden, improved, infected, integrated, known, licensed, loaded, paid, painted, processed, reduced, required, torn, trained, united, wasted*

Here is list of *-ed* classifying adjectives that have a different meaning from the most common meaning of the related verb:

**Example 2.2.90.** *advanced, marked, noted, pointed, spotted, veiled*

2.85 Classifying *-ed* adjectives cannot normally be modified with words like *quite* and *very*.
However, an **adverb of manner**, (see paragraphs **6.36–6.44**) or an **adverb of degree**, (see paragraphs **6.45–6.52**) is often used before an *-ed* adjective.
E.g., *a pleasantly furnished room* is a room that has been furnished with pleasant furniture.

**Example 2.2.91.** *... pleasantly furnished rooms.*
*... a well-known novelist.*

2.86 Some *-ed* adjectives are not often used on their own, and an adverb is necessary to complete the sense.
You do not usually talk about *dressed people*, but you can say that they are *well dressed* or *smartly dressed* e.g.
The *-ed* adjectives in the following examples nearly always have an adverb in front of them.

**Example 2.2.92.** *... a cautiously worded statement.*
*... impeccably dressed men.*
*It was a richly deserved honor.*
*... superbly cut clothes.*
*... the existence of a highly developed national press.*
*... a well organized campaign.*
*... a tall, powerfully built man.*
*She gazed down at his perfectly formed little face.*

Note that combinations like this are sometimes hyphenated, making them **compound adjectives**.

**Example 2.2.93.** *... a well-equipped army.*

2.87 A few *-ed* adjectives are related to the *-ed* participle of intransitive verbs and have an active meaning, not a passive meaning.
E.g., *a fallen tree* is a tree that has fallen.

**Example 2.2.94.** *... a capsized ship.*
*She is the daughter of a retired army officer.*
*... an escaped prisoner.*

Here is a list of *-ed* adjectives with an active meaning:

**Example 2.2.95.** *accumulated, dated, escaped, faded, fallen, retired, swollen, wilted*

2.88 Most *-ed* adjectives can be used both in front of a noun and after a linking verb.

**Example 2.2.96.** *The worried authorities decided to play safe.*
*My husband was worried.*

A small number of *-ed* adjectives are normally only used after a linking verb.
Often, they are followed by a preposition, a *to*-infinitive, or a *that*-clause.

**Example 2.2.97.** *I was thrilled by the exhibition.*
*The Brazilians are pleased with the results.*
*... food destined for areas of south Sudan.*
*He was always prepared to account for his actions.*

Here is a list of *-ed* adjectives often used after a linking verb, with or without a phrase or clause after them:

**Example 2.2.98.** *convinced, delighted, interested, intimidated, intrigued, involved, pleased, prepared, scared, thrilled, tired, touched*

Here is a list of *-ed* adjectives normally used after a linking verb with a phrase or clause after them:

**Example 2.2.99.** *agreed, destined, dressed, finished, lost, prepared, shut, stuck*

2.89 [⋆] The *-ed* participle of almost any transitive verb can be used as an adjective, though some are more commonly used than others.

**Example 2.2.100.** *... she said, with a forced smile.*
*There was 1 paid tutor and 3 volunteer tutors.*
*The recovered animals will be released.*
*... the final corrected version.*

2.90 ⋆ Some *-ed* adjectives are formed from nouns.
E.g., if a living thing has wings, you can describe it as *winged*.
Inf someone has skills, you can describe them as *skilled*.

**Example 2.2.101.** *... winged angels.*
*... a skilled engineer.*
*She was dressed in black and carried a black beaded purse.*
*... armored cars.*
*... the education of gifted children.*

2.91 Here is a list of *-ed* adjectives formed from nouns:

**Example 2.2.102.** *armored, barbed, beaded, bearded, detailed, flowered, freckled, gifted, gloved, hooded, mannered, pointed, principled, salaried, skilled, spotted, striped, turbaned, walled, winged*

*-ed* adjectives formed from nouns are commonly used as the 2nd part of **compound adjectives** (see paragraph **2.94–2.102**) e..g *grey-haired* and *open-minded*.

2.92 There are also some *-ed* adjectives in regular use that are not related to verbs or nouns in the ways described above. E.g., there are no words *parch* or *belove*.

There is a noun *concert*, but the adjective *concerted* does not mean *having a concert*.

**Example 2.2.103.** *He climbed up the dry parched grass to the terrace steps.*
*. . . a complex and antiquated system of taxation.*
*. . . attempts to mount a concerted campaign.*
*. . . the purchase of expensive sophisticated equipment.*

2.93 Here is a list of *-ed* adjectives that are not related to verbs or nouns:

**Example 2.2.104.** *antiquated, ashamed, assorted, beloved, bloated, concerted, crazed, deceased, doomed, indebted, parched, rugged, sophisticated, tinned*

### 2.2.11 Compound adjectives

2.94 **Compound adjectives** are made up of 2 or more words, usually written with hyphens between them. They may be qualitative, classifying, or color adjectives.

**Example 2.2.105.** *I was in a light-hearted mood.*
*She was dressed in a bottle-green party dress.*
*. . . the built-up urban mass of the city.*
*. . . an air-conditioned restaurant.*
*. . . a good-looking girl.*
*. . . 1-way traffic.*
*. . . a part-time job.*

2.95 These are the most common and least restricted patterns for forming compound adjectives:

- adjective or number plus noun plus *-ed*, e.g. *grey-haired* and *1-sided*
- adjective or adverb plus *-ed* participle, e.g. *low-paid* and *well-behaved*
- adjective, adverb, or noun plus *-ing* participle, e.g. *good-looking, long-lasting* and *man-eating*.

Note that compound adjectives describe simple concepts: a *good-looking* person looks good, and a *man-eating* beast eats humans.

More complex descriptions in English need to be given using a following phrase or clause.

2.96 These are less common and more restricted patterns for forming compound adjectives:

- noun plus *-ed* participle, e.g. *tongue-tied* and *wind-swept*
- noun plus adjective, e.g. *accident-prone, trouble-free*
- adjective plus noun, e.g. *deep-sea, present day*
- *-ed* participle plus adverb, e.g. *run-down, cast-off*
- number plus singular countable noun, e.g. *5-page, 4-door*

Note that compound adjectives formed according to the last of these patterns are always used in front of a noun.

2.97 Here is a list of compound qualitative adjectives:

**Example 2.2.106.** *able-bodied, absent-minded, accident-prone, big-headed, clear-cut, close-fitting, cold-blooded, easy-going, far-fetched, far-reaching, good-looking, good-tempered, hard-up, hard-wearing, ill-advised, kind-hearted, labor saving, laid-back, light-hearted, long-lasting, long-standing, long-suffering, low-cut, low-paid, low-slung, mind-blowing, mouth-watering, muddle-headed, narrow-minded, nice-looking, off-color, off-hand, off-putting, old-fashioned, 1-sided, open-minded, run-down, 2nd-class, 2nd-rate, shop-soiled, short-handed, short-lived, short-sighted, short-tempered, slow-witted, smooth-talking, soft-hearted, starry-eyed, strong-minded, stuck-up, sun-tanned, swollen-headed, tender-hearted, thick-skinned, tongue-tied, top-heavy, trouble-free, 2-edged, 2-faced, warm-hearted, well-balanced, well-behaved, well-dressed, well-known, well-off, wind-blown, wordly-wise, wrong-headed*

2.98 Here is a list of compound classifying adjectives:

**Example 2.2.107.** *air-conditioned, all-out, all-powerful, audio-visual, blue-blooded, bow-legged, brand-new, breast-fed, broken-down, broken-hearted, built-up, bullet-proof, burnt-out, cast-off, clean-shaven, cross-Channel, cross-country, cut-price, deep-sea, deep-seated, double-barreled, double-breasted, drip-dry, drive-in, duty-bound, duty-free, empty-handed, face-saving, far-flung, 1st-class, free-range, free-standing, freeze-dried, front-page, full-blown, full-face, full-grown, full-length, full-scale, gilt-edged, grey-haired, half-price, half-yearly, hand-picked, high-heeled, home-made, ice-cold, interest-free, knee-deep, last-minute, late-night, lead-free, left-handed, lift-size, long-distance, long-lost, long-range, loose-leaf, made-up, man-eating, mass-produced, middle-aged, never-ending, north-east, north-west, nuclear-free, odds-on, off-guard, off-peak, 1-way, open-ended, open-mouthed, panic-stricken, part-time, present-day, purpose-built, ready-made, record-breaking, red-brick, remote-controlled, right-angled, right-handed, 2nd-class, 2nd-hand, see-through, silver-plated, single-handed, so-called, so-so, south-east, south-west, strong-arm, tax-free, tone-deaf, top-secret, unheard-of, wide-awake, world-famous, worn-out, year-long*

2.99 Here is a list of compound color adjectives:

**Example 2.2.108.** *blood-red, blue-black, bottle-green, dove-grey, electric-blue, flesh-colored, ice-blue, iron-grey, jet-black, lime-green, navy-blue, nut-brown, off-white, pea-green, pearl-grey, royal-blue, shocking-pink, sky-blue, snow-white*

2.100 A few compound adjectives are made up of more than 2 words.

Compounds of 3 or more words are often written with hyphens when they are used in front of nouns, and without hyphens when they are used after a linking verb.

**Example 2.2.109.** *. . . the day-to-day chores of life.*
*. . . a down-to-earth approach.*
*. . . a free-and-easy relationship.*
*. . . life-and-death decisions.*
*. . . a trip to an out-of-the-way resort.*
*Their act is out of date.*

2.101 Some compound adjectives seem rather odd because they contain words that are never used as single words on their own, e.g. *namby-pamby, higgledy-piggledy*, and *topsy-turvy.*

Words like these are usually informal.

**Example 2.2.110.** *. . . all that artsy-craftsy spiritualism.*
*. . . his la-di-da family.*

2.102 Some compound adjectives are borrowed from foreign languages, especially from French and Latin.

**Example 2.2.111.** *. . . the arguments once used to defend laissez-faire economics.*
*. . . their present per capita fuel consumption.*
*In the commercial theater, almost every production is ad hoc.*

Here is a list of compound adjectives borrowed from other languages:

**Example 2.2.112.** *à la mode, a posteriori, a priori, ad hoc, ad lib, au fait, avant-garde, bona fide, compos mentis, cordon bleu, de facto, de jure, de luxe, de rigueur, de trop, ex gratia, hors de combat, infra dig, laissez-faire, non compas mentis, per capita, prima facie, pro rata, sub judice*

## 2.3 Comparing things: comparatives

2.103 You can describe something by saying that it has more of a quality than something else.

You do this by using **comparative adjectives**.

Only qualitative adjectives usually have comparatives, but a few color adjectives also have them.

Comparatives normally consist of the usual form of the adjective with either *-er* added to the end, as in *harder* and *smaller*, or *more* placed in front, as in *more interesting* and *more flexible.*

Note that *good* and *bad* have the irregular comparative forms *better* and *worse.*

The patterns for forming regular and irregular comparatives are explained in the Reference section.

2.104 Comparatives can be used as **modifiers** in front of a noun.

**Example 2.3.1.** *The family moved to a smaller home.*
*He dreams of a better, more exciting life.*
*A harder mattress often helps with black injuries.*

Note that comparatives can also be used as modifiers in front of *one*.

**Example 2.3.2.** *An understanding of this reality provokes a better one.*

2.105 Comparatives can also be used after a **linking verb**.

**Example 2.3.3.** *The ball soaked up water and became heavier.*
*His breath became quieter.*
*We need to be more flexible.*

The use of adjectives after linking verbs is explained in paragraphs **3.132–3.137**.

2.106 Comparatives are often followed by *than* when you want to specify what the other thing involved in the comparison is.

You say exactly what you are comparing by using 1 of a number of structures after *than*.
These structures can be

**Example 2.3.4.** *noun phrases*

**Example 2.3.5.** *Charlie was more honest than his predecessor.*
*. . . an area bigger than Mexico.*

*Note that when than is followed by a pronoun on its own, the pronoun must be an object pronouns e.g. me, him, or her.*

**Example 2.3.6.** *My brother is younger than me.*
*Lamin was shorter than her.*

*phrases that start with a preposition*

**Example 2.3.7.** *The changes will be even more striking in the case of teaching than in medicine.*
*The odds of surviving childhood in New York City are worse than in some 3rd World countries.*

*clauses*

**Example 2.3.8.** *I would have done a better job than he did.*
*I was a better writer than he was.*
*He's taller than I am.*

Note that when a comparative is not followed by a *than* phrase, the other thing in the comparison should be obvious.
E.g., if someone says *Could I have a bigger one, please?* they are likely to be holding the item that they think is too small.

**Example 2.3.9.** *A mattress would be better.*

2.107 If you choose a phrase or clause beginning with *than* when you are using a comparative in front of a noun, you usually put the phrase or clause after the whole noun phrase, not directly after the comparative.

**Example 2.3.10.** *The world is a more dangerous place than it was.*
*Willy owned a larger collection of books than anyone else I have ever met.*

A comparative can also come immediately after a noun, but only when it is followed by *than* and a noun phrase.

**Example 2.3.11.** *We've got a rat bigger than a cat living in our roof.*
*. . . packs of cards larger than he was used to.*

2.108 *More* is sometimes used in front of a whole noun phrase to show that something has more of the qualities of 1 thing than another, or is 1 thing rather than being another.

**Example 2.3.12.** *Music is more a way of life than an interest.*
*This is more a war movie than a western.*

Note that *more than* is used before adjectives for emphasis.

**Example 2.3.13.** *Their life may be horribly full, but they are more than satisfied.*
*You would be more than welcome.*

2.109 Comparative adjectives are sometimes used as noun-type words in fairly formal English.
In such phrases, you put *the* in front of it, and follow it with *of* and a noun phrase that refers to the 2 things being compared.

**Example 2.3.14.** ... *the shorter of the 2 lines.*
*Dorothea was the more beautiful of the 2.*
*There are 2 windmills, the larger of which stands a hundred feet high.*

If it is clear what you are talking about, you can omit *of* and the following noun phrase.

**Example 2.3.15.** *Notice to quit must cover the rental period or 4 weeks, whichever is the longer.*

2.110 The form that is used to say that something does not have as much of a quality as something else is *less* followed by an adjective.

**Example 2.3.16.** *The answer had been less truthful than his own.*

You can also use *less* and an adjective to say that something does not have as much of a quality as it had before.

**Example 2.3.17.** *As the days went by, Sita became less anxious.*

Note that less than is used before adjectives to express a negative idea.

**Example 2.3.18.** *It would have been less than fair.*

2.111 You show that 1 amount of a quality or thing is linked to another amount by using 2 contrasted comparatives preceded by *the*.

**Example 2.3.19.** *The smaller it is, the cheaper it is to post.*
*The more militant we became, the less confident she became.*
*The larger the organization, the less scope there is for decision.*

## 2.4 Comparing things: superlatives

2.112 Another way of describing something is to say that it has more of a quality than anything else of its kind.
You do this by using a **superlative adjective**.
Only qualitative adjectives usually have superlatives, but a few color adjectives also have them.
Superlatives normally consist of either *-est* added to the end of an adjective and *the* placed in front of it, as in *the hardest* and *the smallest*, or of *the most* placed in front of the adjective, as in *the most interesting* and *the most flexible*.
Note that *good* and *bad* have the irregular superlative forms *the best* and *the worst*.
The patterns for forming regular and irregular superlatives of adjectives are explained in the Reference section.
Note that superlative adjectives are nearly always preceded by *the*, because you are talking about something definite.
Occasionally, when superlatives are used after a linking verb, *the* is omitted (see paragraph **2.117**).
2.113 [!] Adjectives with *most* in front of them are not always superlatives.
*Most* can also mean *very*.

**Example 2.4.1.** *This book was most interesting.*
*My grandfather was a most extraordinary man.*

Words like *very* and *rather* are called **submodifying adverbs**.
These are explained in paragraphs **2.140–2.156**.
2.114 Superlatives can be used as **modifiers** in front of a noun.

**Example 2.4.2.** *He was the cleverest man I ever knew.*
*It was the most exciting summer of their lives.*
*She came out of the thickest part of the crowd.*
*Now we come to the most important thing.*
... *the oldest rock paintings in North America.*
... *the most eminent scientists in Britain.*

Note that superlatives are also used as modifiers in front of *one*.

**Example 2.4.3.** *No one ever used the smallest one.*

2.115 Superlatives are also used after a **linking verb**.

**Example 2.4.4.** *He was the youngest.*
*The sergeant was the tallest.*

The use of adjectives after linking verbs is explained in paragraphs **3.132–3.137**.

2.116 You can use a superlative on its own if it is clear what is being compared.

E.g., if you say *Paul was the tallest*, you are referring to a group of people that has already been identified.

If you need to refer to the point of the comparison, you use a phrase or clause that consists of

- phrases that start with a preposition, usually *in* or *of*

  **Example 2.4.5.** *Henry was the biggest of them.*

  *The 3rd requirement is the most important of all.*

  *These cakes are probably the best in the world.*

- a relative clause

  **Example 2.4.6.** *It's the best I'm likely to get.*

  *The waiting room was the worst I had seen.*

Note that if the superlative is placed in front of a noun, the relative clause comes after the noun.

**Example 2.4.7.** *That's the most convincing answer that you've given me.*

2.117 [i] You usually put *the* in front of the superlative, but you can occasionally omit it, especially in informal speech or writing.

**Example 2.4.8.** *Wool and cotton blankets are generally cheapest.*
*It can be used by whoever is closest.*

However, you cannot omit *the* when the superlative is followed by *of* or another structure showing what group of things you are comparing.

So, e.g., you can say *Amanda was the youngest of our group* or *Amanda was the youngest* or *Amanda was youngest*, but you cannot say *Amanda was youngest of our group.*

You can sometimes use the possessive form of a noun or a possessive determiner instead of *the* in front of a superlative.

Often the possessive form of a noun is used instead of a phrase beginning with a preposition.

E.g., you can say *Britain's oldest man* instead of *the oldest man in Britain.*

**Example 2.4.9.** ... *the world's most popular cheese.*
... *my newest assistant.*

The possessive form of nouns is explained in paragraphs **1.211-1.222**, and possessive determiners are explained in paragraphs **1.194–1.210**.

2.118 A superlative is sometimes accompanied by another adjective ending in *-able* or *-ible*.

This 2nd adjective can be placed either between the superlative and the noun or after the noun.

**Example 2.4.10.** ... *the narrowest imaginable range of interests.*
... *the most beautiful scenery imaginable.*
... *the longest possible gap.*
*I say that in the nicest way possible.*

2.119 Superlative adjectives are sometimes used like nouns in fairly formal English.

When you use a superlative adjective in this way, you put *the* in front of it, and follow it with *of* and a noun or pronoun that refers to the things being compared.

When superlative adjectives are used in this way they can refer to 1 thing or to more than one.

**Example 2.4.11.** *They are often too poor to buy or rent even the cheapest of houses.*
*He made several important discoveries. The most interesting of these came from an examination of an old manuscript.*

If it is clear what you are talking about, you can omit *of* and the following noun phrase.

**Example 2.4.12.** *There are 3 types of ant-eater. The smallest lives entirely in trees.*

2.120 [i] In informal speech, people often use a superlative rather than a comparative when they are talking about 2 things.

E.g., someone might say *The train is quickest* rather than *The train is quicker* when comparing a train service with a bus service.

However, some people think that it is better to use superlatives only when comparing more than 2 things.

2.121 **Ordinal numbers** are used with superlatives to show that something has more of a quality than nearly all other things of their kind.

E.g., if you say that a mountain is *the 2nd highest mountain*, you mean that it is higher than any other mountain except the highest one.

**Example 2.4.13.** *Cancer is the 2nd biggest cause of death in Britain.*
*... the 2nd most important man in her life, her hairdresser.*
*It is Japan's 3rd largest city.*

Ordinal numbers are explained in paragraphs **2.232–2.239**.

2.122 When you want to show that something has less of a quality than anything else, you use *the least* followed by an adjective.

**Example 2.4.14.** *This is the least popular branch of medicine.*

Similarly, when you are talking about a group of things that have less of a quality than other things of their kind, you use *the least*.

**Example 2.4.15.** *... the least savage men in the country.*

## 2.5 Other ways of comparing things: saying that things are similar

2.123 Another way of describing things is by saying that something is similar in some way to something else.

2.124 If you want to say that a thing or person has as much of a quality as something or someone else, you can use a structure based on the word *as* in front of a qualitative adjective.

Usually this adjective is followed by a phrase or clause that also begins with *as*.

This can be

- a phrase beginning with the preposition *as*

  **Example 2.5.1.** *You're just as bad as your sister.*

  *... huge ponds as big as tennis courts.*

  *Talking were as high as ever.*

- a clause introduced by *as*

  **Example 2.5.2.** *Conversation was not as slow as I feared it would be.*

  *The village gardens aren't as good as they used to be.*

2.125 When this comparative structure is followed by a phrase consisting of *as* and a pronoun on its own, the pronoun must be an object pronoun e.g. *me, him*, or *her*.

**Example 2.5.3.** *Jane was not as clever as him.*

However, when the comparative structure is followed by a clause consisting of *as* and a pronoun that is the subject of a clause, then that pronoun must be a subject pronoun e.g. *I, he* or *she*.

**Example 2.5.4.** *They aren't as clever as they appear to be.*

2.126 If it is clear what you are comparing something to someone to, you can omit the phrase or clause.

**Example 2.5.5.** *Frozen peas are just as good.*

2.127 You can also use the *as... as...* structure to say that something has much more or less of a quality than something else.

You do this by putting an expression e.g. *twice, 3 times, 10 times*, or *half* in front of the 1st *as*.

E.g., if 1 building is 10 meters high and another building is 20 meters high, you can say that the 2nd building is *twice as high as* the 1st building or that the 1st building is *half as high as* the 2nd one.

**Example 2.5.6.** *The grass was twice as tall as in the rest of the field.*
*Water is 800 times as dense as air.*

This structure is often used in the same way to refer to qualities that cannot be measured.

E.g., if you want to say that something is much more useful than something else, you can say that the 1st thing is *a hundred times as useful as* the 2nd one.

**Example 2.5.7.** *Without this help, rearing our children would be 10 times as hard as it is.*

2.128 [i] When the *as... as...* structure is preceded by *not*, it has the same meaning as *less... than*.
E.g., *I am not as tall as George* means the same as *I am less tall than George*.
Some people use *not so... as...* instead of *not as... as...*

**Example 2.5.8.** *The film is not as good as the book.*
*The younger otter is not so handsome as the old.*

2.129 Words like *just, quite, nearly* and *almost* can be used in front of this comparative structure, modifying the comparison with their usual meanings.

**Example 2.5.9.** *Sunburn can be just as severe as a heat burn.*

The use of these words in comparison is explained in paragraphs **2.157–2.168**.
2.130 When you are using the *as... as...* structure you sometimes put a noun after the adjective and before the following phrase or clause.
This noun must begin with *a* or *an*.
E.g., instead of saying *This knife is as good as that one*, you can say *This is as good a knife as that one.*

**Example 2.5.10.** *I'm as good a cook as she is.*
*This was not as bad a result as they expected.*

Sometimes, instead of using *not* before this structure, you use *not such* followed by *a* or *an*, an adjective, a noun, and *as*.

**Example 2.5.11.** *Water is not such a good conductor as metal.*

2.131 Instead of using this as... as... structure you can use expressions e.g. *the height of* and *the size of* to show that something is as big as something else, or bigger or smaller.

**Example 2.5.12.** *The tumor was the size of a golf ball.*
*It is roughly the length of a man's arm.*

2.132 If something has similar qualities or features to something else, instead of using the *as... as...* comparative structures you can say that the 1st thing is *like* the 2nd one.
You do this by using phrases beginning with *like* after **linking verbs**/

**Example 2.5.13.** *He looked like an actor.*
*That sounds like an exaggeration.*
*The whole thing is like a bad dream.*

Here is a list of the linking verbs used with *like*:

**Example 2.5.14.** *be, feel, look, seem, smell, sound, taste*

When you want to say that 1 thing resembles another, you can use a phrase beginning with *like* after these linking verbs.

**Example 2.5.15.** *It was like a dream.*
*Sometimes I feel like a prisoner here.*
*He looked like a nice man.*
*The houses seemed like mansions.*
*You smell like a tramp!*
*It sounded like a fine idea.*

2.133 *Like* has the comparative *more like* and *less like*, and the superlative *most like* and *least like*.

**Example 2.5.16.** *It made her seem less like a child.*
*Of all his children, she was the one most like me.*

2.134 [i] You can use words like *exactly* and *just* in front of *like*.

**Example 2.5.17.** *He looks just like a baby.*
*She looked like a queen, just exactly like a queen.*

This is explained in paragraph **2.165**.
2.135 If you want to say that 1 thing is exactly like something else, you can say that it is *the same as* the other thing.

**Example 2.5.18.** *The rich are the same as the rest of us.*

*The same as* can be followed by a noun phrase, a pronoun, or a clause.

**Example 2.5.19.** *24 Spring Terrace was the same as all its neighbors.*
*Her coloring was the same as mine.*
*The furnishings are not exactly the same as they were when we lived there.*

If 2 or more things are exactly like each other, you can say that they are *the same*.

**Example 2.5.20.** *Come and look! They're exactly the same.*
*They both taste the same.*

You use *the same* when you are comparing people or things with other people or things that you have just mentioned.

**Example 2.5.21.** *It looks like a calculator and weights about the same.*
*The message was the same.*
*The end result is the same.*

Note that you use *the opposite* and *the reverse* in a similar way.

**Example 2.5.22.** *The kind of religious thoughts I had were just the opposite.*
*Some people think that a healthy diet is expensive, but in fact the reverse is true.*

2.136 [i] You can use words like *nearly* and *exactly* in front of *the same as* and *the same*.

**Example 2.5.23.** *They are virtually the same as other single cells.*
*You 2 look exactly the same.*

Here is a list of words used in the same way with *the same as* and *the same*:

**Example 2.5.24.** *almost, exactly, just, more or less, much, nearly, virtually*

These words are explained in paragraphs **2.140–2.168**.
2.137 You can put a noun e.g. *size, length*, or *color* after *the same*.
E.g., if you want to say that 1 street is as long as another one, you can say that the 1st street is *the same length* as the 2nd one, or that the 2 streets are *the same length*.

**Example 2.5.25.** *Its brain was about the same size as that of a gorilla.*
*They were almost the same height.*

2.138 The adjectives *alike, comparable, equivalent, identical*, and *similar* are also used to say that 2 or more things are like each other.
You can put the preposition *to* after all of them except *alike* in order to mention the 2nd of the things being compared.

**Example 2.5.26.** *They all looked alike.*
*The houses were all identical.*
*Flemish is similar to Afrikaans.*

2.139 When you want to suggest that you are comparing different amounts of a quality, you can use words like *comparatively, relatively*, and *equally*.

**Example 2.5.27.** *Psychology's a comparatively new subject.*
*The costs remained relatively low.*
*Her technique was less dramatic than Ann's, but equally effective.*
*He was extra polite to his superiors.*

## 2.6 Talking about different amounts of a quality

2.140 When you want to say something more about the quality that an adjective describes, you can use a **submodifying adverb** e.g. *very* or *rather* with it.
You do this in order to indicate the amount of the quality, or to intensify it.
2.141 Because qualitative adjectives are **gradable**, allowing you to say how much or how little of the quality is relevant, you are more likely to use **submodifying adverbs** (words like *extremely* or *slightly*) with them than with other types of adjective.

**Example 2.6.1.** *... an extremely narrow road.*
*... a highly successful company.*
*... in a slightly different way.*
*I was extraordinarily happy.*
*... helping them in a strongly supportive way.*
*... a very pretty girl.*
*She seems very pleasant.*
*... a rather clumsy person.*
*His hair was rather long.*

2.142 You can use words like *very* and *extremely* with some classifying adjectives (see paragraphs **2.146–2.148**) and with color adjectives (see paragraph **2.35**).

Note that most *-ed* adjectives can be modified by words e.g. *very* and *extremely*, just like other qualitative adjectives.

**Example 2.6.2.** *... a very frightened little girl.*
*... an extremely disappointed young man.*

2.143 You can use many submodifying adverbs like *very* or *extremely* with qualitative adjectives in order to intensify their meaning.

**Example 2.6.3.** *... extremely high temperatures.*
*Geoffrey was a deeply religious man.*
*France is heavily dependent on foreign trade.*

Here is a list of words used to intensify the meaning of adjectives:

**Example 2.6.4.** *amazingly, awfully, bitterly, critically, dangerously, deeply, delightfully, disturbingly, dreadfully, eminently, especially, exceedingly, extraordinarily, extremely, fantastically, greatly, heavily, highly, hopelessly, horribly, hugely, impossibly, incredibly, infinitely, notably, particularly, radically, really, remarkably, seriously, strikingly, supremely, surprisingly, suspiciously, terribly, unbelievably, very, violently, vitally, wildly, wonderfully*

Note that *very* can be used in front of superlative adjectives when you want to be very emphatic.
This is explained in paragraphs **2.167–2.168**.

2.144 Many of these submodifying adverbs not only intensify the meaning of the adjective but also allow you to express your opinion about what you are saying.

E.g., if you say that something is *surprisingly large*, you are expressing surprise at how large it is as well as intensifying the meaning of *large*.

**Example 2.6.5.** *He has amazingly long eyelashes.*
*... a delightfully refreshing taste.*
*... a shockingly brutal scene.*
*... a horribly uncomfortable chair.*
*... incredibly boring documents.*

However, you use a few of these submodifying adverbs with no other purpose than to intensify the meaning of the adjective.

**Example 2.6.6.** *They're awfully brave.*
*The other girls were dreadfully dull companions.*

Here is a list of words only used to intensify adjectives:

**Example 2.6.7.** *awfully, dreadfully, especially, extremely, greatly, highly, really, so, terribly, very*

Note that *awfully, dreadfully*, and *terribly* are used in informal language and *highly* is used in very formal language.
Note also that *so* is normally only used after a linking verb.

**Example 2.6.8.** *I am so sorry.*

2.145 Some submodifying adverbs are used to reduce the effect of qualitative adjectives.

**Example 2.6.9.** *The story was mildly amusing.*
*It's fairly common feeling.*
*... moderately rich people.*
*... his rather large stomach.*
*My last question is somewhat personal.*

Here is a list of words used to reduce the effect of an adjective:

**Example 2.6.10.** *faintly, fairly, mildly, moderately, pretty, quite, rather, reasonably, slightly, somewhat*

Note also that *quite* is normally only used with adjectives that are used after a linking verb.

**Example 2.6.11.** *She was quite tall.*

2.146 Some modifying adverbs are used to talk about the extent of the quality that you are describing.
Here is a list of words used to talk about the extent of a quality:

**Example 2.6.12.** *almost, exclusively, fully, largely, mainly, mostly, nearly, partly, predominantly, primarily, roughly absolutely, altogether, completely, entirely, perfectly, purely, quite, simply, totally, utterly*

2.147 The 1st group in the list above are used almost always just to talk about the extent of a quality.
They are most commonly used with classifying adjectives.

**Example 2.6.13.** *It was an almost automatic reflex.*
*. . . a shop with an exclusively female clientele.*
*. . . the largely rural south east.*
*The wolf is now nearly extinct.*
*The reasons for this were partly economic and practical, and partly political and social.*

*Almost* and *nearly* are also used with qualitative adjectives.

**Example 2.6.14.** *The club was almost empty.*
*It was nearly dark.*

Note that *roughly* can be used when you want to say that something is nearly or approximately like something else.

**Example 2.6.15.** *West Germany, Japan and Sweden are at roughly similar levels of economic development.*

Note also that *half* is sometimes used in this way.
E.g., you can describe someone as *half American* if just 1 of their parents was American.
2.148 The 2nd group in the list above are used not only to talk about the extent of a quality but also to emphasize the adjective.
They are used with classifying adjectives as well as qualitative adjectives.

**Example 2.6.16.** *You're absolutely right.*
*This policy has been completely unsuccessful.*
*Everyone appeared to be completely unaware of the fact.*
*The discussion was purely theoretical.*
*It really is quite astonishing.*
*. . . a totally new situation.*
*We lived totally separate lives.*
*. . . utterly trivial matters.*

Note that *absolutely* is frequently used with qualitative adjectives that express enthusiasm or lack of enthusiasm.
When you use *absolutely* in this way you are emphasizing how strongly you feel about what you are saying.

**Example 2.6.17.** *. . . an absolutely absurd idea.*
*I think it's absolutely wonderful.*
*The enquiry is absolutely crucial.*

Here is a list of qualitative adjectives often emphasized by *absolutely*:

**Example 2.6.18.** *absurd, awful, brilliant, certain, crucial, enormous, essential, excellent, furious, hilarious, huge, impossible, massive, perfect, ridiculous, splendid, terrible, vital, wonderful*

Note also that *completely* and *utterly* can also be used in this way.

**Example 2.6.19.** *It is completely impossible to imagine such a world.*
*He began to feel utterly miserable.*

2.149 You can use submodifying adverbs e.g. *adequately, sufficiently*, and *acceptably* when you want to say that someone or something has enough of the quality you are describing.

**Example 2.6.20.** *The roof is adequately insulated.*
*We found a bank of snow sufficiently deep to dig a cave.*

2.150 [i] You can also show that you think something is sufficient by using *enough*.
*Enough* always comes after the adjective, and never before it.

**Example 2.6.21.** *I was not a good enough rider.*
*It seemed that Henry had not been careful enough.*

*Enough* can be followed by the preposition *for* to indicate a person involved, or by a *to*-infinitive to indicate a related action.

**Example 2.6.22.** *A girl from the factory wasn't good enough for him.*
*If you find that the white wine is not cold enough for you, ask for some ice to be put in it.*
*The children are old enough to travel to school on their own.*
*None of the fruit was ripe enough to eat.*

Note that when *enough* is used after an adjective, you can use *just* in front of the adjective to show that someone or something has enough of the quality described by the adjective, but no more than that.

**Example 2.6.23.** *Some of these creatures are just large enough to see with the naked eye.*

2.151 *Enough* is also a determiner (see paragraphs **1.223**–**1.247**).

**Example 2.6.24.** *He hasn't had enough exercise.*

When *enough* is a determiner, it can have a word like *just* or *almost* in front of it.

**Example 2.6.25.** *There was just enough space for a bed.*
*I have almost enough tokens for 1 book.*

2.152 If you want to show that you think something you are describing is insufficient, you can use submodifying adverbs e.g. *inadequately, insufficiently*, and *unacceptably*.

**Example 2.6.26.** *... people growing up in insufficiently supportive families.*
*Their publications were inadequately researched.*

2.153 If you want to say that you think someone or something has too much of a quality, you normally use *too* in front of a qualitative adjective that is used after a linking verb.

**Example 2.6.27.** *My feet are too big.*
*It was too hot.*
*Dad thought I was too idealistic.*

You can emphasize *too* by putting *far* in front of it.
In informal English you can also use *way*.

**Example 2.6.28.** *The journey was far too long.*
*It was far too hot to work in the garden.*
*The price was way too high.*

*Too* can be followed by the preposition *for* to indicate a person involved or by a *to*-infinitive to indicate a related action.

**Example 2.6.29.** *The shoes were too big for him.*
*He was too old for that sort of thing.*
*She was too weak to lift me.*
*He was too proud to apologize.*

Note that you do not usually use *too* with an adjective in front of a noun, although you do use *too* in front of the determiners *many, much*, and *few*.

**Example 2.6.30.** *There is too much chance of error.*
*Too few people nowadays are interested in literature.*
*You ask too many questions, Sam.*

2.154 [!] *Too* cannot be used instead of *very*.

Rather than saying *I am too happy to meet you*, you must say *I am very happy to meet you*.

2.155 Other words that indicate too much of a quality are *excessively, overly*, and the prefix *over-*.

These can be used, like *too*, with adjectives that come after a linking verb, but they can also be used with adjectives in front of a noun.

**Example 2.6.31.** *... excessively high accident rates.*
*... an intellectual but over-cautious man.*
*They were overly eager.*

2.156 [⋆] As well as adverbs of degree like *excessively* and *insufficiently*, you can use some other types of adverb in front of adjectives to modify their meaning.

**Example 2.6.32.** *... the once elegant palace.*
*... a permanently muddy road.*
*... internationally famous golfers.*
*... naturally blonde hair.*
*... coolly elegant furniture.*
*... purposely expensive gadgets.*

Adverbs are explained in Chap. 6.

## 2.7 Saying things are different

2.157 When you are using comparative adjectives, you may want to say that something has much more or much less of a quantity than something else.

You do this by adding words like *much* or *a little*.

**Example 2.7.1.** *It is a much better school than yours.*
*These creatures are much less mobile.*
*These are far worse dangers.*
*Some children are a lot more difficult than others.*

You also use these words to say that something has much more or much less of a quality than it had before.

**Example 2.7.2.** *He had become much more nature.*
*That's much less important than it was.*

2.158 Some modifying words and phrases are only used when comparative adjectives are being used after linking verbs.

**Example 2.7.3.** *You look a lot better.*
*It would be a good deal easier if you came to my place.*
*The journey back was a great deal more unpleasant than the outward one had been.*

Here is a list of modifying words and phrases used in front of comparative adjectives after a linking verb:

**Example 2.7.4.** *a good deal, a great deal, a lot, heaps, lots*

Note that *lots* and *heaps* are only used in informal spoken English.

2.159 However, other submodifying adverbs can be used with comparative adjectives that are being used either in front of a noun or after a linking verb.

**Example 2.7.5.** *They are faced with a much harder problem than the rest of us.*
*The risk from smoking is much greater if you have a weak heart.*
*Computers can be applied to a far wider range of tasks.*
*The delay was far longer than they claimed.*

Here is a list of submodifying adverbs used with adjectives that are used both in front of a noun and after a linking verb:

**Example 2.7.6.** *considerably, far, infinitely, much, vastly, very much*

2.160 [i] If you want to say that something has more of a quality than something else that already has a lot of it, you use *even* or *still* before a comparative adjective, or *still* after it.

**Example 2.7.7.** *She's even lazier than me!*
*She was even more possessive than Rosamund.*
*I had a still more recent report.*
*The text is actually worse still/*

Similarly, you use *even* or *still* to say that something has less of a quality than something else that has little of this quality.

**Example 2.7.8.** *This did not happen before the war, and is now even less likely.*

You also use *even* or *still* when comparing the amount of a quality that something has at 1 time with the amount that it has at another.

**Example 2.7.9.** *The flight was even faster coming back.*
*They will become richer still.*

In formal or literary English, *yet* is sometimes used in the same way as *still*.

**Example 2.7.10.** *He would have been yet more alarmed had she withdrawn.*
*The planes grow mightier yet.*

2.161 You can show that something has an increasing or decreasing amount of a quality by repeating comparative adjectives. E.g., you can say that something is getting *bigger and bigger, more and more difficult*, or *less and less common*.

**Example 2.7.11.** *He's getting taller and taller.*
*... defences that were proving more and more effective.*

*Increasingly* can be used instead of *more and more* and *decreasingly* instead of *less and less*.

**Example 2.7.12.** *I was becoming increasingly depressed.*
*It was the 1st of a number of increasingly frank talks.*

2.162 If you want to say that something has a little more or a little less of a quality than something else, you use *rather, slightly, a bit, a little bit*, or *a little* with comparative adjectives.

**Example 2.7.13.** *It's a rather more complicated story than that.*
*She's only a little bit taller than her sister.*

You also use these forms to say that something has a little more or a little less of a quality than it had before.

**Example 2.7.14.** *We must be rather more visible to people in the community.*
*... the little things that made life slightly less intolerable.*

2.163 If you want to say emphatically that something has no more of a quality than something else or than it had before, you can use *no* in front of comparative adjectives.

**Example 2.7.15.** *Some species of dinosaur were no bigger than a chicken.*

*Any* is used for emphasis in front of comparatives in negative clauses, questions, and conditional clauses.
E.g., *He wasn't any taller than Jane* means the same as *He was no taller than Jane*.

**Example 2.7.16.** *I was 10 and didn't look any older.*
*If it will make you any happier, I'll shave off my beard.*
*Is that any clearer?*

Note that you only use *no* and *any* like this when comparatives are being used after a linking verb.
You cannot use *no* and *any* with comparatives when they are being used in front of a noun phrase.
E.g., you cannot say *It was a no better meal* or *Is that an any faster train?*

2.164 When you use the comparative structure *as... as...* (see paragraphs **2.124–2.130**), submodifying words e.g. *just, quite, nearly*, and *almost* can be used in front of it, modifying the comparison with their usual meanings.

**Example 2.7.17.** *Mary was just as pale as he was.*
*There is nothing quite as lonely as illness.*
*... a huge bird which was nearly as big as a man.*
*The land seemed almost as dark as the water.*

*Nearly* is also used when the *as... as...* structure is preceded by *not* with the meaning *less... than*.
You put it after the *not*.
E.g., *I am not nearly as tall as George* means the same as *I am much less tall than George*.

**Example 2.7.18.** *This is not nearly as complicated as it sounds.*

2.165 When you use *like* to describe someone or something by comparing them with someone or something else (see paragraphs **2.132–2.134**), you can use a submodifying adverb in front of it.

**Example 2.7.19.** *... animals that looked a little like donkeys.*
*It's a plane exactly like his.*

Here is a list of modifying words and phrases used with *like*:

**Example 2.7.20.** *a bit, a little, exactly, just, quite, rather, somewhat, very*

2.166 When you use *the same as* and *the same* to describe someone or something by saying they are identical to someone or something else, you can use a number of submodifying adverbs in front of them, including *just, exactly, much, nearly, virtually*, and *more or less*.

**Example 2.7.21.** *I'm just the same as everyone else.*
*The situation was much the same in Germany.*
*The moral code would seem to be more or less the same throughout the world.*

2.167 When you are using superlative adjectives, you may wish to say that something has much more or much less of a quality than anything else of its kind.
The submodifying adverbs *much, quite, easily, by far*, and *very* can be used with the superlative adjectives.
*Much, quite*, and *easily* are placed in front of *the* and the superlative.

**Example 2.7.22.** *Music may have been much the most respectable of his tastes.*
*... the most frightening time of my life, and quite the most dishonest.*
*This is easily the best film of the year.*

*By far* can be placed either in front of *the* and the superlative or after the superlative.

**Example 2.7.23.** *They are by far the most dangerous creatures on the island.*
*The Union was the largest by far.*

2.168 *Very* is only used with superlatives formed by adding *-est* or with irregular superlatives e.g. *1st* or *last*.

**Example 2.7.24.** *... in the very smallest countries.*
*... 1 of the very finest breeds of dogs.*
*... on the very 1st day of the war.*
*He had come at the very last moment.*
*That very next afternoon he was working in his room.*
*He spent weeks in that very same basement.*

## 2.8 Modifying using nouns: noun modifiers

2.169 Nouns can be used as modifiers in front of other nouns when you want to give more specific information about someone or something.
Sometimes, when nouns are used like this they become fixed expressions called **compound nouns** (see paragraphs **1.83–1.92**).
When the nouns used in front of other nouns are not in fixed expressions, they are called **noun modifiers**.

**Example 2.8.1.** *... the car door.*
*... tennis lessons.*
*... a football player.*
*... cat food.*
*... the music industry.*
*... a surprise announcement.*

2.170 You normally use the singular form of a **countable noun** (see paragraphs **1.15**–**1.22**) as a noun modifier, even when you are referring to more than 1 thing.

E.g., you refer to a shop that sells books as *a book shop*, not *a books shop*, even though it sells a large number of books, not just 1.

Many **plural nouns** lose their *-s* endings when used in front of other nouns.

**Example 2.8.2.** ... *my trouser pocket.*
... *pyjama trousers.*
... *paratroop attacks.*

Here is a list of common plural nouns that lose their *-s* and *-es* endings when they are used as modifiers:

**Example 2.8.3.** *knickers, paratroops, pyjamas, scissors, spectacles, troops, trousers*

However, some plural nouns keep the same form when used in front of other nouns.

**Example 2.8.4.** ... *arms control.*
... *clothes pegs.*

Here is a list of common plural nouns that remain the same when they are used as modifiers:

**Example 2.8.5.** *arms, binoculars, clothes, glasses, jeans, sunglasses*

Plural nouns are explained in paragraphs **1.41**–**1.46**.

2.171 If you want to be even more specific, you can use more than 1 noun modifier.

E.g., a *car insurance certificate* is a certificate that shows that a car has been insured, and a *state pension scheme* is a scheme that is run by the state and concerns workers' pensions.

**Example 2.8.6.** ... *a Careers Information Officer.*
... *car body repair kits.*
... *a family dinner party.*
... *a school medical officer.*

2.172 If you want to give more information about a noun that has a noun modifier in front of it, you can put **adjectives** in front of the noun modifier.

**Example 2.8.7.** ... *a long car journey.*
... *a new scarlet silk handkerchief.*
... *complex business deals.*
... *this beautiful morning sunlight.*
... *the French film industry.*

When an adjective comes in front of 2 nouns, it is usually obvious whether it is modifying the 2 nouns combined or only the noun modifier.

E.g., in *an electric can opener*, the adjective *electric* is modifying the combination *can opener*, whereas in *electric shock treatment, electric* is modifying the noun *shock* and then both the adjective and the noun modifier are modifying the noun *treatment*.

Adjectives are explained in paragraphs **2.2**–**2.102**.

2.173 **Proper nouns** can also be used as noun modifiers.

E.g., if you want to show that something is connected with a place, organization, or institution, you put the name of the place, organization, or institution in front of all other noun modifiers.

You also put them in front of classifying adjectives.

**Example 2.8.8.** ... *Brighton Technical College.*
... *the Cambridge House Literacy Scheme.*

Proper nouns are explained in paragraphs **1.52**–**1.58**.

2.174 [⋆] The use of noun modifiers in English is very common indeed.

In fact, when the context makes it clear what you mean, you can use almost any noun to modify any other noun.

You can use noun modifiers to talk about a wide range of relationships between the 2 nouns.

E.g., you can say what something is made of, as in *cotton socks*.

You can also say what is made in a particular place, as in *a glass factory*.

You can say what someone does, as in *a football player*, or you can say where something is, as in *my bedroom curtains*.

You can say when something happens, as in *the morning mist* and *he wartime activities*.

You can also describe the nature or size of something, as in *a surprise attack* and *a pocket chess-set*.

## 2.9 Talking about quantities & amounts

2.175 This section deals with ways of talking about quantities and amounts of things.

You often refer to quantities by using a number, but sometimes in everyday situations you can do this by using a word or a phrase e.g. *several* or *a lot* and link it with *of* to the following noun.

Quantity expressions like these are explained in paragraphs **2.176–2.193**.

When phrases e.g. *a bottle* are used like this, they are called **partitives**.

Partitives are explained in paragraphs **2.194–2.207**.

When you want to be very precise about the quality or amount of something, you can use **numbers** (see paragraphs **2.208–2.239**) or **fractions** (see paragraphs **2.240–2.249**).

Numbers, fractions, and quantity expressions are also used in expressions of measurement to indicate the size, weight, length, and so on, of something.

Ways of talking about **measurements** are explained in paragraphs **2.250–2.257**.

Approximate measurements are explained in paragraphs **2.264–2.271**.

Numbers are also used to say how old someone or something is.

This is explained in paragraphs **2.258–2.263**.

### 2.9.1 Talking about amounts of things: *a lot of ideas, plenty of shops*

2.176 When you want to talk about a quantity of things or an amount of something, you can use the pronoun form of some indefinite determiners (e.g. *all* or *both*) followed by *of* and a noun phrase.

**Example 2.9.1.** *I am sure both of you agree with me.*
*Most of the population have fled.*
*All of her children live abroad.*

2.177 Here is the list of indefinite determiners that can be used in this way.

*Of* is given after each as a reminder.

**Example 2.9.2.** *all of, another of, any of, both of, each of, either of, enough of, (a) few of, fewer of, less of, (a) little of, lots of, many of, more of, most of, much of, neither of, none of, 1 of, several of, some of*

You can also use a phrase e.g. *a lot of* or *a number of* to talk about quantity in the same way.

**Example 2.9.3.** *... a house with lots of windows.*
*I make a lot of mistakes.*
*In Tunis there are a number of art galleries.*
*I never found the rest of my relatives.*

2.178 Here is a list of phrases that can be used to talk about quantity.

**Example 2.9.4.** *an amount of, a bit of, a little bit of, a couple of, a good deal of, a great deal of, a lot of, a good many of, a great many of, a number of, plenty of, a quantity of*
*a majority of, the majority of, a minority of*
*part of, the remainder of, the rest of, the whole of*
*gobs of (*American*), heaps of, loads of, masses of, tons of*

Note that the words in the last group in this list are used in informal speech only.

2.179 Some of these quantity expressions are linked by *of* only to noun phrases that begin with a definite determiner e.g. *the, these*, or *my*.

A pronoun e.g. *us, them*, or *these* can also be used after *of*.

**Example 2.9.5.** *Nearly all of the increase has been caused by inflation.*
*Part of the farm lay close to the river bank.*
*Only a few of them were armed.*

Here is a list of quantity expressions with *of* that are usually or always followed by noun phrases beginning with definite determiners:

**Example 2.9.6.** *all of, another of, any of, both of, certain of, each of, either of, enough of, few of, fewer of, less of, little of, many of, more of, most of, much of, neither of, none of, 1 of, part of, several of, some of, various of*
*a few of, a little of, a good many of, a great many of*
*the remainder of, the rest of, the whole of*

2.180 Some of these quantity expressions can also be used with place names.

**Example 2.9.7.** *Much of America will be shocked by what happened.*
*. . . involving most of Africa and a lot of South America.*

Here is a list of quantity expressions used with place names:

**Example 2.9.8.** *all of, less of, more of, most of, much of, none of, part of, some of*
*a bit of, a little bit of, a good deal of, a great deal of, a lot of*
*the rest of, the whole of*

2.181 When you use a quantity expression as the subject of a verb, the verb is singular or plural depending on whether the quantity expression refers to 1 thing or to more than 1 thing.

**Example 2.9.9.** *Some of the information has already been analyzed.*
*Some of my best friends are policemen.*

2.182 Many quantity expressions can only be used in front of plural noun phrases.

**Example 2.9.10.** *I am sure both of you agree with me.*
*Start by looking through their papers for either of the 2 documents mentioned below.*
*Few of these organizations survive for long.*
*Several of his best books are about space flight.*
*I would like to ask you a couple of questions.*
*The report contained large numbers of inaccuracies.*

Here is a list of quantity expressions that are only used with plural noun phrases:

**Example 2.9.11.** *another of, both of, certain of, each of, either of, few of, fewer of, many of, neither of, numbers of, 1 of, several of, various of*
*a couple of, a few of, a good many of, a great many of, a number of*

For more information about *each of* see paragraphs **2.186–2.187**, about *fewer of* see paragraph **2.189**, and about *a number of* see paragraphs **2.191–2.192**.
Note that *neither of* is used in a similar way to *either of* when you are talking about 2 things in negative clauses.
This is explained in paragraphs **5.81**.

2.183 A few quantity expressions are only used with uncountable nouns and singular noun phrases.

**Example 2.9.12.** *Much of the day was taken up with classes.*
*This is a bit of a change.*
*There was a good deal of smoke.*
*If you use rich milk, pour off a little of the cream.*
*I spent the whole of last year working there.*

Here is a list of quantity expressions only used with uncountable nouns and singular noun phrases:

**Example 2.9.13.** *less of, little of, much of, part of*
*a bit of, a little bit of, a good deal of, a great deal of, a little of*
*the whole of*

For more information about *less of* see paragraph **2.189**.

2.184 A very few quantity expressions are used only with plural noun phrases and uncountable nouns.

**Example 2.9.14.** *. . . the seizure of vast quantities of illegal weapons.*
*Very large quantities of aid were needed.*
*They had loads of things to say about each other.*
*We had loads of room.*
*. . . plenty of the men.*
*Make sure you give plenty of notice.*

Here is a list of quantity expressions that are only used with plural noun phrases and uncountable nouns:

**Example 2.9.15.** *plenty of, quantities of*
*gobs of (*American*), heaps of, loads of, masses of, tons of*

Note that when the 2nd group in this list are used with an uncountable noun as the subject of a verb, the verb is singular, even though the quantity expression looks plural.

**Example 2.9.16.** *Masses and masses of food was left over.*

2.185 Some quantity expressions can be used with plural nouns, with singular nouns, or with uncountable nouns.

**Example 2.9.17.** *... some of the most distinguished men of our time.*
*We did some of the journey by night.*
*Some of the gossip was surprisingly accurate.*

Here is a list of quantity expressions that are used with plural nouns, singular nouns, or uncountable nouns:

**Example 2.9.18.** *all of, any of, enough of, lots of, more of, most of, none of, some of*
*an amount of, a lot of, a quantity of*
*the remainder of, the rest of*

Note that *an amount of* is nearly always used with an adjective e.g. *small*: *a small amount of.*
This is explained in paragraph **2.191**.
Note also that when *lots of* is used with an uncountable noun as the subject of a verb, the verb is singular, even though the quantity expression looks plural.

**Example 2.9.19.** *He thought that lots of lovely money was the source of happiness.*

*Any of* is explained more fully in paragraphs **2.188**.
2.186 [i] When you want to refer to each member of a particular group, you can use *each of* and a plural noun phrase.

**Example 2.9.20.** *Each of the drawings is slightly different.*
*We feel quite differently about each of our children.*
*Work out how much you can afford to pay each of them.*

Note that *each one* and *every one* can be used before *of* instead of *each*, for emphasis.

**Example 2.9.21.** *This view of poverty influences each one of us.*
*Every one of them is given a financial target.*

2.187 [!] When the quantity expression *each of* is used with a plural noun phrase, the verb after the noun phrase is always singular.
2.188 [i] *Any of* can refer to 1 or several people or things, or to part of something.
Note that if it is the subject of a verb, when it refers to several things, the verb is plural, and when it refers to a part of something, the verb is singular.

**Example 2.9.22.** *She has those coats. She might have been wearing any of them.*
*Hardly any of these find their way into consumer products.*
*Has any of this been helpful?*
*It was more expensive than any of the other magazines we were normally able to afford.*

2.189 There are 3 comparative quantity expressions that can be used before noun phrases.
*Less of* is usually used with singular nouns and uncountable nouns, *fewer of* is usually used with plural nouns, and *more of* is used with all 3 types of noun.

**Example 2.9.23.** *I enjoy cooking far more now, because I do less of it.*
*Fewer of these children will become bored.*
*He was far more of an existentialist.*

Note that *more of* is sometimes used in front of a noun phrase to intensify it.

**Example 2.9.24.** *He could hardy have felt more of a fool than he did at that moment.*
*She was more of a flirt than ever.*
*America is much more of a classless society.*

Note also hat *less of* is sometimes used instead of *fewer of*, but many people think that this is not correct.
2.190 When the context makes it clear, or when you think that the person you are talking to will understand what you mean, you can sometimes reduce the structure to the quantity word only.
E.g., if you are talking about applications for a job and there were 20 candidates, you can say *Some were very good* rather than *Some of them were very good.*

**Example 2.9.25.** *A few crossed over the bridge.*
*Some parts can be separated from the whole.*
*I have 4 bins. I keep one in the kitchen and the rest in the dustbin area.*
*Most of the books had been packed into an enormous trunk and the remainder piled on top of it.*

2.191 [i] You can add adjectives to *a number of* and *a quantity of* to say how large or small an amount or number of things is.

**Example 2.9.26.** *The city attracts a large number of tourists.*
*We had a limited number of people to choose from.*
*The novel provides an enormous quantity of information.*
*... a tiny quantity of acid.*

*An amount of* is always used with adjectives, and is usually used with uncountable nouns.

**Example 2.9.27.** *Pour a small amount of the sauce over the kitchen.*
*He has a large amount of responsibility.*
*It only involves a small amount of time.*
*There has to be a certain amount of hard work.*

The plural forms of *quantity, number*, and *amount* are used, especially when referring to separate amounts.

**Example 2.9.28.** *... groups that employ large numbers of low-paid workers.*
*Enormous amounts of money are spent on advertising.*

2.192 When a quantity expression contains an adjective, you can put *very* in front of the adjective.

**Example 2.9.29.** *... a very great deal of work.*
*... a very large amount of money.*

2.193 Some quantity expressions can be modified using *quite*.

**Example 2.9.30.** *I've wasted quite enough of my life here.*
*Quite a few of the employees are beginning to realize the truth.*
*Most of them have had quite a lot of experience.*
*... quite a large amount of industry.*

Here is a list of quantity expressions that can be modified by *quite*:

**Example 2.9.31.** *enough, a few, a lot of, a large amount of, a small amount of, a number of, a large number of*

### 2.9.2 Talking about particular amounts of things: *a piece of paper, a drop of water*

2.194 When you want to talk about a particularly quantity of something, you can use a **partitive** structure that consists of a particular partitive (e.g. *piece*) linked by *of* to another noun.
Partitives are always countable nouns.

**Example 2.9.32.** *Who owns this bit of land?*
*... portions of mashed potato.*

If the partitive is singular, then the verb used with it is usually singular.
If it is plural, the verb is also plural.

**Example 2.9.33.** *A piece of paper is lifeless.*
*2 pieces of metal were being rubbed together.*

Note that all partitives consist of 2 or more words, because *of* is needed in every case.
*Of* is printed in the lists below as a reminder.
2.195 When the noun after the partitive is an uncountable noun, you use countable noun e.g. *bit, drop, lump*, or *piece* as the partitive.

**Example 2.9.34.** *Here's a bit of paper.*
*... a drop of blood.*
*Drops of sweat dripped from his forehead.*
*... a tiny piece of material.*
*... a pinch of salt.*
*... specks of dust.*

These partitives can be used without *of* when it is obvious what you are talking about.

**Example 2.9.35.** *He sat down in the kitchen before a plate of cold ham, but he had only eaten 1 piece when the phone rang.*

2.196 Here is a list of partitives used with uncountable nouns:

**Example 2.9.36.** *amount of, bit of, blob of, chunk of, dash of, drop of, grain of, heap of, knob of, lump of, mass of, morsel of, mountain of, piece of, pile of, pinch of, pool of, portion of, scrap of, sheet of, shred of, slice of, speck of, spot of, touch of, trace of*

Some of these partitives are also used with plural nouns referring to things that together form a mass.

**Example 2.9.37.** *. . . a huge heap of stones.*
*. . . a pile of newspapers.*

Here is a list of partitives used with both uncountable and plural nouns:

**Example 2.9.38.** *amount of, clump of, heap of, mass of, mountain of, pile of, portion of*

2.197 [⋆] Many nouns that refer to the shape of an amount of something can also be partitives with uncountable or plural nouns.

**Example 2.9.39.** *. . . a ball of wool.*
*. . . columns of smoke.*
*. . . a ring of excited faces.*

Here is a list of partitives used for talking about the shape of an amount of something:

**Example 2.9.40.** *ball of, column of, ring of, shaft of, square of, stick of, strip of, thread of, tuft of, wall of*

Many nouns that refer to both shape and movement can also be used as partitives.

**Example 2.9.41.** *It blew a jet of water into the air.*
*. . . a constant stream of children passing through the door.*

Here is a list of partitives used for talking about both shape and movement:

**Example 2.9.42.** *dribble of, gush of, gust of, jet of, shower of, spurt of, stream of, torrent of*

[⋆] You can use any noun to describe shape in this way.
E.g., you can talk about *a triangle of snooker balls.*
2.198 There are many nouns that refer to groups that can be used as partitives.
They are linked by *of* to plural nouns that indicate what the group consists of.

**Example 2.9.43.** *It was evaluated by an independent team of inspectors.*
*A group of journalists gathered at the airport to watch us take off.*
*. . . a bunch of flowers.*

Here is a list of partitives referring to groups:

**Example 2.9.44.** *audience of, bunch of, clump of, company of, family of, flock of, gang of, group of, herd of, team of, troupe of*

[⋆] You can use any noun referring to a group of people or things in this way.
E.g., you can talk about *an army of volunteers.*
2.199 Nouns referring to measurements are often used in partitive structures to talk about an amount of something that is a particular length, area, volume, or weight.
Uncountable nouns are used after *of* in structures referring to length, and both uncountable and plural nouns are used in structures referring to weight.

**Example 2.9.45.** *. . . 10 yards of velvet.*
*Thousands of square miles of land have been contaminated.*
*I drink a pint of milk a day.*
*. . . 3 pounds of strawberries.*
*. . . 10 ounces of cheese.*

Nouns referring to measurements are explained in paragraphs **2.250–2.257**.

2.200 You use partitives when you want to talk about the contents of a container as well as to the container itself.
E.g., you can refer to a carton filled with milk as *a carton of milk*.

**Example 2.9.46.** *I went to buy a bag of chips.*
*The waiter appeared with a bottle of red wine.*
*. . . a packet of cigarettes.*
*. . . a pot of honey.*
*. . . tubes of glue.*

You can also use partitives to refer to the contents only.

**Example 2.9.47.** *They drank another bottle of champagne.*
*She ate a whole box of chocolates.*

Here is a list of partitives referring to containers:

**Example 2.9.48.** *bag of, barrel of, basin of, basket of, bottle of, bowl of, box of, bucket of, can of, carton of, case of, cask of, crate of, cup of, glass of, jar of, jug of, mug of, pack of, packet of, plate of, pot of, sack of, spoon of, tablespoon of, tank of, teaspoon of, tin of, tub of, tube of, tumbler of*

2.201 You can add *-ful* to these partitives referring to containers.

**Example 2.9.49.** *He brought me a bagful of sweets.*
*Pour a bucketful of cold water on the ash.*
*. . . a cupful of boiled water.*
*. . . a tankful of petrol.*

Here is a list of partitives referring to containers that are very commonly used with *-ful*:

**Example 2.9.50.** *bag, basket, box, bucket, cup, plate, spoon, tablespoon, tank, teaspoon*

When people want to make a noun ending in *-ful* plural, they usually add an *-s* to the end of the word, as in *bucketfuls*. However some people put the *-s* in front of *-ful*, as in *bucketsful*.

**Example 2.9.51.** *She ladled 3 spoonfuls of sugar into my tea.*
*They were collecting basketfuls of apples.*
*. . . 2 teaspoonfuls of powder.*
*. . . 2 teaspoonsful of milk.*

2.202 [⋆] You can also add *-ful* to other partitives.

**Example 2.9.52.** *Eleanor was holding an armful of red roses.*
*I went outside to throw a handful of bread to the birds.*
*He took another mouthful of whisky.*
*. . . a houseful of children.*

2.203 [i] You sometimes use a mass noun instead of a partitive structure.
E.g., *2 teas* means the same as *2 cups of tea*, and *2 sugars* means *2 spoonfuls of sugar*.

**Example 2.9.53.** *We drank a couple of beers.*
*I asked for 2 coffees with milk.*

**Mass nouns** are explained in paragraphs **1.28–1.31**.

2.204 You use a partitive when you want to talk about a part or a fraction of a particular thing.

**Example 2.9.54.** *I spent a large part of my life in broadcasting.*
*The system is breaking down in many parts of Africa.*
*A large portion of the university budget goes into the Community Services area.*
*. . . a mass movement involving all segments of society.*

Here is a list of partitives referring to a part of something:

**Example 2.9.55.** *part of, portion of, section of, segment of*

2.205 You use a partitive with an uncountable noun referring to things of a certain type when you want to refer to 1 particular thing of that type.

**Example 2.9.56.** *... an article of clothing.*
*I bought a few bits of furniture.*
*Any item of information can be accessed.*

Here is a list of partitives referring to 1 thing of a particular type:

**Example 2.9.57.** *article of, bit of, item of, piece of*

Here is a list of uncountable nouns referring to things of a certain type that are often used with the partitives listed above:

**Example 2.9.58.** *advice, apparatus, baggage, clothing, equipment, furniture, homework, information, knowledge, luggage, machinery, news, research*

2.206 Some plural nouns refer to things that are normally thought to consist of 2 parts, e.g. trousers or scissors.
Some others refer to things that are made in twos, e.g. shoes or shocks.
When you want to talk about 1 of these 2-part items, or 2-item sets, you use the partitive *pair* linked to these plural nouns by *of*.

**Example 2.9.59.** *... a pair of jeans.*
*... a pair of tights.*
*... a dozen pairs of sunglasses.*
*I brought a pair of tennis shoes.*
*I smashed 3 pairs of skis.*

These **plural nouns** are explained in paragraphs **1.41–1.46**.
2.207 [⋆] Whenever you want to

(i) talk about a limited amount of something,

(ii) indicate the area that something occupies, or

(iii) specify a particular feature that something has,

you can use a noun that indicates the amount or the nature of the thing (e.g. *bottle*), linked by *of* to a noun that indicates what the thing is (e.g. *water*).
E.g., if you say *a forest of pines*, you are talking about a large area of trees.
Similarly, you can talk about *a border of roses*.
This structure can be extended very widely, so that you can talk about *a city of dreaming spires*, e.g.

## 2.10 Referring to an exact number of things: numbers

2.208 When you want to refer to an exact number of things, you use numbers e.g. *two, thirty*, and *777*, which are called **cardinal numbers**, or sometimes **cardinals**.

**Example 2.10.1.** *I'm going to ask you 30 questions.*
*... 260 copies of the record.*

The cardinal numbers are listed in the Reference section and their use is explained in paragraphs **2.213–2.231**.
2.209 When you want to identify or describe something by showing where it comes in a series or sequence, you use an **ordinal number**, or an **ordinal**, e.g. *1st, 2nd, 14th*, or *27th*.

**Example 2.10.2.** *She received a video camera for her 14th birthday.*
*I repeated my story for the 3rd time that day.*

The ordinal numbers are listed in the Reference section and their use is explained in paragraphs **2.232–2.239**.
2.210 When you want to show how large a part of something is compared to the whole of it, you use a **fraction** e.g. *a 3rd* or *3-quarters*.

**Example 2.10.3.** *A 3rd of the American forces were involved.*
*The bottle was about 3-quarters full when he started.*

Fractions are explained in paragraphs **2.240–2.249**.
2.211 When you want to talk about a size, distance, area, volume, weight, speed, or temperature, you can do so by using a number or quantity expression in front of a **measurement noun** e.g. *feet* and *miles*.

**Example 2.10.4.** *He was about 6 feet tall.*
*It's 4 miles to the city center from here.*

Measurements nouns are explained in paragraphs **2.250–2.257**.

If you do not know the exact number, size, or quantity of something, you can give an approximate amount of measurement using 1 of a group of special words and expressions.

These are explained in paragraphs **2.263–2.271**.

2.212 When you want to say how old someone or something is, you have a choice of ways in which to do it.

These are explained in paragraphs **2.258–2.263**.

### 2.10.1 Talking about the number of things: cardinal numbers

2.213 If you want to talk about some or all of the things in a group, you can show how many things you are talking about by using a **cardinal number**.

The cardinal numbers are listed in the Reference section.

**Example 2.10.5.** *By Christmas, we had 10 cows.*

When you use a determiner and a number in front of a noun, you put the determiner in front of the number.

**Example 2.10.6.** *... the 3 young men.*
*... my 2 daughters.*
*Watch the eyes of any 2 people engrossed in conversation.*
*All 3 candidates are coming to Blackpool later this week.*

When you put a number and an adjective in front of a noun, you usually put the number in front of the adjective.

**Example 2.10.7.** *... 2 small children.*
*... 1500 local residents.*
*... 3 beautiful young girls.*

2.214 *One* is used as a number in front of a noun to emphasize that there is only 1 thing, to show that you are being precise, or to contrast 1 thing with another.

*One* is followed by a singular noun.

**Example 2.10.8.** *That is the 1 big reservation I've got.*
*He balanced himself on 1 foot.*
*There was only 1 gate into the palace.*
*This treaty was signed 1 year after the Suez Crisis.*
*It was negative in 1 respect but positive in another.*

*One* is also used, like other numbers, as a quantity expression.

**Example 2.10.9.** *1 of my students sold me her ticket.*
*... 1 of the few great novels of the century.*
*It's 1 of the best films I've ever seen.*

*One* also has special uses a determiner and a pronoun.

These are explained in paragraph **1.249** and paragraphs **1.158–1.161**.

2.215 When a large number begins with the figure *1*, the *1* can be said or written as *a* or *one*.

*One* is more formal.

**Example 2.10.10.** *... a million dollars.*
*... a hundred and fifty miles.*
*Over one million pounds has been raised.*

2.216 The number 0 is not used in ordinary English to say that the number of things you are talking about is zero.

Instead the negative determiner *no* or the negative pronoun *none* is used, or *any* is used with a negative.

These are explained in paragraphs **5.51** and **5.71–5.73**.

2.217 When you use any number except *one* in front of a noun, you use a plural noun.

**Example 2.10.11.** *There were 10 people there, all men.*
*... 100 years.*
*... 101 things.*

2.218 When you use a number and a plural noun to talk about 2 or more things, you usually use a plural verb.
You use a singular verb with *one*.

**Example 2.10.12.** *7 guerrillas were wounded.*
*There is 1 clue.*

However, when you are talking about an amount of money or time, or a distance, speed, or weight, you usually use a number, a plural noun, and a singular verb.

**Example 2.10.13.** *300 pounds is a lot of money.*
*10 years is a long time.*
*26 miles is a long way to run.*
*90 miles an hour is much too fast.*
*90 pounds is all she weighs.*

Ways of measuring things are explained in paragraphs **2.250–2.257**.
2.219 You can use cardinal numbers with both **ordinals** (see paragraphs **2.232–2.239**) and **postdeterminers** (see paragraph **2.40**).
When you use a cardinal number with a determiner followed by an ordinal number of a postdeterminer, the cardinal number usually comes after the determiner and the ordinal or postdeterminer.

**Example 2.10.14.** *The 1st 2 years have been very successful.*
*... throughout the 1st 4 months of this year.*
*... the last 2 volumes of the encyclopedia.*
*... in the previous 3 years of his reign.*

Note that some postdeterminers can be used like ordinary **classifying adjectives** (see paragraph **2.40**).
When they are used like this, the cardinal number comes before them.

**Example 2.10.15.** *He has written 2 previous novels.*
*... 2 further examples.*

2.220 When either the context makes it clear, or you think that your listener already knows something, you can use the cardinal number without a noun.

**Example 2.10.16.** *These 2 are quite different.*

When cardinal numbers are used like this, you can put ordinal numbers, postdeterminers, or superlatives adjectives in between the determiner and the cardinal number.

**Example 2.10.17.** *I want to tell you about the programmes. The 1st 4 are devoted to universities.*
*The other 6 are masterpieces.*
*The best 30 have the potential to be successful journalists.*

2.221 When you use *dozen, hundred, thousand, million*, or *billion* to indicate exact numbers, you put *a* or another number in front of them.

**Example 2.10.18.** *... a hundred dollars.*
*... 610 miles.*
*... a thousand billion pounds.*
*... 2 dozen diapers.*

2.222 [!] When you use *dozen, hundred, thousand, million*, or *billion* they remain singular even when the number in front of them is greater than 1.
2.223 [!] You can use *dozen, hundred, thousand, million*, or *billion* without *of* in a less precise way by putting *several, a few*, and *a couple of* in front of them.

**Example 2.10.19.** *... several hundred people.*
*A few thousand cars have gone.*
*... life a couple of hundred years ago.*

2.224 When you want to emphasize how large a number is without stating it precisely, you can use *dozens, hundreds, thousands, millions*, and *billions* in the same way as cardinals followed by *of*.

**Example 2.10.20.** *That's going to take hundreds of years.*
*... hundreds of dollars.*
*We traveled thousands of miles across Europe.*
*... languages spoken by millions of people.*
*We have dozens of friends in the community.*

You can put *many* in front of these plural forms.

**Example 2.10.21.** *I have traveled many hundreds of miles with them.*

2.225 [i] People often use the plural forms when they are exaggerating.

**Example 2.10.22.** *I was meeting thousands of people.*
*Do you have to fill in hundreds of forms before you go?*

You can also emphasize or exaggerate a large number of using these words in phrases beginning with *by*.

**Example 2.10.23.** *... a book which sells by the million.*
*... people who give injections by the dozen.*
*Videos of the royal wedding sold by the hundred thousand.*

2.226 Cardinal numbers are used to label or identify things.

**Example 2.10.24.** *Room 777 of the Stanley Hotel.*
*Number 11 Downing Street.*

2.227 You can also use cardinal numbers as quantity expressions linked by *of* to a noun phrase referring to a group.
You do this when you want to emphasize that you are talking about a part or all of a group.

**Example 2.10.25.** *I saw 4 of these programmes.*
*3 of the questions today have been about democracy.*
*I use plastic kitchen bins. I have 4 of them.*
*All 8 of my great-grandparents lived in the city.*
*All 4 of us wanted to get away from the Earl's Court area.*
*The clerk looked at the 6 of them and said, All of you?*
*I find it less worrying than the 2 of you are suggesting.*

Quantity expressions are explained in paragraphs **2.176**–**2.193**.
2.228 Cardinal numbers are used to quantify something without the *of* and the noun phrase, when it is clear what you are referring to.

**Example 2.10.26.** *... a group of painters, 9 or 10 in all.*
*Of the other wives, 2 are dancers and 1 is a singer.*
*... the taller student of the 2.*
*... breakfast for 2.*

2.229 Cardinal numbers are also used after subject pronouns.

**Example 2.10.27.** *In the fall we 2 are going to England.*
*You 4, come with me.*

2.230 Cardinal numbers can be used as part of a **compound adjective** (see paragraphs **2.94**–**2.102**).
The cardinal number is used in front of a noun to form a compound adjective that is usually hyphenated

**Example 2.10.28.** *He took out a 5-dollar bill.*
*I wrote a 5-page summary of the situation.*

Note that the noun remains singular even when the number is 2 or more, and that compound adjectives that are formed like this cannot be used after a linking verb.
E.g., you cannot say *My essay is five-hundred-word.*
Instead you would probably say *My essay is 500 words long.*
2.231 Cardinal numbers are sometimes used with general time words e.g. *month* and *week*.
You do this when you want to describe something by saying how long it lasts.
If the thing is referred to with an uncountable noun, you use the **possessive form** (see paragraphs **1.211**–**1.222**) of the general time word.

**Example 2.10.29.** *She's already had at least 9 months' experience.*
*On Friday she had been given 2 weeks' notice.*

Sometimes the apostrophe is omitted.

**Example 2.10.30.** *They wanted 3 weeks holiday and 3 weeks pay.*

The determiner *a* is usually used when you are talking about a single period of time, although *one* can be used instead when you want to be more formal.

**Example 2.10.31.** *She's on a year's leave from Hunter College.*
*He was only given 1 week's notice.*

Cardinal numbers are also used with general time words as modifiers of adjectives.

**Example 2.10.32.** *She was 4 months pregnant.*
*The rains are 2 months late.*
*His rent was 3 weeks overdue.*

### 2.10.2 Referring to things in a sequence: ordinal numbers

2.232 If you want to identify or describe something by saying where it comes in a series or sequence, you use an **ordinal number**.

**Example 2.10.33.** *Quietly they took their seats in the 1st 3 rows.*
*Flora's flat is on the 4th floor of this 5-storey block.*
*They stopped at the 1st of the trees.*

Note that you can also use *following, last, next, preceding, previous*, and *subsequent* like ordinal numbers to say where something comes in a series or sequence.

**Example 2.10.34.** *The following morning he checked out of the hotel.*
*... the last rungs of the fire-escape.*
*... at the next general election.*
*The preceding text has been professionally transcribed.*
*I mentioned this in a previous programme.*
*... the subsequent career patterns of those taking degrees.*

*Following, subsequent, previous*, and *preceding* are only used to indicate the position of something in a sequence in time or in a piece of writing.
*Next* and *last* are used more generally, e.g. to refer to things in rows or lists.
The ordinal numbers are listed in the Reference section.
2.233 Ordinals are often used in front of nouns.
They are not usually used after linking verbs like *be*.
They are usually preceded by a determiner.

**Example 2.10.35.** *... the 1st day of autumn.*
*He took the lift to the 16th floor.*
*... on her 21st birthday.*
*... his father's 2nd marriage.*

In some idiomatic phrases ordinals are used without determiners.

**Example 2.10.36.** *The picture seems at 1st glance chaotic.*
*I might. On 2nd thoughts, no.*
*1st children usually get a lot of attention.*

2.234 Ordinals can be written in abbreviated form, e.g. in dates or headings or in very informal writing.
You write the last 2 letters of the ordinal after the number expressed in figures.
E.g., *first* can be written as *1st, twenty-second* as *22nd, hundred and thirds* as *103rd*, and *fourteenth* as *14th*.

**Example 2.10.37.** *... on August 2nd.*
*... the 1st Division of the Sovereign's Escort.*
*... the 11th Cavalry.*

2.235 You can specify which group the thing referred to by an ordinal belongs to by using the preposition *of* after the ordinal.

**Example 2.10.38.** *It is the 3rd of a series of 8 programmes.*
*Tony was the 2nd of 4 sons.*

When ordinals are used like this, they usually refer to 1 person or thing.
However, when they are used with a *to*-infinitive, or another phrase or clause after them, they can refer to 1 person or thing or to more than 1.
*1st* is used like this more than the other ordinals.

**Example 2.10.39.** *I was the 1st to recover.*
*They had to be the 1st to go.*
*The proposals - the 1st for 22 years - amount to a new charter for the mentally ill.*
*The withdrawals were the 1st that the army agreed to.*

2.236 You can use an ordinal to refer to a member of a group that you have already mentioned or to something of the kind already mentioned, and you can omit the noun that identifies the thing.

**Example 2.10.40.** *In Aug 1932 2 of the group's members were expelled from the party and a 3rd was suspended.*
*The 3rd child tries to outdo the 1st and 2nd.*
*A 2nd pheasant flew up. Then a third and a 4th.*

2.237 The adjectives *next* and *last* can be used, like ordinals, by themselves when the context makes the meaning clear.

**Example 2.10.41.** *You missed 1 meal. The meal is on the table in half an hour.*
*Smithy removed the last of the crews.*

2.238 The ordinal *1st* is also used as an adverb to show that something is done before other things.
Other ordinals are also sometimes used to show the order in which things are done, especially in informal English.
People also use ordinals as adverbs when they are giving a list of points, reasons, or items.
This is explained fully in paragraph **10.54**.
2.239 The use of ordinals in expressing fractions is explained in paragraphs **2.241**–**2.243**.
The use of ordinals to express dates, as in *the 17th of June*, is explained in paragraph **4.88**.
Ordinal numbers can be used in front of cardinal numbers.
This is explained in paragraphs **2.219**–**2.220**.

### 2.10.3 Talking about an exact part of something: fractions

2.240 When you want to show how small or large a part of something is compared to the whole of it, you use a **fraction**, e.g. *a 3rd*, followed by *of* and a noun referring to the whole thing.
Fractions can also be written in figures (see paragraph **2.248**).
2.241 When you express a fraction in words, the way you do so depends on whether the fraction is singular or plural.
If it is singular, you write or say an **ordinal number** or the special fraction terms *half* or *quarter*, with either the number *one* or a determiner e.g. *a* in front of them.
The fraction is linked to a noun by *of*.

**Example 2.10.42.** *This state produces a 3rd of the nation's oil.*
*... a quarter of an inch.*
*You can take a 5th of your money out on demand.*
*A 10th of our budget goes on fuel.*
*Forests cover 1 3rd of the country.*
*... 100th of a degree.*
*... 1 quarter of the total population.*

An adjective can also be placed after the determiner and before the fraction.

**Example 2.10.43.** *... the 1st half of the 20th century.*
*I read the 1st half of the book.*
*... the southern half of England.*
*... in the 1st quarter of 2004.*

2.242 [i] If you are using *half* in front of a pronoun, you still use *of* after the *half*.

**Example 2.10.44.** *Nearly half of it comes from the Middle East.*
*More than half of them have gone home.*
*Half of us have lost our jobs.*

Note that when the fraction *a half* is used with *of*, you usually write or say it as *half* without a determiner.
*A half* and *one half* are rarely used.

**Example 2.10.45.** *They lost half of their pay.*
*Half of the people went to private schools.*
*I had crossed more than half of America.*

2.243 If the fraction is plural, you put a **cardinal number** in front of a plural form of the **ordinal number** or special fraction word *quarter*.

**Example 2.10.46.** *... the poorer 2 3rds of the world.*
*The journey is going to take 3 quarters of an hour.*
*... 4 5ths of the money.*
*9 10th of them live on the land.*
*... 3 millionths of a centimeter.*

When *half* is used with whole numbers or amounts, it is used with the determiner *a*.

**Example 2.10.47.** *... 1 and a half acres of land.*
*... 4 and a half centuries.*

2.244 When you talk about fractions of a single thing, you use a singular form of a verb afterwards.

**Example 2.10.48.** *Half of our work is to design programmes.*
*2 3rds of the planet's surface is covered with water.*
*2 5ths of the forest was removed.*

However, when you talk about fractions of a number of things, you use a plural form of a verb afterwards.

**Example 2.10.49.** *2 3rds of Chad's exports were cotton.*
*A quarter of the students were seen individually.*
*More than half of these photographs are of her.*

2.245 When it is clear to your listener or reader who or what you are referring to, either because of the context or because you and your listener or reader know what is meant, you can use fraction as pronouns without the *of* and noun after them.

**Example 2.10.50.** *Of the people who work here, half are French and half are English.*
*2 3rds were sterilized.*
*1 6th are disappointed with the service.*

2.246 Besides their use as quantity expressions linked by *of* to a noun phrase, fractions can also be used after a whole number or amount plus *and*, with a noun placed after the fraction.
The noun must be plural even if the number is *1*.

**Example 2.10.51.** *You've got to sit there for 1 and a half hours.*
*... 5 and a quarter days.*
*... more than 4 and a half centuries ago.*

If you are using *a* instead of *one*, the *and* and the fraction come after the noun.

**Example 2.10.52.** *... a mile and a half below the surface.*
*... a mile and a quarter of motorway.*

2.247 Besides being used with *of* as a quantity expression, *half* is also used as a **predeterminer** (see paragraph **1.251**), directly in front of a determiner.

**Example 2.10.53.** *I met half the girls at the conference.*
*The farmers sold off half their land.*
*... half a pound of coffee.*
*... half a bottle of milk.*

Note that *half* is always used with *of* before a pronoun (see paragraph **2.242**).

2.248 You can write a fraction in figures, e.g. $\frac{1}{2}$, $\frac{1}{4}$, $\frac{3}{4}$, and $\frac{2}{3}$.

These correspond to *a half, a quarter, 3 quarters* and *2 3rds*, resp.

2.249 Fractions are often given in a special form as a number of 100ths.

This type of fraction is called a **percentage**.

E.g., *3 100ths*, expressed as a percentage, is *3 per cent*.

It can also be written as *3 percent* or *3%*.

*A half* can be expressed as *50 per cent, 50 percent*, or *50%*.

**Example 2.10.54.** *90 percent of most food is water.*
*About 20 per cent of student accountants are women.*
*Before 1960 45% of British trade was with the Commonwealth.*

You use percentages on their own as noun phrases when it is clear what they refer to.

**Example 2.10.55.** *90 per cent were self employed.*
*... interest at 10% per annum.*

### 2.10.4 Talking about measurements

2.250 You can refer to a size, distance, area, volume, weight, speed, or temperature by using a number of quantity expression in front of a **measurement noun**.

Measurement nouns are countable.

**Example 2.10.56.** *They grow to 20 feet.*
*... blocks of stone weighting up to a hundred tons.*
*Reduce the temperature by a few degrees.*
*Average annual temperatures exceed 20° centigrade.*

Other ways of expressing distance are explained in paragraphs **6.91–6.92**.

Measurement nouns referring to size, area, volume, and weight are often used in **partitive structures** (see paragraphs **2.194–2.207**) e.g. *a pint of milk* and *a pound of onions*.

They are also used in phrases beginning with *of* (see paragraph **2.283**).

2.251 There are 2 systems of measurement used in Britain - the **imperial system** and the **metric system**.

Each system has its own measurement nouns.

Here is a list of the imperial units of measurement indicating size, distance, area, volume, and weight:

**Example 2.10.57.** *inch, foot, yard, mile*
*acre*
*pint, quart, gallon*
*ounce, pound, stone, hundredweight, ton*

Note that the plural of *foot* is *feet*, but *foot* can also be used with numbers.

Similarly *stone* is usually used instead of *stones*.

Here is a list of the metric units of measurement indicating size, distance, area, volume, and weight:

**Example 2.10.58.** *millimeter, centimeter, meter, kilometer*
*hectare*
*milliliter, centiliter, liter*
*milligram, gram, kilogram, tonne*

2.252 Measurement nouns are often used after **linking verbs** e.g. *be, measure* and *weigh*.

**Example 2.10.59.** *The fish was about 8 feet long.*
*It measures approximately 26 inches wide ×25 inches long.*
*... a square area measuring 900 meters on each side.*
*It weighs 50 or more kilos.*

The use of adjectives after linking verbs is explained in paragraphs **3.132–3.137**.

2.253 When measurement nouns that give the size of something are used after a linking verb, they are often followed by an adjective that makes it clear exactly what the measurement refers to

**Example 2.10.60.** *He was about 6 feet tall.*
*The spears were about 6 foot long.*
*. . . a room 2 meters wide.*
*The water was 15 feet deep.*
*. . . a layer of stone 4 meters thick.*

Here is a list of the adjectives that follow measurement nouns indicating size:

**Example 2.10.61.** *broad, deep, high, long, tall, thick, wide*

Note that you do not say *2 pounds heavy* but *2 pounds in weight* instead.
2.254 Similarly, some measurement nouns can be followed by prepositional phrases beginning with *in*.

**Example 2.10.62.** *. . . a block of ice 1 cubic foot in size.*
*I put on nearly a stone in weight.*
*They are 30 centimeters in length.*
*. . . deposits measuring up to a kilometer in thickness.*
*It was close to 10 feet in height.*

Here is a list of phrases beginning with *in* used after measurements:

**Example 2.10.63.** *in area, in breadth, in depth, in distance, in height, in length, in size, in thickness, in volume, in weight, in width*

2.255 Measurement nouns can also be used as modifiers in front of a noun when you want to describe things in terms of their measurements.

**Example 2.10.64.** *. . . a 5 foot 9 inch bed.*
*. . . 70 foot high mounds of dust.*
*. . . 12 × 12 inch tiles.*
*. . . a 5-pound bag of lentils.*

Note that the measurement noun is singular.
2.256 [i] If you want to describe fully the size of an object or area, you can give its dimensions; i.e., you give measurements of its length and width, or length, width, and depth.
When you give the dimensions of an object, you separate the figures using *and, by*, or the multiplication sign ×.

**Example 2.10.65.** *. . . planks of wood about 3 inches thick and 2 feet wide.*
*The island measures about 25 miles by 12 miles.*
*Lake Nyasa is 450 miles long by about 50 miles wide.*
*The box measures approximately 26 inches wide × 25 inches deep × 16 inches high.*

If you are talking about a square object or area, you give the length of each side followed by the word *square*.

**Example 2.10.66.** *Each family hs only 1 room 8 or 10 feet square.*
*The site measures roughly 35 feet square.*

*Square* is used in front of units of length when expressing data.
*Cubic* is used in front of units of length when expressing volume.

**Example 2.10.67.** *. . . a farm covering 300 square miles.*
*The brain of the 1st ape-men was about the same size as that of gorilla, around 500 cubic centimeters.*

You express temperature in degrees, using either degrees centigrade, or degrees Fahrenheit.
Note that in everyday language the metric term *centigrade* is used to indicate temperature, whereas in scientific language the term *Celsius* is used which refers to exactly the same scale of measurement.
2.257 You talk about the speed of something by saying how far it can travel in a particular unit of time.
To do this, you use a noun e.g. *mile* or *kilometer*, followed by *per, a*, or *an*, and a time noun.

**Example 2.10.68.** *The car would do only 45 miles per hour.*
*Wind speeds at the airport were 160 kilometers per hour.*
*Warships move at about 500 miles per day.*

### 2.10.5 Talking about age

2.258 When you want to say how old someone is, you have a choice of ways in which to do it.
You can be exact or approximate.
Similarly, when you ant to say how old something is, you can use different ways, some exact, and some approximate.

2.259 When you want to talk about a person's exact age, you can do so by using

- *be* followed by a number, and sometimes *years old* after the number.

  **Example 2.10.69.** *I was 19, and he was 21.*

  *I'm only 63.*

  *She is 25 years old.*

  *I am 40 years old.*

- *of* (or less commonly *aged*) and a number after a noun

  **Example 2.10.70.** *... a child of 6.*

  *... 2 little boys aged about 9 and 11.*

- a compound adjective, usually hyphenated, consisting of a number, followed by a singular noun referring to a period of time, followed by *old*

  **Example 2.10.71.** *... a twenty-two-year-old student.*

  *... a 5-month-old baby.*

  *... a pretty 350-year-old cottage.*

  *... a violation of a 6-year-old agreement.*

- a compound noun consisting of a number followed by *-year-old*

  **Example 2.10.72.** *The servant was a pale little 14-year-old who looked hardly more than 10.*

  *All the 6-year-olds are taught by 1 teacher.*

  *... Melvin Kalkhoven, a tall, thin 35-year-old.*

2.260 When you want to talk about a person's age in an approximate way, you can do so by using

- *in*, followed by a possessive determiner, followed by a plural noun referring to a particular range of years e.g. *twenties* and *teens*

  **Example 2.10.73.** *He was in his sixties.*

  *I didn't mature till I was in my forties.*

  *... the groups who are now in their thirties.*

  *... when I was in my teens.*

  Note that you can use *early, mid-, middle*, or *late* to indicate approximately where someone's age comes in a particular range of years.

  **Example 2.10.74.** *He was then in his late seventies.*

  *She was in her mid-twenties.*

  *Jame is only in her early forties.*

- *over* or *under* followed by a number

  **Example 2.10.75.** *She was well over 50.*

  *She was only a little over 40 years old.*

  *There weren't enough people who were under 25.*

  Note that you can also use *above* or *below* followed by *the age of* and a number.

**Example 2.10.76.** *55 per cent of them were below the age of 21.*

- a compound noun referring to a group of people whose age is more or less than a particular number, which consists of *over* or *under* followed by the plural form of the particular number.

  **Example 2.10.77.** *The over-sixties do not want to be turned out of their homes.*
  *Schooling for under-fives should be expanded.*

  [AE] This construction is not common in American English.

2.261 You can put several of the above structures after a noun to talk about the age of a person or thing.

**Example 2.10.78.** *... a woman in her early 30s.*
*... help for elderly ladies over 65.*
*She had 4 children under the age of 5.*

2.262 If you want to say that someone's age is similar to someone else's age, you use structures e.g. *of his age* and *of her parents's age* after a noun.
The *of* is often dropped.

**Example 2.10.79.** *A lot of girls of Helen's age are interested in clothes.*
*It's easy to make friends because you're with people of your own age.*
*She will have a tough time when she plays with children her own age.*

2.263 If you want to say what the age of a thing is, you can use

- *be* followed by a number followed by *years old*

  **Example 2.10.80.** *It's at least a thousand million years old.*
  *The house was about 30 years old.*

  Note that you can also use this pattern after a noun.

  **Example 2.10.81.** *... rocks 200 million years old.*

- a compound adjective indicating the century when something existed or was made, which consists of an ordinal number and *century*

  **Example 2.10.82.** *... a 6th-century church.*
  *... life in 5th-century Athens.*

- a compound adjective, usually hyphenated, consisting of a number, followed by a singular noun referring to a period of time, followed by *old*

  **Example 2.10.83.** *... a 1,000-year-old temple.*

## 2.11 Approximate amounts & measurements

2.264 If you do not know the exact number, size, or quantity of something, you can give an approximate amount of measurement using 1 of a group of special words and expressions.
Some of these words and expressions are put in front of a quantity and some are put after it.
Here is a list of some of the words and expressions used to give approximate amounts and measurements:

**Example 2.11.1.** *about, almost, a maximum of, a minimum of, approximately, around, at least, at most, at the maximum, at the most, less than, maximum, minimum, more than, nearly, no more than, odd, or less, or more, or so, or thereabouts, or under, over, roughly, some, something like, under, upto*

2.265 Some of these expressions indicate that a number is a minimum figure and that the actual figure is or may be larger.
Here is a list of expressions that indicate a minimum number:

**Example 2.11.2.** *a minimum of, a least, minimum, more than, or more, over, plus*

2.266 [i] You put *a minimum of, more than*, and *over* in front of a number.

**Example 2.11.3.** *He needed a minimum of 26 Democratic votes.*
*... a school with more than 1300 pupils.*
*The British have been on the island for over a thousand years.*

You put *or more* and *plus* after a number or amount, and *minimum* after an amount.

**Example 2.11.4.** *... a choice of 3 or more possibilities.*
*This is the worst disaster I can remember in my 25 years plus as a police officer.*
*He does an hour's homework per night minimum.*

You put *at least* in front of a number or after a number or amount.

**Example 2.11.5.** *She had at least a dozen brandies.*
*I must have slept 12 hours at least!*

2.267 Some of these expressions are used to indicate that a number is a maximum figure and that the actual figure is or may be smaller.

Here is a list of expressions that indicate a maximum number:

**Example 2.11.6.** *almost, a maximum of, at most, at the maximum, at the most, fewer than, less than, maximum, nearly, no more than, or less, or under, under, up to*

2.2608 [i] You put *almost, a maximum of, fewer than, less than, nearly, no more than, under* and *up to* in front of a number.

*Fewer than* and *less than* mean the same, but *fewer than* is more formal.

**Example 2.11.7.** *There were fewer than 20 people at the event.*
*The puppy's less than 7 weeks old.*
*The company now supplies almost 100 of the city's restaurants.*
*These loans must be repaid over a maximum of 3 years.*
*She had nearly 50 dollars.*
*We managed to finish the entire job in under 3 months.*
*Their bodies might be up to a meter wide.*

You put *at the maximum, at most, at the most, maximum, or less*, and *or under* after a number.

**Example 2.11.8.** *Classes are of 8 at the maximum.*
*The images take 36 hours maximum.*
*The area would yield only 200 pounds of rice or less.*
*... 12 hours a week or under.*

2.269 Some of these expressions are used to show that a number is approximate and that the actual figure could be larger or smaller.

Here is a list of the expressions showing that a number is approximate:

**Example 2.11.9.** *about, approximately, around, odd, or so, or thereabouts, roughly, some, something like*

2.270 [i] You put *about, approximately, around, roughly, some*, and *something like* in front of a number.

**Example 2.11.10.** *About 85 students were there.*
*Every year we have approximately 40 pupils who take mathematics.*
*It would cost around 35 million pounds.*
*A loft conversion costs roughly £12,000.*
*They have to pay America some $683,000 this year.*
*Harrington has cheated us out of something like 30,000 quid over the past 2 years.*

You put *odd* and *or so* after a number or amount, and *or thereabouts* after an amount.

**Example 2.11.11.** *... a hundred odd acres.*
*For half a minute or so, neither of them spoke.*
*Get the temperature to* 30° *or thereabouts.*

2.271 You show a range of numbers using *between* and *and*, or *from* and *to*, or just *to*.

**Example 2.11.12.** *Most of the farms around here are between 4 and 5 hundred years old.*
*My hospital groups contain from 10 to 20 patients.*
*... peasants owning 2 to 5 acres of land.*

Note the use of *anything* before *between* and *from*, to emphasize how great the range is.

**Example 2.11.13.** *An average rate of anything between 25 and 60% is usual.*
*It is a job that takes anything from 2 to 5 weeks.*

## 2.12 Expanding the noun phrase

2.272 This section deals with structures that are used to add further information about the person or thing referred to.
These are called **qualifiers**.
The word that is qualified is usually a noun but can be an indefinite pronoun or *those*.
2.273 The structures that are dealt with in this section are

**Example 2.12.1.**

*prepositional phrases*

**Example 2.12.2.** *... a girl with red hair.*
*... the man in the dark glasses.*

*The use of prepositional phrases to expand the noun phrase is explained in paragraphs **2.275–2.290**.*

*adjectives followed by phrases or clauses*

**Example 2.12.3.** *... machinery capable of clearing rubble off the main roads.*
*... the type of comments likely to provoke criticism.*
*... a concept inconceivable a hundred years earlier.*

*The use of adjectives followed by phrases or clauses to expand the noun phrase is explained in paragraphs **2.291–2.292**.*

*non-finite clauses*

**Example 2.12.4.** *... a simple device to test lung function.*
*... 2 of the problems mentioned above.*
*He gestured towards the 3 cards lying on the table.*

*The use of non-finite clauses to expand the noun phrase is explained in paragraphs **2.293–2.301**.*

*noun phrases giving further information about other noun phrases.*
*This is explained in paragraph **2.302**.*

2.274 Some other structures are also used.
These are explained fully in other sections.
They include

- single words e.g. *galore* and *concerned*, which are explained in paragraphs **2.58–2.62**.
- relative clauses

  **Example 2.12.5.** *Shortly after the shooting, the man who had done it was arrested.*
  *Where's that cake your mother made?*

- place adverbs and time adverbials

  **Example 2.12.6.** *... down in the dungeon beneath.*
  *... a reflection of life today in England.*

  Time adverbials are explained in Chap. 4 and adverbs of place are explained in paragraphs **6.53–6.72**.

### 2.12.1 Nouns with prepositional phrases

2.275 In general, any prepositional phrase that describes classifies something can be used directly after a noun or pronoun.

**Example 2.12.7.** *... the main in charge.*
*... a film about 4 men on holiday.*
*She reached into the room behind her.*

2.276 In particular, there are several kinds of prepositional phrase that are usually only used in this way.
Of these, prepositional phrases beginning with *of* are the most numerous.
Others include certain uses of *with, in* and *by*.
2.277 Many nouns referring to things and actions can be expanded by using prepositional phrases beginning with *of* after them.
This allows the noun to be expanded with a wide range of meanings.

You can use *of* with nouns referring to feelings e.g. *love* and *fear* to show what the feeling relates to; e.g., *fear of lying* and *love of animals*.

Further meanings are described in the following paragraphs.

2.278 [!] **Personal pronouns** are not usually placed after *of*.

E.g., you cannot say *Joyce was the daughter of him* or *the pages of it*.

**Possessive determiners** are used instead to show possession.

These are explained in paragraphs **1.194–1.210**.

2.279 Prepositional phrases beginning with *of* can be used to show what something consists of.

**Example 2.12.8.** *... a letter of confirmation.*
*... strong feelings of jealousy.*

They can also be used to show what the subject matter of something is.

**Example 2.12.9.** *... a picture of a house.*
*... Gretchen's account of her interview with Nichols.*
*... the idea of death.*

2.280 Prepositional phrases beginning with *of* can be used to say that something belongs to or is associated with someone or something.

**Example 2.12.10.** *Cental is a trademark of Monotore Ltd.*
*No.28 was the town house of Sir Winston Churchill.*
*James is the son of a Methodist minister.*
*The acting ability of the pupils is admirable.*
*... the beauty of the Welsh landscape.*
*4 boys sat on the floor of the living room.*
*Ellen aimlessly turned the pages of her magazine.*

Note that apostrophe *s* ('s) structures are much more frequently used to say that something belongs to someone or something.

**Apostrophe *s* ('s)** is explained in paragraphs **1.211–1.222**.

2.281 Prepositional phrases beginning with *of* can be used to say that someone or something has a particular quality.

**Example 2.12.11.** *... a woman of energy and ambition.*
*... problems of varying complexity.*
*... a flower of monstrous proportions.*
*A household of this size inevitably has problems.*

*Of* can also be used in front of a number to indicate someone's age.

**Example 2.12.12.** *... a woman of 22.*
*... a child of 6.*

Other ways of talking about age are explained in paragraphs **2.258–2.263**.

2.282 Prepositional phrases beginning with *of* can be used with nouns referring to an action to show who or what is performing the action.

**Example 2.12.13.** *... the arrival of the police.*
*... the growth of modern industry.*

They are also used to show who or what someone does something to.

E.g., if you are talking about people who support a scheme, you can call them *the supporters of the scheme*.

**Example 2.12.14.** *... supporters of the hunger strike.*
*... critics of the Trade Union Movement.*
*... the creator of the universe.*
*... a student of English.*
*... the cause of the tragedy.*

*Of* structures can also used to indicate the thing affected by an action.

**Example 2.12.15.** *... the destruction of their city.*
*... the dismissal of hundreds of workers.*

2.283 Prepositional phrases beginning with *of* and containing measurement are used to show how great an area, speed, distance, or temperature is.

**Example 2.12.16.** *There were fires burning over a total area of about 600 square miles.*
*It can barely maintain a speed of 25 kilometers an hour.*
*... an average annual temperature of 20°.*

Ways of measuring things are explained in paragraphs **2.250–2.257**.

2.284 Prepositional phrases beginning with *with* can be used to say that someone or something has a particular characteristic, feature, or possession.

**Example 2.12.17.** *... a girl with red hair.*
*... a girl with a foreign accent.*
*... a big car with reclining seats.*
*... a man with a violent temper.*
*... the man with the gun.*
*... those with large families.*

They are also used to indicate what something has on or in it.

**Example 2.12.18.** *... a sheet of paper with writing on it.*
*... a round box with some buttons in it.*
*... a white, plain envelope with her name printed on it.*
*... fragments of wrapping paper with bits of sticky tape still adhering to them.*

2.285 Prepositional phrases beginning with *in* can be used to say what someone is wearing.

**Example 2.12.19.** *... a grey-haired man in a raincoat.*
*... the man in the dark glasses.*
*... little groups of people in black.*

2.286 Prepositional phrases beginning with *by* can be used after a noun referring to an action to say who or what is performing it.

**Example 2.12.20.** *... his appointment by the King.*
*... the compression of air by the piston.*

2.287 Some nouns, especially abstract nouns, need to be followed by a prepositional phrase to show what they relate to.
There is often little or no choice about which preposition to use after a particular noun.

**Example 2.12.21.** *He has an allergy to peanuts.*
*... his authority over them.*
*... the solution to our energy problem.*
*... the bond between mother and child.*

2.288 Here is a list of nouns that usually or often have *to* after them:

**Example 2.12.22.** *access, addiction, adherence, affront, allegiance, allergy, allusion, alternative, answer, antidote, approach, attachment, aversion, contribution, damage, devotion, disloyalty, exception, fidelity, incitement, introduction, preface, prelude, recourse, reference, relevance, reply, resistance, return, sequel, solution, susceptibility, testimony, threat, vulnerability, witness*

Here is a list of nouns that usually or often have *for* after them:

**Example 2.12.23.** *admiration, appetite, aptitude, bid, craving, credit, cure, demand, desire, disdain, dislike, disregard, disrespect, hunger, love, need, provision, quest, recipe, regard, remedy, respect, responsibility, room, search, substitute, sympathy, synonym, taste, thirst, demand*

Here is a list of nouns that usually or often have *on* after them:

**Example 2.12.24.** *assault, attack, ban, claim, comment, concentration, constraint, crackdown, curb, dependence, effect, embargo, hold, insistence, reflection, reliance, restriction, stance, tax*

Here is a list of nouns that usually or often have *with* after them:

**Example 2.12.25.** *affinity, collision, collusion, connection, contrast, correspondence, date, dealings, dissatisfaction, encounter, familiarity, identification, intersection, intimacy, involvement, link, parity, quarrel, relationship, sympathy*

Here is a list of nouns that are usually followed by 1 of 2 prepositions.
The list indicates the choice of prepositions available:

**Example 2.12.26.** *agreement about/on, argument against/for, battle against/for, case against/for, debate about/on, decision about/on, transition from/to*

Here is a list of other nouns that are usually followed by a preposition.

**Example 2.12.27.** *complex about, crime against, grudge against, insurance against, reaction against, safeguard against, anger at, bond between, departure from, escape from, excerpt from, freedom from, quotation from, foray into, relapse into, awareness of, authority over, control over*

As you can see from the lists and examples given above, it is often the case that words with a similar meaning are typically followed by the same preposition.
E.g., *appetite, craving, desire, hunger*, and *thirst* are all followed by *for*.
2.289 [i] Some nouns are related to verbs that are always or often followed by a particular preposition.
These nouns are followed by the same preposition as their related verbs, and they are used to indicate the thing that is affected by the action.
E.g., *to* is used after both the verb *refer* and the related noun *reference*.

**Example 2.12.28.** *We have already referred to this phenomenon.*
*... reverent references to the importance of home.*
*They swim about busily searching for food.*
*... the search for food.*
*I want to escape from here.*
*... an escape from reality.*

2.290 Some nouns referring to a feeling or state are related to an adjective that is usually followed by a preposition.
These nouns are followed by the same preposition as their related adjectives.
E.g., *of* is used after the adjective *aware* and the related noun *awareness*.

**Example 2.12.29.** *She was quite aware of her current situation.*
*... the public's increasing awareness of the problems.*
*He was angry at Sally Gardner for accusing him.*
*... her anger at the kids.*

### 2.12.2 Nouns with adjectives

2.291 When adjectives are used in clauses after nouns or pronouns to expand their meaning they can be followed by

- prepositional phrases

  **Example 2.12.30.** *... a warning to people eager for a quick cure.*
  *those responsible for the project.*

- a *to*-infinitive

  **Example 2.12.31.** *... remarks likely to cause offence.*
  *It has been directed against those least able to retaliate.*

- expression of time or place

  **Example 2.12.32.** *... a concept inconceivable 100 years earlier.*
  *For the facilities available here, I must ask for a fee.*

Note that you can use adjectives as qualifiers when they are preceded by time or measurement expressions.

**Example 2.12.33.** *... those still alive.*
*... a small hill about 400 feet high.*

Note also that a few adjectives, e.g. *present* and *responsible*, can be used on their own after a noun or pronoun.

The use of these adjectives is explained in paragraphs **2.58**–**2.62**.

2.292 There are some other structures, especially those that indicate comparison, degree, or result, that often involve a qualifying structure.

In particular, some words that modify adjectives, e.g. *more, too*, or *so*, often have a qualifying structure to complete their meaning.

**Example 2.12.34.** *Peter came in, more excited than anyone had seen him before.*
*Ralph was too angry to think clearly.*
*... steel cylinders strong enough to survive a nuclear catastrophe.*
*... a grand piano as big as 2 coffins.*
*She was so ill that she couldn't eat.*
*Technology has made such spectacular advances that it is difficult to keep up.*

The use of comparative adjectives plus *than* after noun phrases is explained in paragraphs **2.106**–**2.108**.

Other ways of comparing things are explained in paragraphs **2.123**–**2.139**.

The use of *so... that* and *such... that* is explained in paragraphs **8.58**–**8.63**.

### 2.12.3 Nouns followed by *to*-infinitive, *-ed* participle, or *-ing* participle: *something to eat, a girl called Patricia, a basket containing eggs*

2.293 The following **non-finite** clauses (= clauses containing a verb that has no tense) can be used to expand the meaning of a noun: *to*-infinitive clauses (see paragraphs **2.294**–**2.299**), *-ed* participle clauses (see paragraph **2.300**), and *-ing* participle clauses (see paragraph **2.301**).

2.294 A *to*-infinitive clause is often placed after nouns in order to show what the thing referred to is intended to do.

**Example 2.12.35.** *The government of Mexico set up a programme to develop new varieties of wheat.*
*They need people to work in the factories.*

2.295 You can refer to something or someone that should or can have something done to them by using a clause containing a *to*-infinitive after a noun or indefinite pronoun.

**Example 2.12.36.** *I make notes in the back of my diary of things to be mended or replaced.*
*... When I've had something to eat.*

You can also use a clause consisting of a *to*-infinitive followed by a preposition.

**Example 2.12.37.** *There wasn't even a chair to sit on.*
*He had nothing to write with.*

2.296 You can also use a *to*-infinitive clause when you want to say that you are talking about, e.g., the 1st, oldest, or only person who did something.

**Example 2.12.38.** *... the 1st woman to be elected to the council.*

2.297 A clause containing a *to*-infinitive is used after some abstract nouns to show what action they relate to.

**Example 2.12.39.** *... people who didn't have the opportunity to go to university.*

2.298 [i] Many of these nouns are related to verbs or adjectives that are also often followed by *to*-infinitive clauses.

E.g., a *to*-infinitive clause is used after both the verb *need* and the noun *need*, and after both the adjective *able* and the related noun *ability*.

**Example 2.12.40.** *I need to borrow 5000 dollars.*
*... the need to preserve secrecy about their intentions.*
*It failed to grow.*

2.299 Here is a list of nouns that usually or often have a *to*-infinitive clause after them:

**Example 2.12.41.** *ability, attempt, bid, chance, compulsion, desire, disinclination, failure, inability, inclination, need, opportunity, readiness, reason, refusal, unwillingness, urge, way, willingness*

2.300 A clause containing an *-ed* participle can be used directly after a noun to show that something has been produced or affected by an action.

**Example 2.12.42.** *... a girl called Patricia.*
*... dresses made of paper.*
*... 2 of the problems mentioned above.*
*... a story written by a 9-year-old girl.*

2.301 A clause containing an *-ing* participle can be used directly after a noun to show that someone or something is doing something.

**Example 2.12.43.** *He gestured towards the 3 cards lying on the table.*
*... a wicker shopping-basket containing groceries.*

2.302 You can give further information about someone or something by using a noun phrase that describes them or identifies them.

If you put this noun phrase after the main noun phrase, a comma is almost always put after the main noun phrase because the 2nd noun phrase is separate from it, not part of it.

**Example 2.12.44.** *... the bald eagle, the symbol of America.*
*... David Beckham, a 1st-class football player.*
*Her mother, a Canadian, died when she was 6.*

If you put this noun phrase before the main noun phrase, you can sometimes choose whether to use a comma to separate the 2 noun phrases or not.

**Example 2.12.45.** *... Joan's husband, Jim Inglis.*
*... my husband George.*

# Chapter 3

# Making a message: types of verb

3.1 When you make a statement, you use a **clause**.

A clause that is used to make a statement contains a **noun phrase**, which refers to the person or thing that you are talking about, and a **verb phrase**, which shows what short of action, process, or state you are talking about.

The noun phrase, which usually comes in front of the verb, is called the **subject** or the verb or the clause.

E.g., in the clause *Ellen laughed, Ellen* is the subject.

The information of noun phrases is explained in **Chaps. 1–2**.

A verb phrase used in a statement has a particular form, and shows agreement with number and person.

The formation of verb phrases is explained in the Reference section.

Quite often in statements the verb phrase is a single word, and it is quite common to talk about the *verb* of a clause.

This chapter deals mainly with the use of the verbs in **active** clauses, where the subject is the performer of an action rather than the person or thing affected by an action.

The use of verbs in **passive** clauses, where the subject is the person or thing affected, is explained in paragraphs **9.8–9.24**.

## 3.1 Show who is involved

3.2 If an action or event involves only 1 person or thing, you mention only the performer of the action (the subject) and the action (the verb).

**Example 3.1.1.** *The girl screamed.*
*I waited.*
*An awful thing has happened.*

Verbs like this are called **intransitive verbs**.

However, you can then mention another person or thing that is involved using a **prepositional phrase**.

**Example 3.1.2.** *She walked across the street.*

Intransitive verbs are explained in paragraphs **3.8–3.13**.

3.3 If the action or event involves another person or thing that the action affects, relates to, or produces, you put a noun phrase referring to them after the verb.

This is called the **object** of the verb.

If it is necessary to distinguish it from other objects, it is called the **direct object**.

**Example 3.1.3.** *He closed the door.*
*I hate sport.*
*Some of the women noticed me.*

Verbs like this are called **transitive verbs**.

Transitive verbs are explained in paragraphs **3.14–3.25**.

**Reflexive verbs** and **delexical verbs** are special kinds of transitive verbs.

They are explained in paragraphs **3.26–3.31** and **3.32–3.45**.

3.4 The majority of verbs in English give you the option of presenting an event either as involving the subject only, or as involving the subject and someone or something else as a direct object.

**Example 3.1.4.** *She paints by holding the brush in her teeth.*
*Yarkov paints vivid portraits of friends and acquaintances.*
*Gus asked me whether I'd like to have dinner with him. I accepted.*
*I accepted the invitation.*

This means that most verbs can be used with or without an object.
Verbs that can be used like this are explained in paragraphs **3.46–3.54**.
With some verbs, the thing affected by the action can be put as the object of the verb or as the object of a preposition after the verb.
These verbs are explained in paragraphs **3.55–3.58**.
**Ergative verbs** are a special kind of verb that can be used with or without an object.
They are explained in paragraphs **3.59–3.67**.
3.5 **Reciprocal verbs** refer to actions that involve people affecting each other in the same way with the same action.
There are 2 types of **reciprocal verb**.
1 type is used either with or without an object.

**Example 3.1.5.** *We met at Hargreaves' place.*
*I had met him in Zermatt.*

The other type is used without an object, and with or without a prepositional phrase mentioning 1 of the participants.

**Example 3.1.6.** *We argued over this question for a long time.*
*I argued with this man for half an hour.*

Reciprocal verbs are explained in paragraphs **3.68–3.72**.
3.6 Some transitive verbs also allow you to mention a person who benefits from an action or receives something as a result.
The verb is then followed by both a direct object and an **indirect object**.

**Example 3.1.7.** *Hand me my bad.*
*His uncle had given him books on India.*
*She sends you her love.*
*She passed him his cup.*

Verbs that can take an indirect object as well as a direct object are explained in paragraphs **3.73–3.82**.
3.7 Some verbs have 2 or 3 parts.
These are **phrasal verbs** and **compound verbs**.
Phrasal verbs are explained in paragraphs **3.83–3.116**, and compound verbs are explained in paragraphs **3.117–3.125**.

### 3.1.1 Intransitive verbs: talking about events that involve only the subject

3.8 When you are talking about an action or event that does not have an object, you use an **intransitive verb**.

**Example 3.1.8.** *Her whole body ached.*
*Such people still exist.*
*My condition deteriorated.*

Many intransitive verbs describe physical behavior or making of sounds.

**Example 3.1.9.** *Bob coughed.*
*Vicki wept bitterly.*
*The gate squeaked.*

3.9 Here is a list of verbs that are normally used without an object and that usually or often have no adverb or prepositional phrase after them:

**Example 3.1.10.** *ache, advance, arise, arrive, bleed, blush, cease, collapse, cough, crackle, cry, decay, depart, deteriorate, die, digress, dine, disappear, disintegrate, doze, droop, economize, elapse, ensue, erupt, evaporate, exist, expire, faint, fall, falter, fidget, flinch, flourish, fluctuate, gleam, growl, happen, hesitate, howl, itch, kneel, laugh, moan, occur, pause, persist, prosper, quiver, recede, relent, rise, roar, scream, shine, shiver, sigh, sleep, slip, smile, snarl, sneeze, snore, snort, sob, sparkle, speak, squeak, squeal, stink, subside, sulk, surrender, swim, throb, tingle, vanish, vary, vibrate, wait, waver, weep, wilt, work, yawn*

A few of these verbs are used with an object in idioms or with very specific objects, but they are intransitive in all their common meanings.

3.10 Many intransitive verbs always or typically have an adverb or prepositional phrase after them.

With some, only a prepositional phrase beginning with a particular preposition is possible.

This use of a preposition allows something affected by the action to be mentioned, as the object of the preposition.

**Example 3.1.11.** *Everything you see here belongs to me.*
*Landlords often resorted to violence.*
*I sympathized with them.*
*I'm relying on Bill.*
*He strives for excellence in all things.*

3.11 Here is a list of verbs that always or typically have a particular preposition after them when they are used with a particular meaning:

**Example 3.1.12.** *rave about*
*insure against, plot against, react against*
*hint at*
*alternate between, differentiate between, oscillate between*
*appeal for, atone for, care for, clamor for, hope for, long for, opt for, pay for, qualify for, strive for, yearn for*
*detract from, emanate from, emerge from, radiate from, shrink from, stem from, suffer from*
*believe in, consist in, culminate in, dabble in, indulge in, invest in, result in, wallow in*
*lapse into*
*complain of, conceive of, consist of, despair of, learn of, smack of, think of, tire of*
*bet on, feed on, insist on, spy on, trample on*
*adhere to, allude to, amount to, appeal to, aspire to, assent to, attend to, belong to, bow to, cling to, defer to, dictate to, lead to, listen to, object to, refer to, relate to, resort to, revert to, stoop to*
*alternate with, associate with, consort with, contend with, flirt with, grapple with, sympathize with, teem with*

Here is a list of verbs that can have either of 2 prepositions after them with the same or very similar meaning:

**Example 3.1.13.** *abound in/with, cater for/to, conform to/with, contribute to/towards, depend on/upon, dote on/upon, embark on/upon, end in/with, engage in/on, enthuse about/over, gravitate to/towards, hunger after/for, improve on/upon, liaise between/with, lust after/for, prevail on/upon, profit by/from, rely on/upon, revolve around/round, spring from/out of*

Note that some intransitive verbs can be used in the passive when they are followed by a preposition.

See paragraph **9.23**.

3.12 Other verbs can be followed by a variety of prepositional phrases, or an adverb, often relating to time or place.

Verbs of movements are usually or often followed by adverbs or phrases relating to direction.

**Example 3.1.14.** *He went back to his own room.*
*I traveled south.*

Here is a list of verbs of movement:

**Example 3.1.15.** *come, crawl, creep, drift, flow, gallop, glide, go, hurtle, plunge, run, soar, spring, stroll, travel, walk*

*Look, gaze, glance*, and *stare* are also followed by adverbs or phrases relating to direction.

Verbs of position are usually followed by adverbs or phrases relating to position.

**Example 3.1.16.** *Donald was lying on the bed.*
*She lives in Lausanne.*
*I used to live here.*

Here is a list of verbs of position:

**Example 3.1.17.** *be, belong, hand, lie, live, be located, remain, sit, be situated, stand, stay*

Verbs e.g. *extend* or *stretch* are followed by adverbs or phrases relating to extent.

**Example 3.1.18.** *... an area stretching from London to Cambridge.*

There are a few verbs that are always followed by other types of adverb or phrase.

**Example 3.1.19.** *It behaves rather like a squirrel.*
*My brother agreed to act as a go-between.*
*I hoped that the absorption of poison hadn't progressed too far.*

Here is a list of verbs that are always followed by other types of adverb or phrase:

**Example 3.1.20.** *act, behave, campaign, progress*

3.13 There are a few verbs that are usually intransitive but that can be transitive when they are used with 1 particular object.
The object is usually directly related to the verb.
E.g., *smile* is usually used without an object, but you can use it with the noun *smile*.
E.g., *He smiled a patient smile* is a literary alternative to saying *He smiled patiently*.
The focus is on the type of smile rather than on the act of smiling.

**Example 3.1.21.** *Steve smiled his thin, cruel smile.*
*He appears to have lived the life of any other rich gentleman.*
*Alice laughed a scornful laugh.*
*I once dreamed a very nice dream about you.*

Here is a list of verbs that can only be used with an object when the object is directly related to the verb:

**Example 3.1.22.** *dance (a dance), die (a death), dream (a dream), laugh (a laugh), live (a life), sigh (a sigh), smile (a smile)*

A more common way of focusing on the noun phrase is to use a **delexical verb** e.g. *give, take*, or *have*, as in *Mary gave him a really lovely smile.*
See paragraphs **3.32–3.45** for more information about the use of delexical verbs.

### 3.1.2 Transitive verbs: involving someone or something other than the subject

3.14 Many verbs describe events that must, in addition to the subject, involve someone or something else.
Some of these verbs can only be used with a following object.

**Example 3.1.23.** *The extra profit justifies the investment.*
*He had committed a disgraceful action.*
*They are employing more staff.*

This means that they are followed by a direct object.

**Example 3.1.24.** *She had friends.*
*Children seek independence.*
*The trial raised a number of questions.*

3.15 Many verbs that are only used with an object can take a large range of objects.
E.g., there are many things you can *want*: money, a rest, success, and so on.

**Example 3.1.25.** *She wanted some help.*
*I put my hand on the door.*
*She described her background.*
*I still support the government.*
*He had always liked Mr Phillips.*
*Japan has a population of about a hundred million.*

Some transitive verbs have a restricted range of objects, because of their meaning.
E.g., the object of the verb *kill* must be something that is alive.
The object of the verb *waste* must be something you ca use, e.g. time, money, or food.

**Example 3.1.26.** *They killed huge elephants with tiny poisoned darts.*
*Why waste money on them?*

3.16 Here is a list of verbs that are transitive:

**Example 3.1.27.** *achieve, address, admire, affect, afford, avoid, bear, believe, blame, build, buy, calm, carry, catch, claim, commit, complete, concern, consider, control, convince, correct, cover, create, cut, damage, defy, demand, describe, design, desire, destroy, discover, discuss, display, do, dread, enjoy, equal, exchange, expect, experience, express, favor, fear, fill, find, free, get, give, grant, guard, handle, hate, have, hear, heat, hire, hit, include, influence, introduce, issue, justify, keep, kill, know, lack, like, list, love, lower, maintain, make, mean, mention, name, need, own, plant, please, prefer, prevent, process, produce, pronounce, protect, provide, raise, reach, receive, recommend, record, release, remember, remove, rent, report, respect, reveal, risk, see, seek, sell, shock, specify, spot, support, take, tease, test, threaten, trust, upset, use, value, want, waste, wear, welcome*

Note that *do* and *have* are also very often used as **auxiliaries**.
See the Reference section for this us.
*Have got* and *has got* are often used instead of the present tense of *have* when talking about possession.
The forms of *have* like auxiliaries when used like this before *got*.

**Example 3.1.28.** *I've got an umbrella.*
*She's got a degree.*

*Measure* and *weigh* are sometimes considered to be transitive verbs when used to state measurements and weights.
This use is explained in paragraph **2.252**.
*Cost* is used to state the cost of something, as in *An adult ticket costs 90p.*
3.17 When you are talking about something that affects a person rather than a thing, it is normal in English to say who that person is.
Therefore, verbs e.g. *anger, thank*, and *warn*, which involve affecting people, usually have a human object.

**Example 3.1.29.** *I tried to comfort her.*
*Her sudden death had surprised everybody.*
*Blue suits you.*
*Money did not interest him very much.*
*Lebel briefed Caron on the events of th afternoon.*

3.18 Here is a list of verbs that usually have a human object:

**Example 3.1.30.** *anger, brief, comfort, contact, frighten, interest, suit, surprise, tease, thank, trouble, warn*

3.19 With some transitive verbs, you have to give additional information about what is going on by using an adverb or prepositional phrase after the object.
Some verbs typically have a prepositional phrase beginning with a particular preposition after their object.

**Example 3.1.31.** *The judge based his decision on constitutional rights.*
*He had subjected me to the pressure of financial ruin.*
*My parents still view me as a little boy.*

Here is a list of verbs that always or usually have a particular preposition after their object:

**Example 3.1.32.** *regard as, view as*
*mistake for, swap for*
*dissociate from, prevent from*
*deprive of, remind of, rid of, rob of*
*accustom to, ascribe to, attribute to, compare to, condemn to, confine to, consign to, dedicate to, entitle to, liken to, owe to, return to, subject to, subordinate to*
*acquaint with, associate with, confront with, engrave with, pelt with, ply with, trust with*

With the following verbs, there is a choice of preposition:

**Example 3.1.33.** *divide by/into*
*incorporate in/into*
*based on/upon, lavish on/upon*
*entrust to/with, equate to/with, present to/with, supply to/with*

3.20 Other verbs are typically followed by an adverb or prepositional phrase, but not one containing a particular preposition.
The adverb or phrase often relates to place.

**Example 3.1.34.** *He placed the baby on the woman's lap.*
*I positioned my chair outside the room.*
*He never puts anything away.*
*He treated his laborers with kindness.*

Here is a list of verbs that usually have some kind of adverb or prepositional phrase after their object:

**Example 3.1.35.** *bring, chuck, convey, cram, direct, drag, escort, fling, hoist, job, jot, jay, lead, place, point, position, prop, put, rip, send, set, shove, smear, stick, store, throw, thrust, tie, treat*

For more on adverbs and phrases that follow verbs, see Chap. 6.

3.21 Note that some verbs of movement and position are transitive, not intransitive; they are followed by nouns referring to places rather than by adverbs or prepositional phrases.
This is because the verbs themselves show that you are talking about movement or position of a particular kind.
E.g., *enter* implies movement *into* a place and *occupy* implies position *in* a place.

**Example 3.1.36.** *He approached the house nervously.*
*It was dark by the time they reached their house.*
*A small ornamental pool occupied the center of the room.*
*Everyone had left the room.*

Here is a list of transitive verbs of movement:

**Example 3.1.37.** *approach, enter, leave, near, reach, round*

Here is a list of transitive verbs of position:

**Example 3.1.38.** *cover, crowd, fill, inhabit, occupy, throng*

Some verbs of movement can be followed either by a noun phrase or by a prepositional phrase.
See paragraph **3.58**.

3.22 [i] Note that even verbs that are almost always followed by an object can occasionally be used without an object.
This is possible in very restricted contexts.
E.g., if you are contrasting 2 actions, it is not necessary to say what else is involved.

**Example 3.1.39.** *Money markets are the places where people with money buy and sell.*
*Some people build while others destroy.*
*We gave, they took.*

If you use a list of different verbs for emphasis, you do not need to name the object.

**Example 3.1.40.** *They set out to be rude; to defy, threaten, or tease.*

If you repeat a verb in order to contrast it with a similar action, or to emphasize it, the object can be omitted.

**Example 3.1.41.** *She had ceased to love as she had once loved.*

3.23 Verbs that describe feelings and attitudes are sometimes used without an object, particularly in the ***to*-infinitive** form.
This is because the object is assumed to be people in general.
E.g., *please* usually requires an object, but you can say *He likes to please*, meaning he likes to please people.

**Example 3.1.42.** *He likes to shock.*
*She was anxious to please.*
*He must be convinced if he is to convince.*
*I have a tendency to tease.*

3.24 There is a large group of verbs, e.g. *say, suggest*, and *think*, which are used to report what people say or think.
They are called **reporting verbs**.
They are followed by a *that*-clause which is called the **reported clause**.

**Example 3.1.43.** *She said that she would come.*

The reported clause is often thought of as being an object, and so these verbs are usually said to be transitive verbs.

In this book, reporting verbs are explained in Chap. 7.

Reporting verbs e.g. *advise* and *persuade*, which have an object that refers to the person being addressed, are explained in paragraphs **7.75–7.76**.

Some reporting verbs can take as their object a noun e.g. *question* or *story* that refers to something that is said or written.

These verbs are listed in paragraph **7.82**.

Some take an object that refers to an event or fact, and is therefore closely related to a *that*-clause.

These are listed in paragraph **7.83**.

Verbs e.g. *believe* and *know* that can be used as reporting verbs, but that are ordinary transitive verbs when used with another common meaning, are included in the lists of transitive verbs given above.

3.25 Most transitive verbs can be used in the passive.

See paragraphs **9.9–9.21**.

### 3.1.3 Reflexive verbs: verbs where the object refers back to the subject

3.26 If you want to talk about a situation where the same person is involved as both the subject and the object of an action, you use a **reflexive pronoun** as the object of a clause.

E.g., it is common to blame someone else if something goes wrong, but you say *I blame myself for what happened* if you think that the mistake was your own fault.

Although a few verbs are typically used with reflexive pronouns, you can actually use a reflexive pronoun as the object of any transitive verb, when the meaning allows you to do so.

**Example 3.1.44.** *I blame myself for not paying attention.*
*She freed herself from my embrace.*
*After the meeting, he introduced himself to me.*
*Why not buy a book and teach yourself?*
*Don't deceive yourself.*
*We must ask ourselves several questions.*
*Every country has the right to defend itself.*

**Reflexive pronouns** are explained in paragraphs **1.111–1.118**.

3.27 Note that the verbs *busy, content*, and *pride* are true reflexive verbs: they must be used with a reflexive pronoun.

**Example 3.1.45.** *He had busied himself in the laboratory.*
*Many scholars contented themselves with writing textbooks.*
*He prides himself on his tidiness.*

3.28 Another small group of verbs only take an object that refers to a person when the object is a reflexive pronoun.

E.g., you can *express an opinion* and you can *express yourself* (meaning that you can put ideas into words), but you cannot *express a person.*

**Example 3.1.46.** *Prof. Baxendale expressed himself very forcibly.*
*She enjoyed herself enormously.*
*He applied himself to learning how Parliament worked.*

Here is a list of verbs that take a reflexive pronoun as their object when you refer to a person:

**Example 3.1.47.** *apply, compose, distance, enjoy, excel, exert, express, strain*

3.29 Some verbs that normally do not have objects, because they involve only the performer of the action, can have a reflexive pronoun as their object if you want to emphasize that the subject is doing something that affects himself or herself.

You can therefore say *Bill washed himself* rather than *Bill washed.*

**Example 3.1.48.** *I always wash 5 times a day.*
*Children were encouraged to wash themselves.*
*I stood in the kitchen while he shaved.*
*He prefers to shave himself before breakfast.*
*Ashton had behaved abominably.*
*He is old enough to behave himself.*
*Successful companies know how to adapt to change.*
*You've got to be willing to adapt yourself.*

Here is a list of verbs that have sense in which you can use a reflexive pronoun for emphasis:

**Example 3.1.49.** *acclimatize, adapt, behave, commit, dress, hide, move, readjust, shave, undress, wash*

3.30 [i] Note that reflexive pronouns are not used as much in English as in some other languages when talking about actions that you do to yourself.

As mentioned above, you would usually say *I washed* rather than *I washed myself* in English.

Sometimes a noun with a possessive is used instead.

E.g., you would say *I combed my hair* rather than *I combed myself.*

3.31 Note that reflexive verbs are not used in the passive.

### 3.1.4 Delexical verbs: verbs with little meaning

## 3.2 Verbs that can be used both with and without an object

## 3.3 Verbs that can take an object or a prepositional phrase

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